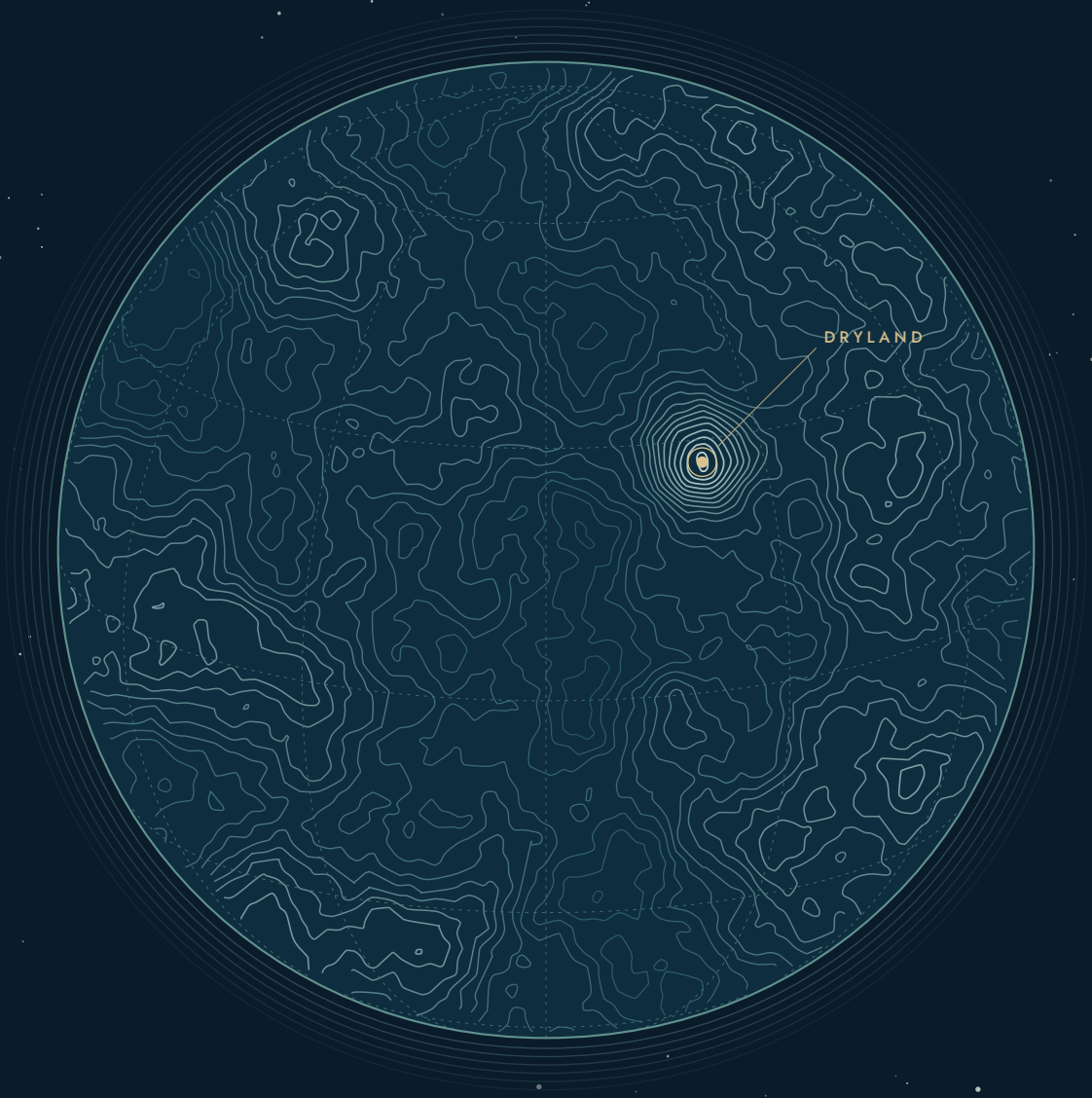
Dorsal Nomos



PANTHALASSA WITHOUT A PANGAEA

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The Panthalassic Condition, Elemental Political Theology, and the Inscription of Land in Kevin Reynolds's Waterworld (1995)

@ERTERTWERT

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Abstract

Consigned by its reception to the annals of industrial misadventure and dismissed as a derivative "Mad Max on water," *Waterworld* (dir. Kevin Reynolds; scr. Peter Rader and David Twohy; Universal Pictures, 1995) is here reconstructed as the most systematic cinematic articulation of what this dissertation terms the **panthalassic condition**: a cosmological, juridical, and somatic situation in which the disappearance of land abolishes the ground (*Grund*) upon which the Western tradition has founded property, law, memory, and personhood, compelling every surviving human order to relocate its foundation onto substitute surfaces. The film's premise is hydrologically impossible — the total melt of terrestrial ice would raise mean sea level by roughly seventy metres, not the kilometres required to drown the continents — and this impossibility is read not as a failure of extrapolation but as the index of the film's true register, which is diluvial myth rather than climatological forecast.

Situating the film within a comparative archive of flood and earth-diver cosmogonies (*Atrahasis*, Gilgamesh XI, Genesis 1 and 6–9, the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa's narrative of Manu and the fish, the Gun–Yu cycle of the *Shanhaijing*, the Aztec Legend of the Suns, the Haudenosaunee account of Sky Woman, and the Hawaiian *Kumulipo*), and reading it through an elemental hermeneutic assembled from pre-Socratic physics, Aristotle's doctrine of natural place, Dante's hydrography, Gaston Bachelard's material imagination, and Carl Schmitt's geo-jurisprudence of land and sea, the dissertation identifies four rival regimes of value, each corresponding to a classical element: the Atoll's compost commonwealth of dirt (earth); the Smokers' petro-theology of combustion, enshrined in the hagiography of "Saint Joe" Hazelwood aboard the hulk of the *Exxon Valdez* (fire); Gregor's aeronautical hermeneutics (air); and the Mariner's amphibious somatics (water). Each is a distinct answer to the problem Schmitt posed when he observed that the sea, unlike the earth, cannot be engraved.

The fifth term, Enola's tattooed back, yields the dissertation's governing concept, **dorsal nomos**: the inscription of territorial law upon a surface its bearer cannot read, whose genealogy runs from Turtle Island cosmogony and Polynesian

tatau through Deucalion's stones, Queequeg's coffin, and Kafka's harrow to the feminized cartographies of American pastoral. Against the Noahic covenant, which re-founds human dominion upon the mountain where the ark comes to rest, the film's final movement stages what is here called the COUNTER-ARARAT: the Mariner's refusal of the land he has delivered. Read through Sándor Ferenczi's *Thalassa*, Otto Neurath's boat, Kant's "land of truth," Dante's Ulysses, and the Western's iconography of the threshold, this refusal is reconstructed as a THALASSAL ETHICS of non-appropriation. A concluding chapter tests the film's mythic foresight against the emerging jurisprudence of deterritorialized statehood in the Pacific, arguing that *Waterworld* posed, three decades early and in the idiom of the summer spectacle, the question now confronting international law: whether a polity can survive the loss of the ground upon which — from Westphalia to the Montevideo Convention's requirement of "a defined territory" — the very concept of statehood has rested.

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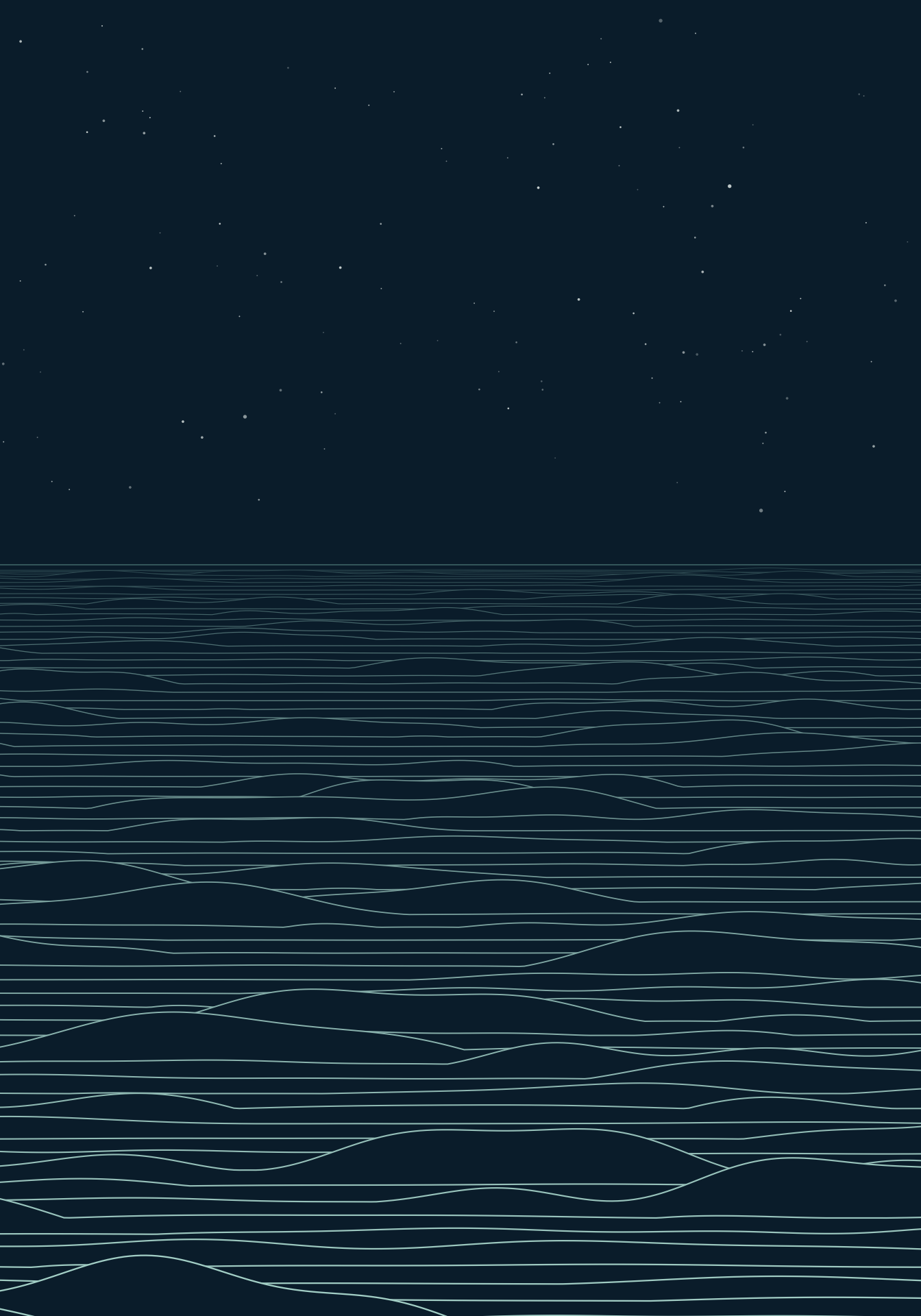
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I

A SEA WITHOUT CHARACTER

The Panthalassic Condition and the Problem of Inscription

I

And God said, Let the waters under the heaven be gathered together unto one place, and let the dry land appear: and it was so. And God called the dry land Earth.

— Genesis 1:9–10 (Authorized Version, 1611)

Sea water is at once the purest and the foulest of waters: for fish, drinkable and life-preserving; for human beings, undrinkable and lethal.

— Heraclitus, DK 22 B61 (trans. mine)

Water, water, every where, / Nor any drop to drink.

— Samuel Taylor Coleridge, *The Rime of the Ancient Mariner* (text of 1834)

1.1

Shipwreck with Spectators

Few films have been so thoroughly pre-interpreted by the circumstances of their making. Before it opened on 28 July 1995, *Waterworld* had already been narrated — in the trade press, in the monologues of late-night television, and in a punning taxonomy of industrial disaster ("Fishtar," "Kevin's Gate") that shelved it beside *Ishtar* (1987) and *Heaven's Gate* (1980) as a parable of auteurist hubris and studio indiscipline. The facts that adhered to the project composed a second text superimposed upon the first: an initial authorization of $100 million that swelled to an estimated $175 million, then the largest sum ever committed to a single production; a schedule extended from 96 shooting days to more than 150 inside an artificial seawater enclosure off the west coast of Hawai'i Island; a floating set lost to heavy seas; a director who quit before release after sustained conflict with his star and producer; a score rejected, on Costner's reported verdict, as "too ethnic and bleak" and recommissioned from James Newton Howard; and last-minute rewrites by an uncredited Joss Whedon (production record). In aggregate these facts produced a meta-narrative of waste in which a fable of scarcity, rationing, and the recycling of every molecule was ironized by its own conspicuous expenditure. That the film was the ninth-highest-grossing release of its year, that it earned roughly two-thirds of its $264 million worldwide gross outside North America, that it became profitable through home video and broadcast sales, and that it has enjoyed an unbroken afterlife as a live stunt spectacle in four Universal parks on both shores of the Pacific — none of this has dislodged the frame established in the summer of its release. Reynolds would later remark that, by the end, audiences had wanted the picture to be a disaster.

The present study proceeds from the conviction that this reception frame is itself a philosophical figure, and that it must be interpreted before it can be set aside. Hans Blumenberg's *Shipwreck with Spectator* (1979) reconstructs the long career of a metaphor inaugurated by the proem to the second book of Lucretius's *De rerum natura*: *Suave, mari magno turbantibus aequora ventis, / e terra magnum alterius spectare laborem* — it is sweet, when the winds churn the waters of the great sea, to watch from land the great toil of another. Lucretius is careful to specify that the pleasure derives not from another's suffering as such but from the recognition of one's own exemption from it; the shore is the locus of an existential privilege, the vantage of the sage who surveys the tumult of the world from the

serene temples of philosophy. Blumenberg's thesis is that modernity progressively dissolves that vantage. From Pascal's *vous êtes embarqué* to Otto Neurath's sailors, condemned to rebuild their ship on the open sea without ever bringing it into dry dock, the history of the metaphor is the history of the shore's disappearance: the spectator discovers that he, too, is at sea, and that there is no ground from which the catastrophe can be watched without being shared.

The reception of *Waterworld* reproduced the Lucretian configuration with uncanny literalism. The film's shipwreck — its financial and logistical distress upon an actual ocean — was consumed as spectacle by an industry and a press positioned on terra firma, deriving from another's labor the *suave* satisfaction of exemption. Yet the object so consumed was a fable about the abolition of terra firma. It posed, in the idiom of the summer blockbuster, precisely the question that Blumenberg's genealogy poses in the idiom of the history of ideas: what becomes of a civilization, an epistemology, a law, when there is no longer any shore from which to watch? To read *Waterworld* from the shore is to commit a performative contradiction — to exempt oneself, in the act of judgment, from the condition the film represents. The present study resolves to embark.

A second inherited frame requires equal scrutiny: the designation "Mad Max on water," a phrase that has served at once as pitch, as dismissal, and — though rarely acknowledged as such — as genealogy. The dismissive use presumes that derivation precludes significance, a presumption that would disqualify most of the Western canon, from Virgil's rewriting of Homer to Joyce's rewriting of both. The genealogical use is more exact than its users have known. Peter Rader conceived the project in conversation with the producer Brad Krevoy as a *Mad Max* derivative, drafted it in 1986, and shelved it until 1989; David Twohy, who rewrote it, named *Mad Max 2* (1981) as a principal model; both films were photographed by Dean Semler; and a further precursor is widely discerned in *Freakwave* (1983–85), Peter Milligan and Brendan McCarthy's "Mad Max goes surfing" comic, whose co-creator would go on to co-write *Mad Max: Fury Road* (2015) (production record). *Waterworld* therefore occupies a node in a lineage that passes, quite literally, through the same hands, and its relation to George Miller's cycle is better described as filiation than as plagiarism.

What the filiation transmits is a theory of resource-sovereignty. *Mad Max 2*, released in the wake of the second oil shock, organizes its world around the possession of a single combustible fluid: the besieged refinery compound, the marauding horde, the laconic drifter whose competence is the residue of a vanished order, the feral child who will narrate the hero's passage into legend. *Mad Max Beyond*

Thunderdome (1985) extends the theory into a political economy: Bartertown runs on methane harvested from pig excrement in its subterranean Underworld, and its lost tribe of children preserves, in a ritual recitation called "the Tell," the eschatological memory of a city it has never seen. *Waterworld* inherits this apparatus and subjects it to an elemental transposition. Where Miller's wasteland is xeric — a world of dust, distance, and evaporated law — Reynolds's is hydric; where Miller's economy turns on a fluid that is burned, *Waterworld*'s turns on a fluid that is everywhere and yet unusable, a world in which the dominant element and the scarcest resource are chemically identical and differ only by salinity. The transposition is not cosmetic. It converts the post-apocalypse from a narrative of exhaustion into a narrative of excess, and in doing so exposes what the xeric version conceals: that scarcity is never a quantity of matter but a relation between matter and a body. The sea is poverty only for those who cannot drink it.

Heraclitus formulated this relation two and a half millennia ago, in the fragment that supplies this chapter's second epigraph. B61 is customarily cited as an instance of Heraclitean perspectivism, the unity of opposites in a single substance relative to diverse users. *Waterworld* restages it as anthropology. Its protagonist is the one being for whom the fragment's antithesis has begun to collapse: a man who breathes through gills behind his ears, whose webbed feet propel him through the element that kills his neighbors, and whose hostility toward those neighbors is the obverse of their terror of him. One of the film's first images — the Mariner urinating into a hand-pumped filtration apparatus and drinking the purified product — is the visual thesis of the entire work: where water is everywhere and potable water nowhere, the body becomes the last closed circuit, the final refinery, the only reliable well. Coleridge's Mariner, becalmed upon a painted ocean, had registered the same paradox in the most quoted couplet of English Romanticism, and it is not incidental that Rader and Twohy's protagonist bears no name but the Coleridgean epithet. That the image provoked derision rather than reflection measures how completely the reception frame foreclosed interpretation; it is also, as Chapter Five argues, the inaugural gesture of a somatic economy the film develops with considerable rigor.

The reception frame performs three operations that this dissertation sets out to reverse. It treats expenditure as the film's subject rather than its context; it treats derivation as disqualification rather than as genealogy; and it treats impossibility — a hydrology that drowns every summit but one, gills that let a man breathe the sea — as error rather than as a signal of register. Each reversal opens a field of inquiry. The first returns the film's economic imagination to the center of analysis.

The second situates it within a transmedial lineage of post-apocalyptic, diluvial, and maritime fictions. The third, which governs the remainder of this chapter, reclassifies the film's premise from failed forecast to successful myth.

1.2

Archipelagic Authorship

Questions of authorship in *Waterworld* cannot be settled by the conventions of auteurism, which presuppose what may be called a continental model of the creative subject: a single landmass of intention whose coastline is the work. The film's history is better described as archipelagic — a chain of discrete intentional islands, linked and divided by the sea of industrial production, each depositing a sedimentary layer in the finished text. The originating island is Rader's 1986 screenplay. The second is Twohy's rewrite. The third is the directorial sensibility of Kevin Reynolds, chosen by Costner over Universal's preferred candidates, Robert Zemeckis and Lawrence Kasdan, on the strength of a friendship and a shared filmography that already included *Fandango* (1985), *Robin Hood: Prince of Thieves* (1991), and *Rapa Nui* (1994). The fourth is Costner's star persona and producing authority, which extended, by most accounts, to supervising the film's completion after Reynolds quit the production over their disputes — though Reynolds retained sole directorial credit, and the two would reunite two decades later for *Hatfields & McCoys* (2012), a miniseries, aptly enough, about a feud. The fifth island is submerged: Whedon, flown to the set for last-minute revisions, later characterized the assignment as weeks of misery whose substance was the transcription of Costner's ideas without alteration (production record). To these must be added the archipelago's ocean itself. Steven Spielberg, chastened by *Jaws* (1975), reportedly warned the filmmakers against shooting on open water; the Pacific's weather repeatedly rewrote the schedule; and Costner nearly drowned when a squall caught him lashed to the trimaran's mast. The sea was, in the most literal sense, a collaborator — and an antagonist with a temporality of its own.

Each island has a recognizable geology. Rader's, by his own account, braided three sources: Miller's cycle, "various Old Testament stories," and the matter of Troy, the heroine being named for Helen in deliberate allusion. The Trojan coding is not confined to her. Among the Atoll's inhabitants is a man named Priam, played by Zakes Mokae, and the extended version of the film concludes with Helen

bestowing upon the nameless Mariner the name Ulysses. The film's mythic substrate is therefore not a critical projection but an authorial deposit, and it has two strata: the first Hebraic and diluvial, the second Homeric and maritime. The Atoll is Troy — a walled city besieged from the sea, one of whose inhabitants bears Priam's name and from whose fall a woman named Helen escapes. The Mariner is Odysseus, the man of many turns who tells the Cyclops that his name is *Outis*, No-one. Chapter Six will argue that the film's ending rewrites not Homer's Odysseus, who returns home, but Dante's, who refuses to.

Twohy's island is defined by a preoccupation that his subsequent filmography makes unmistakable: the habitability of a hostile element. *The Arrival* (1996), which he wrote and directed in the year after *Waterworld*, imagines an extraterrestrial conspiracy to accelerate the greenhouse effect in order to terraform the Earth for a species adapted to heat — a premise that converts anthropogenic warming from an unintended externality into a deliberate project, and thereby renders legible, in the form of paranoia, the agency that climate science attributes to industrial civilization as a whole. *Pitch Black* (2000) relocates survival to a planet of perpetual daylight whose predators emerge only during a generational eclipse, so that habitability becomes a function of an astronomical periodicity no individual can master. *Below* (2002), on whose screenplay Darren Aronofsky shared credit, returns to the sea, sealing a wartime submarine crew inside a hull haunted by a concealed crime; Aronofsky would later direct his own diluvial epic, *Noah* (2014). Across this oeuvre the environment is never setting but adversary, and the human question is always whether a body, a vessel, or a polity can be engineered to endure it. *Waterworld* is the first and most ambitious statement of the problematic.

Reynolds's island exhibits a comparable consistency, organized around what may be called a thalassic Christology: a recurrent figuration of the sea as the medium of death and resurrection. In *Rapa Nui*, shot on Easter Island in the year preceding *Waterworld*, the climactic ordeal is the *tangata manu* competition, in which contestants swim the shark-haunted strait to the islet of Motu Nui, retrieve the first egg of the sooty tern, and return with it intact; an insular political order already collapsing under deforestation and the competitive erection of *moai* is staked upon a sea-crossing. In *The Count of Monte Cristo* (2002), Edmond Dantès escapes the island fortress of the Château d'If by taking the place of a corpse in its shroud and being cast into the sea, from which he emerges reborn. In *Tristan & Isolde* (2006), the poisoned Tristan is laid in a funeral boat and drifts, presumed dead, to the Irish shore where Isolde revives him. *Risen* (2016) renders the pattern explicit by subjecting the Resurrection itself to a Roman tribune's forensic

inquiry. *Waterworld* stands at the center of this arc. Its protagonist is sentenced to death by drowning in the Atoll's tank of organic sludge, survives by breathing the medium meant to kill him, and is repeatedly submerged and returned; in the film's most intimate sequence he keeps Helen alive beneath the surface by breathing into her mouth — an insufflation that recapitulates, in the register of survival, the animation of Adam in Genesis 2:7, when the breath of life is blown into a body of clay.

Rapa Nui and *Waterworld* are best read as a diptych whose logic is that of the microcosm. Paul Bahn and John Flenley's *Easter Island, Earth Island* (1992) had made the island's deforestation a parable of planetary overshoot. The parable — later popularized by Jared Diamond's *Collapse* (2005), and contested by Terry Hunt and Carl Lipo, who attribute much of the island's ecological transformation to introduced rats and its demographic catastrophe to European contact — supplied early-1990s environmentalism with its governing analogy: the planet as island, bounded and finite, liable to a collapse authored by its own inhabitants. *Rapa Nui* dramatizes the island as planet; *Waterworld* inverts the analogy and dramatizes the planet as island-less. The first film ends with the collapse of an insular order; the second begins after the collapse of the insular condition as such. Between them lies the passage from a parable in which humanity exhausts a finite ground to a parable in which the ground itself has been withdrawn.

Costner's island is the most visible and the least understood. His star persona after *Dances with Wolves* (1990) — the white frontiersman who passes, by elective affinity, into the people the frontier was designed to destroy — furnished the Mariner with an intertextual biography: the man who has crossed over, who belongs to neither side of a border, whose competence is a form of estrangement. *The Postman* (1997), which Costner directed two years later from David Brin's novel, is in this respect *Waterworld*'s terrestrial twin: another post-apocalyptic drifter, another nameless competence, and another plot in which the reconstitution of political order depends upon a technology of inscription — there, the circulation of letters by a counterfeit postal service; here, a cartography tattooed upon a child. Both films answer the question of how a shattered polity might be refounded with the same unexpected answer: by writing. That Costner's later career turns from the Mariner, who refuses land, to the ranching patriarch of *Yellowstone* (2018–), who defends it by any means, and to the settler epic of *Horizon: An American Saga* (2024), suggests that the question of land has organized his persona from the outset, and that *Waterworld* is the pole of refusal from which the later work swings back.

The archipelagic model carries an interpretive corollary. If no single intention governs the film, its coherence — which this dissertation argues is considerable — must be sought not in the will of an author but in the logic of its materials: in the manner in which water, earth, fire, air, and skin organize the diegetic world irrespective of anyone's design. The method adopted here is accordingly elemental rather than auteurist. It asks not what the filmmakers meant but what the elements mean when a culture of land is compelled to imagine their redistribution.

1.3

The Diluvial Archive and the Hydrological Impossibility

Waterworld opens, before its first diegetic image, by drowning its own studio. The Universal Pictures trademark — a terrestrial globe turning in the void, girdled by the corporate name — undergoes an accelerated catastrophe: the polar caps dissolve, the oceans swell, the continents vanish beneath a uniform blue. The gesture is more than a novelty. In "The Age of the World Picture" (1938), Heidegger identified the defining event of modernity as the conquest of the world as picture: the representation of the totality of beings as an object set before, and placed at the disposal of, a representing subject. The rotating globe of the studio trademark is that world picture in its most commodified form — the planet as brand, the Earth reduced to the emblem of an entertainment conglomerate. To drown it is to announce that the film's subject is not a catastrophe within the world but the catastrophe of the world picture as such: the dissolution of the cartographic totality within which modern subjects have located themselves and from which they have derived their sense of possession. The narration that follows, informing the viewer that the ice caps have melted and that humanity has adapted to a new world, functions less as exposition than as epitaph.

The catastrophe so announced is, by any physical measure, impossible. Were every glacier and ice sheet on Earth to melt, mean sea level would rise by something on the order of seventy metres — enough to drown coastal megacities, erase low island nations, and redraw every map, but nothing approaching a scenario in which the only surviving land is a single summit, identified in the extended version as Mount Everest, some 8,850 metres above the present shoreline. Indeed, the entire volume of the hydrosphere, spread uniformly over a smoothed planetary

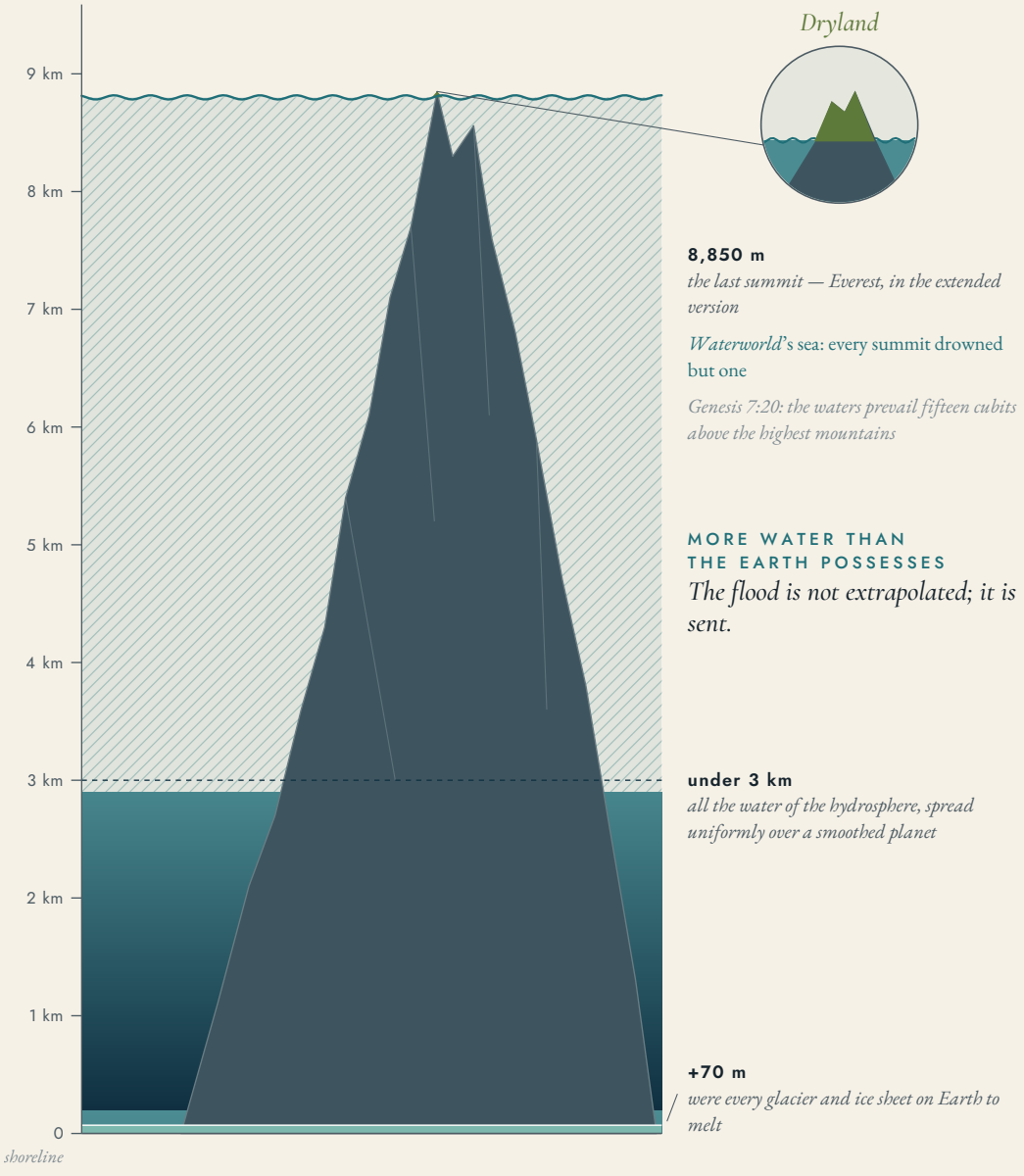
surface, would yield an ocean somewhat under three kilometres deep; the film's flood requires more water than the Earth possesses. It has been customary to treat this as a scientific blunder and a further confirmation of the film's vulgarity. This dissertation treats it as a generic signal, an index of register. The flood of *Waterworld* is not extrapolated; it is sent. Its volume exceeds the hydrological budget of the planet for the same reason that the waters of Genesis 7:20 prevail fifteen cubits above the highest mountains: because the flood is a theological rather than a physical event, a total judgment upon the order of the land. *Waterworld* is a diluvial myth wearing the costume of a climate fiction, and its meanings are to be sought in the archive of the former at least as much as in the anxieties of the latter. The film was released in the year the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change's Second Assessment concluded that the balance of evidence suggested a discernible human influence on global climate; its imaginative sources lie some five millennia deeper.

That archive is among the oldest and most widely distributed bodies of narrative in human culture, and it supplies not one grammar but two. The first is the grammar of judgment and survival: a divinity or cosmic law, offended by human excess, unmakes the habitable world by water, preserves a remnant, and refounds order upon a mountain. The second is the grammar of the primordial waters: before the world there is only the deep, and the habitable is brought forth by separation, by diving, or by the slow genealogical emergence of life from the sea. *Waterworld* superimposes them. Its world is post-diluvial and pre-cosmogonic at once — the judgment has fallen, but the separation of the waters has not been repeated.

The Mesopotamian strata supply the template of the first grammar and, with it, an unexpected political economy. In the Old Babylonian *Atrahasis*, the gods, having created humanity to bear the labor of the lesser deities, are kept from sleep by the clamor of a multiplying people; Enlil responds with plague, drought, and famine before resolving upon the flood, from which Enki saves Atrahasis by addressing his warning to the reed wall of a hut. When the waters recede, the gods institute permanent checks on human fertility: women who do not bear, a demon who snatches infants from the lap, orders of priestesses forbidden to conceive. The oldest surviving flood narrative is thus also the oldest literary theory of overpopulation, and its deluge is a Malthusian instrument *avant la lettre* — the catastrophic correction of a demographic surplus by a regime that subsequently institutionalizes the correction as law. Chapter Two returns to this structure in examining the Atoll, a polity whose closed population, rationed water, and executions-by-compost administer scarcity as a permanent condition.

FIGURE 1

A Flood That Exceeds the Planet



The flood of *Waterworld* set against the planet's water (§1.3). The total melt of terrestrial ice would raise the sea by some seventy metres; the whole hydrosphere, spread over a smoothed Earth, would make an ocean somewhat under three kilometres deep. The film's sea stands just below a summit of about 8,850 metres. Vertical scale linear.

Tablet XI of the Standard Babylonian *Gilgamesh* transmits the flood through the first-person testimony of Utnapishtim, who builds his vessel at Ea's instruction, rides out the storm, and grounds upon Mount Nimush, whence he releases in succession a dove, a swallow, and a raven; the first two return, finding nowhere to perch, and the raven, finding the waters abated, does not. The narrative's coda is more pertinent still. Denied the immortality granted to Utnapishtim, Gilgamesh learns of a plant of renewed youth growing at the bottom of the Apsû, binds stones to his feet, sinks to the floor of the abyss, and plucks it; a serpent steals it while he bathes, sloughing its skin as it departs. The hero who descends to the floor of the waters to retrieve the substance of life is the archetype of the Mariner, who descends in a jury-rigged diving bell to the drowned streets of Denver to harvest the soil that is the Atoll's highest currency — and who, like Gilgamesh, discovers that what he brings to the surface cannot purchase the permanence of the order that covets it. Helen's response to the drowned city, in which her faith in a surviving Dryland is momentarily crushed, is Gilgamesh's response at the pool: the treasure retrieved from the deep is proof not of a future but of a loss.

The Hebrew narrative of Genesis 6–9, woven from Priestly and non-Priestly strands, retains the Mesopotamian sequence — the warning, the vessel, the birds, the mountain, the sacrifice — while transforming its theology: the flood becomes a moral judgment upon an earth filled with violence, and its aftermath is not a demographic check but a covenant. The decisive text is Genesis 9:1–3, in which the blessing of fruitfulness is renewed and intensified: "And the fear of you and the dread of you shall be upon every beast of the earth, and upon every fowl of the air, upon all that moveth upon the earth, and upon all the fishes of the sea; into your hand are they delivered." The Noahic covenant re-founds, upon the mountain where the ark comes to rest, the dominion first granted in Genesis 1:28, adding to it the sanction of terror and the license of carnivory. Ararat is the place where land and law are rejoined after the interregnum of the waters — the original *nomos* of the post-diluvial world. Chapter Six argues that the ending of *Waterworld* conspicuously declines this re-founding. But the film's vocabulary reaches further back than Noah. Its name for the promised land is drawn, whether by design or by the sedimentation of idiom, from the Authorized Version's account of the third day of creation quoted as this chapter's first epigraph: *let the dry land appear*. Dryland is not a place but a cosmogonic event, the first separation of the habitable from the waters, the act by which the formless deep of Genesis 1:2 becomes a world. A civilization that seeks Dryland is a civilization that has fallen back behind the third day, into the condition in which the spirit moves upon the face of the

waters and nothing yet bears a name — which is, precisely, the condition of the film's nameless protagonist.

The Greco-Roman tradition, consolidated in the first book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, adds a detail whose significance for the present argument can scarcely be overstated. Jupiter floods the world in punishment for Lycaon's impiety; Deucalion and Pyrrha, the pious remnant, ground upon Parnassus and, desolate in an emptied world, consult the oracle of Themis, who commands them to veil their heads, loosen their garments, and cast behind their backs the bones of their great mother: *ossaque post tergum magnae iactate parentis* (1.383). Deucalion construes the bones as the stones of the Earth, and the stones, cast over the shoulder, soften into human bodies — men from his throw, women from hers. The repopulation of the world is a dorsal act, performed without looking: the future of humanity is generated behind the back, in the one direction the actor cannot see. Enola, whose back bears the only record of the land and who can never read it, inherits this Ovidian structure; the theory of dorsal nomos developed in Chapter Four begins here.

Plato supplies the archive with its epistemology. In the *Timaeus* (22b–23b), the aged priest of Saïs rebukes Solon — "O Solon, Solon, you Hellenes are never anything but children, and there is not an old man among you" (trans. Jowett) — and explains that the Greeks are perpetually young because recurrent destructions by fire and water have repeatedly annihilated their lettered classes, leaving survivors who must reinvent the arts without knowing that they are reinventing them. Book III of the *Laws* (677a–b) specifies who survives such a deluge: hill-shepherds upon the mountaintops, "small sparks of the human race," unlettered and ignorant of the arts of the drowned cities below. The Platonic flood is an epistemological catastrophe before it is a physical one; it destroys memory along with masonry. The Atollers, who regard Dryland as a fable and handle the Mariner's soil as a commodity of unknown provenance, are Plato's children, a people without an old man among them. And the only humans in the film who retained a connection to the land are, exactly as in the *Laws*, the dwellers on the summit: Enola's parents, whose remains the travelers discover in a hut at the film's end.

The Indic tradition contributes the most precise structural homology of all. In its earliest extant version, preserved in the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa (1.8.1), a small fish comes into Manu's hands as he washes and begs protection, promising in return to save him from a flood that will carry away all creatures. Manu raises it through successive vessels until it is grown, builds a ship at its instruction, and, when the waters rise, binds the ship's rope to the fish's horn; the fish tows him over the

northern mountain, where he moors to a tree and descends as the waters withdraw — the slope thereafter called Manu's Descent. In the Purāṇic elaboration the fish is Matsya, the first *avatāra* of Viṣṇu. The savior of this tradition is not a patriarch but a fish: a being of the water who guides the last human vessel to a Himalayan summit. The homology with *Waterworld* is exact. A fish-man — the gilled Mariner — conducts the bearer of humanity's future, a child marked with the map of the land, across the drowned world to a summit the extended version identifies as Everest. At the level of its deep structure, *Waterworld* is less a Noahic than a Matsyan narrative. The same tradition knows a second aquatic avatar, Varāha, the boar who dives into the cosmic ocean and raises the Earth upon his tusks; Matsya guides, Varāha dives, and the Mariner, as the following chapters show, condenses both functions.

The Chinese flood cycle reorganizes the archive around engineering. In the *Shanhaijing* (*Classic of Mountains and Seas*), the floodwaters rise to the sky; Gun steals from the Supreme God the *xirang* — the "breathing" or self-swelling soil that grows of its own accord — to dam the waters without awaiting divine command, and is executed for the theft at Feather Mountain; from his body Yu is born, and the God at last commands Yu to spread the soil and settle the Nine Provinces. The most precious substance in the Chinese diluvial imaginary is therefore soil: earth that multiplies itself, stolen from heaven to wall out the deep. The later tradition preserved in the *Shujing* and the *Mencius* elaborates the contrast between father and son into a hydraulic philosophy. Gun failed because he obstructed the waters; Yu succeeded because he channeled them, guiding the flood along its own inclination toward the sea. The opposition maps onto *Waterworld* with startling fidelity. The Atoll — a palisade of scrap whose economy is organized around the hoarding of dirt — is Gun's dam. The Mariner, who survives not by resisting the water but by moving with it, enacts the method of Yu.

Mesoamerican cosmogony furnishes a reading of the film's antagonists so exact as to seem uncanny. In the *Legend of the Suns* preserved in the Codex Chimalpopoca (1558), the cosmos has passed through successive ages, each ended by catastrophe. The fourth sun, Nahui Atl, "4-Water," ended in a deluge in which the people of that age were transformed into fish. A single couple, Tata and Nene, survived in a hollowed cypress at Tezcatlipoca's instruction; when the waters receded, they caught a fish and drilled fire to roast it, and the smoke rose to the heavens, provoking the star-gods to demand who had smoked the sky. Tezcatlipoca descended and transformed the couple into dogs. The post-diluvial world of this cosmogony distributes its human fates between those who became fish and those

who were punished for making smoke. *Waterworld* distributes its anthropology in the same way: the Mariner is the man who has begun to become a fish; the Smokers are the survivors whose combustion fouls the heavens of a world that has already ended once.

The second grammar, that of the primordial waters, reaches its most widely distributed form in the earth-diver myth, which Anna Birgitta Rooth (1957) identified as among the principal creation types of North America and which extends across Siberia, Central Asia, and Eastern Europe. In the Haudenosaunee account, Sky Woman falls through a hole beneath the uprooted tree of the sky world toward an endless sea; waterbirds break her fall; the animals dive in turn for mud from the bottom, and the muskrat, in many tellings, surfaces dead with earth clutched in its paws; the mud is spread upon the back of the Great Turtle, which grows into the land called Turtle Island. Alan Dundes (1962) read the myth psychoanalytically as a male creation fantasy, the substitution of a cloacal for a parturitive birth — a world fashioned from mud by beings who cannot bear children. Whatever one makes of the reading, the myth furnishes *Waterworld* with two of its central images. The Mariner's descent to the drowned city to bring up soil is an earth-dive. Enola's back, upon which the land is inscribed, is the turtle's carapace in a cartographic register: in both cases the world is carried on a back. And Dundes's thesis acquires an unexpected pertinence in a film whose economy turns on the recycling of urine and the composting of the dead, and whose hero, initially murderous toward the child in his care, becomes by the end the guarantor of her delivery.

The Babylonian *Enūma Eliš* supplies the archive's most precise image of the film's economy. Its cosmogony begins with the commingling of two waters — Apsû, the sweet, and Tiamat, the salt — and the world comes into being when Marduk slays Tiamat and splits her body like a fish laid open for drying, making heaven of one half and earth of the other. The primal cosmogonic act is the separation of waters, and the first distinction is between sweet and salt. *Waterworld*'s economy rests on precisely this distinction: its most coveted good is fresh water — "hydro" in the Atoll's idiom — and its whole political life is organized along the boundary between Apsû and Tiamat. The Mariner's filtration apparatus, which separates the drinkable from the undrinkable within the circuit of his own body, performs a domestic Marduk's labor: a cosmogony in miniature, repeated daily, by which one man secures a world the size of his own thirst.

Finally, the waters in which the film was made possess their own cosmogony. The *Kumulipo*, the Hawaiian genealogical chant translated by Queen Lili'uokalani and published in 1897, after the overthrow of the Hawaiian Kingdom and during

the struggle against annexation, begins in the deep darkness of Pō, and the first being it brings forth is the coral polyp; there follow the creatures of the sea, then those of the land, then the gods and the genealogy of the chiefs. It is an evolutionary cosmogony, strikingly congruent with the Darwinian sequence, in which humanity descends from the sea through an unbroken lineage of marine and terrestrial kin. Against the Genesis of dominion, which sets humanity over the fishes of the sea, the *Kumulipo* offers a genesis of kinship in which the creatures of the sea are humanity's elder siblings. The Mariner, a man returning to the sea from which the chant derives him, is a *Kumulipo* hero misrecognized as a Noahic one. The production's geography sharpens the irony: the film's Dryland was shot in Waipiʻo Valley on Hawaiʻi Island, the "Valley of Kings" (production record), long associated with the residence of ruling chiefs and, in some traditions, with a passage to the underworld of Milu. The paradise at the end of the drowned world was filmed at the threshold of a Polynesian afterlife, in waters whose own account of creation the film carries without naming.

Read together, these traditions establish the coordinates within which the film's narrative moves. Mircea Eliade observed that, in the symbolism of the waters, immersion signifies regression into the undifferentiated and the dissolution of forms, while emersion repeats the cosmogonic act by which form first appeared; every flood is therefore a return to the beginning, and every landfall a new creation. The world of *Waterworld* is an immersion without emersion — a regressus that has become a habitat. Its inhabitants live inside the dissolution that, in every tradition surveyed here, is supposed to be temporary. The film's narrative question is accordingly not whether there is land, but who will perform the emersion, by what right, and with what consequence for the order that follows. Three candidates present themselves: the Smokers, who would refound the world as property; the Atoll, which would refound it as a closed economy of soil; and the Mariner, who, as the following chapters argue, delivers the land and declines to found anything upon it.

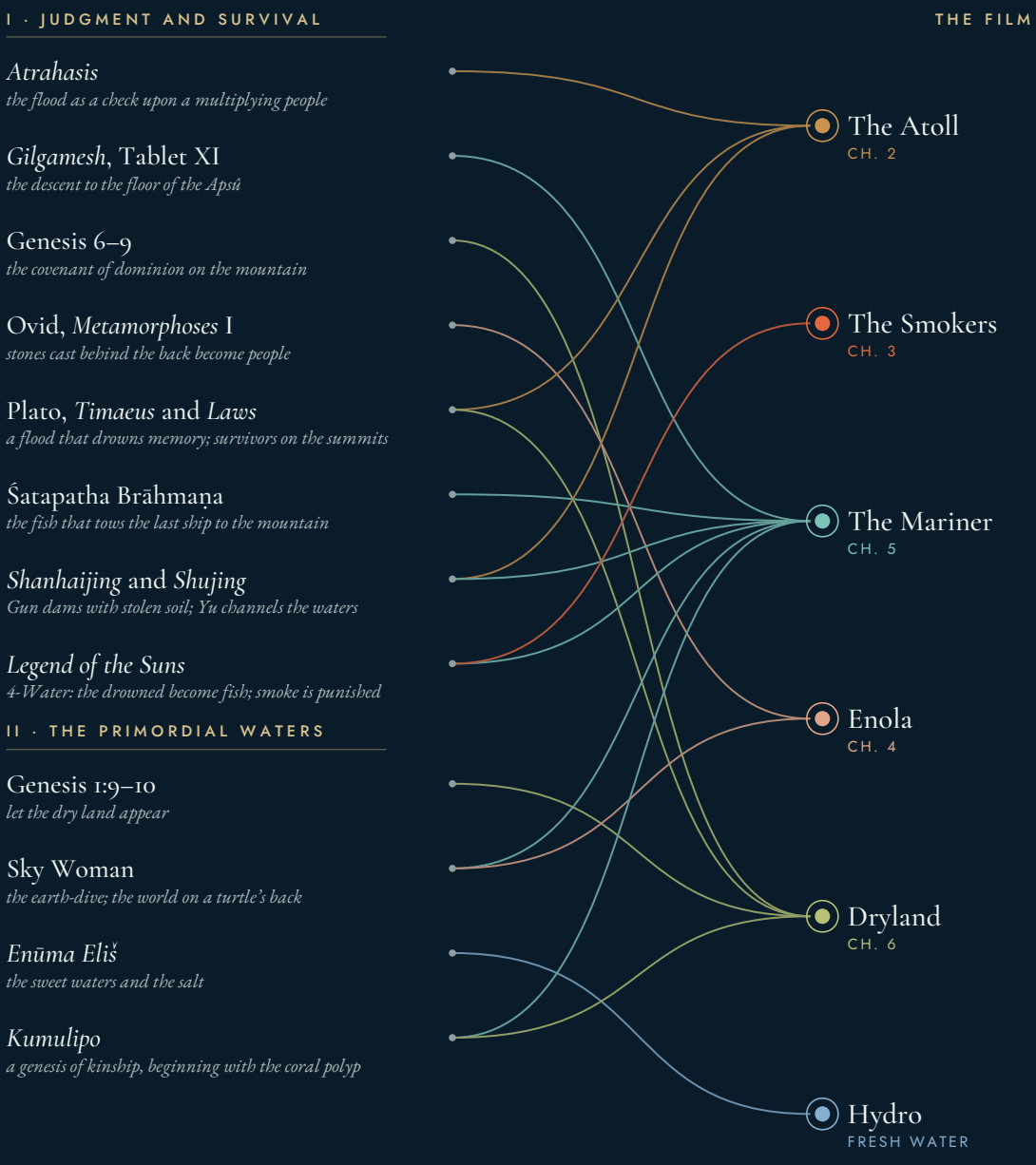
1.4

Toward an Elemental Hermeneutics

If the diluvial archive supplies the film's mythic grammar, its conceptual grammar is elemental, and its proper interlocutors are the first philosophers of the

FIGURE 2

Two Grammars of the Deep



The flood narratives of judgment and survival and the cosmogonies of the primordial waters (§1.3), each joined to the figure of the film whose role it anticipates.

West, whose inquiry into the *archē* — the principle from which all things come and into which they return — was in the first instance an inquiry into which element governs the world. The pre-Socratics did not merely nominate candidates for that office. They proposed models of how a cosmos might be organized around a dominant substance, and each model finds an echo in the film's architecture.

Thales of Miletus, on Aristotle's report (*Metaphysics* A.3, 983b20–27), held water to be the principle of all things, and further maintained that the earth rests upon water, floating, as the *De Caelo* (II.13, 294a28–34) puts it, like a log. The Thalesian cosmos is philosophy's first waterworld: a disc of land borne upon an encompassing sea. The Atoll — an artificial island of salvaged scrap, buoyant, palisaded, adrift — is that cosmos rebuilt by bricolage. Its inhabitants live upon an earth that floats, and their politics, as Chapter Two shows, are the politics of a ground that cannot be trusted to stay still.

Thales's successor Anaximander displaced the *archē* into the *apeiron*, the boundless, and offered the first speculation in the Western tradition on the descent of the human species from another kind of animal. Because the human infant requires prolonged nursing, he reasoned, humanity could not have survived had it appeared in its present form; the first humans must therefore have been nurtured within fish-like creatures and emerged only when able to fend for themselves (Censorinus, *De die natali* 4.7; ps.-Plutarch, *Stromateis* 2). Plutarch reports (*Quaestiones convivales* 8.8.4) that Anaximander accordingly regarded fish as humanity's common parents. The Mariner reverses this zoogony. He is the human who has begun to return into the fish from which, in the first evolutionary speculation of the West, humanity emerged — and the Atollers' horror at his gills is the horror of a child confronting the parent it has disowned.

Heraclitus supplies three fragments that together amount to a theory of the film's world. B61, quoted above, establishes the relativity of the sea to the bodies that use it. B36 establishes the cycle of transformation: "For souls it is death to become water; for water, death to become earth; but out of earth water comes to be, and out of water soul" (trans. mine). The Atoll's practice of "recycling" its dead and its condemned into the organic sludge from which it renews its fertility is the Heraclitean cycle administered by a municipal authority. And B90 establishes the cycle as an economy: "All things are an exchange for fire, and fire for all things, as goods for gold and gold for goods" (trans. mine). The Heraclitean cosmos is already monetary; the transformation of the elements is figured as trade, with fire as the universal equivalent. *Waterworld*'s three currencies — soil, fuel, and fresh water — are the Heraclitean elements monetized, and its political conflict is a

struggle over which element will serve as the measure of all the others. The Smokers' wager is B90 taken literally: that fire can still buy everything, including land.

Empedocles of Acragas systematized the elements as four "roots" (*rhizōmata*) — fire, air, earth, and water, under the divine names Zeus, Hera, Aidoneus, and Nestis (B6) — moved by two cosmic forces: Love (*Philotēs*), which mingles them, and Strife (*Neikos*), which sets them apart (B17). His zoogony imagined an epoch in which limbs and organs wandered and combined at random, producing man-faced ox-progeny and ox-headed man-progeny (B61), and Aristotle reports (*Physics* II.8, 198b29–32) that, on Empedocles' account, those combinations that happened to be suited to survival persisted while the rest perished — the earliest anticipation of natural selection. The Mariner is an Empedoclean compound, man-faced fish-progeny whose persistence is a function of fit. More important is the cosmological lesson. Empedocles' cosmos oscillates between the total mixture of the elements under Love and their total separation under Strife. *Waterworld* represents a third possibility the scheme does not contemplate: neither mixture nor separation but hegemony, the conquest of the cosmos by a single root. Each of the film's factions may be understood as an attempt to restore elemental plurality by hoarding a residue of a vanquished element — earth in the Atoll's jars, fire in the Smokers' tanks, air in Gregor's balloon — while the Mariner alone accommodates himself to the hegemon.

Aristotle's doctrine of natural place sharpens the point into a paradox. In the sublunary cosmos each element has a proper region toward which it moves and in which it rests: earth at the center, water above earth, air above water, fire uppermost. By this physics the flooded world of *Waterworld* is not a catastrophe but the cosmos at rest, water occupying its natural place above earth; it is dry land that requires explanation. Medieval natural philosophy took the problem seriously, and its most remarkable treatment is Dante's own *Questio de aqua et terra* (1320), which argues that the emergence of habitable land above the sphere of water is caused by the influence of the fixed stars drawing the earth upward. The *Commedia* draws the cosmographical consequence. Its southern hemisphere is an unbroken ocean interrupted by a single mountain — Purgatory, thrown up by the earth that fled from Lucifer's fall (*Inferno* XXXIV.121–26) — upon whose summit lies the Earthly Paradise, with its trees, its rivers, and its unfallen springtime. This is the geography of *Waterworld*: a planetary ocean and a single summit crowned with vegetation, fresh water, and animal life. And it is within sight of this mountain that Dante's Ulysses, having sailed beyond the Pillars of Hercules in pursuit of virtue and knowledge, glimpses a mountain dark with distance before a whirlwind

from the new land spins his ship three times and the sea closes over him (*Inferno* XXVI.133–42). The Mariner, whom the extended version names Ulysses, is the Dantean voyager granted the landfall Dante denied him — and who, having attained the mountain, chooses the sea.

The modern theorist who restored the elements to the center of humanistic inquiry is Gaston Bachelard, whose "material imagination" (*imagination matérielle*) holds that reverie is governed less by forms than by substances, and that each element organizes a distinct regime of images, affects, and values. His elemental tetralogy — *The Psychoanalysis of Fire* (1938), *Water and Dreams* (1942), *Air and Dreams* (1943), and the two volumes of *Earth and Reveries* (1948) — furnishes the closest theoretical precedent for the method adopted here, and *Waterworld*'s four regimes correspond with some precision to its four inquiries. *Water and Dreams* argues for the supremacy of fresh water, the imagination's spontaneous privileging of the spring over the sea, which it experiences as an inhuman water; *Waterworld* converts that supremacy into a currency. The same book's analysis of composite waters — water kneaded with earth into paste — anticipates the Atoll's compost economy, and its catalogue of hostile reveries includes the Xerxes complex, named for the king who had the Hellespont flogged, the will to punish the sea that the Smokers' jet-ski cavalry enacts at speed. *The Psychoanalysis of Fire* identifies an Empedocles complex, the fascination with self-annihilation in flame, named for the philosopher who by legend leapt into Etna; the Deacon's tanker, ignited by a single flare dropped into its reserves, is its cinematic apotheosis. *Air and Dreams* theorizes the ascensional psyche, the reverie of lightness that animates Gregor's balloon; *Earth and Reveries of Repose* theorizes the house, the shell, and the refuge — the reveries of enclosure that animate the Atoll's walls. Bachelard wrote no fifth book on skin, but his successor in the psychoanalysis of surfaces, Didier Anzieu, would theorize the skin-ego (*Moi-peau*, 1985), the psychic envelope modeled on the body's surface, which Chapter Four mobilizes to read Enola.

Bachelard's is not the only elemental tetralogy at issue. Between 1961 and 1966, J. G. Ballard — a reader of Freud and Jung rather than of Bachelard — published four novels of planetary catastrophe, each organized around an element: *The Wind from Nowhere* (air), *The Drowned World* (water), *The Drought* (fire; first published in the United States as *The Burning World*), and *The Crystal World*, in which matter itself crystallizes (earth). *The Drowned World* (1962) is *Waterworld*'s most important literary precursor. Solar radiation has melted the ice caps; London is a lagoon of drowned office blocks; and the protagonist, Kerans, experiences the flood not as catastrophe but as summons, a reactivation of archaic memories

encoded in the spinal column that draws him back toward the Triassic and, at the novel's end, southward into the jungle and the sun. Ballard's flood is a psychic regression made planetary, and his hero's refusal of rescue anticipates the Mariner's refusal of land. The difference, developed in Chapter Five, is decisive: Ballard's regression is solitary and terminal, whereas the Mariner's return to the sea follows an act of delivery. He goes back only after he has brought someone else ashore.

The elemental hermeneutic assembled here thus draws on four sources: pre-Socratic physics, which supplies the models; Aristotelian and Dantean cosmography, which supplies the geography; Bachelard's material imagination, which supplies the psychology; and the comparative archive of the preceding section, which supplies the narratives. Its premise is that the elements are not merely things in the film's world but the categories through which that world is thought — that soil, smoke, air, water, and skin function in *Waterworld* as Carl Schmitt held land and sea to function in world history: as elemental orders, each generating its own law.

1.5

A Sea Without Character

Nomos, Smooth Space, and the Migration of the Ground

The second axis of this dissertation is juridical and geopolitical, and its principal interlocutor is Carl Schmitt — a thinker whose complicity with National Socialism requires that his concepts be handled as instruments of diagnosis rather than objects of allegiance, but whose geo-jurisprudence remains the most rigorous account of the relation between law and the elements. In *Land and Sea* (1942) and *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950), Schmitt derives the Greek *nomos* from *nemein*, a verb signifying at once to take, to divide, and to pasture. Every order, on this account, begins with an appropriation of land (*Landnahme*), proceeds to its distribution, and is sustained by its productive use; law is not a system of norms suspended above space but the measure of a determinate earth, the unity of order (*Ordnung*) and localization (*Ortung*). The earth is, in Schmitt's mythic idiom, the mother of law in a threefold sense: it rewards labor with harvest according to an inner measure, it bears the firm lines of fences and furrows by which possession is made visible, and it carries the walls, houses, and boundary-stones by which order is publicly displayed.

The sea knows none of this. Playing on the Greek *charassein* — to engrave, to scratch, to stamp — Schmitt observes that the sea has no character: no fields can be sown upon it, no firm lines cut into it, and the ships that cross it leave no lasting trace. Hence, in the European order whose rise and dissolution *The Nomos of the Earth* narrates, the sea was declared free — Grotius's *Mare Liberum* (1609) prevailing, in practice, over Selden's *Mare Clausum* (1635) — and constituted a zone outside the territorial order, where the bracketing of war that obtained among land-states did not apply and where the pirate, the privateer, and the whaler could flourish as the elemental heroes of a maritime existence. Schmitt, who regarded Melville as the Homer of the oceanic age, located the decisive turn of modern history in England's elemental decision for the sea: its transformation from a fragment of the continent into something like a vessel anchored offshore, a Leviathan rather than a Behemoth, to use the Kabbalistic emblems of sea-power and land-power that he drew, by way of Hobbes, from the Book of Job.

Waterworld is the thought experiment Schmitt's theory does not dare: the generalization of the sea. If nomos is constitutively terrestrial, a world without land should be a world without law. Yet the film's world is not anomic. It teems with orders: the Atoll's elders, gatekeepers, and enforcers, its rationing of water and its penalty of recycling; the Smokers' hierarchy, liturgy, ledger, and fleet; the trading protocols of drifters; the Mariner's own austere code of non-interference. Where, then, has the nomos gone? The thesis of this dissertation is that it has migrated. Deprived of the earth as its support, the nomos relocates onto whatever surfaces remain capable of bearing an inscription and furnishing a measure. In the Atoll, it relocates into dirt — soil traded by weight, the earth made portable and fungible, the mother of law reduced to a commodity in a jar. Among the Smokers, it relocates into fuel — fossil sunlight whose combustion is both the instrument and the sacrament of a would-be *Landnahme*. In Gregor's balloon, it relocates into the aerial view, the cartographic gaze of the surveyor now hovering, unanchored, over an unmarked sea. And in Enola it relocates into skin. Because the sea cannot be engraved, the engraving that would locate the land is cut into a child. The map on Enola's back is the last field, the last furrow, the last boundary-stone: a nomos of the earth borne between the shoulder blades of a girl who was born on that earth and carries it, unseen by herself, into a world that has forgotten it.

The year of the film's release was also the year of Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995), whose concluding section, "The Camp as the *Nomos* of the Modern," reformulates Schmitt's thesis for an age in which the state of exception has become the rule. The camp, for Agamben, is the space that opens when the localization

binding law to land is dislocated, and in which human beings are reduced to bare life — life that may be killed without the killing counting as either homicide or sacrifice. The convergence is suggestive. The Mariner's first experience of the Atoll is of a cage, a summary proceeding, and a sentence of death by immersion in communal sludge: a sequence in which the stranger is stripped of every attribute but his anomalous biology. That the Atollers frame the execution as recycling, the return of the condemned's organic matter to the communal economy, is the precise signature of the camp's logic — the conversion of a political decision into a biological process. The Atoll, a polity without ground, has already discovered the nomos of the modern.

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's distinction between smooth and striated space, elaborated in *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980), translates Schmitt's opposition into a theory of movement. Striated space is measured, gridded, and partitioned; it is the space of the State, of the field and the city wall. Smooth space is a field of intensities and directions occupied without being counted; it is the space of the nomad. Their privileged instance of smoothness is the sea, which they treat as the maritime model of smooth space and, for that very reason, as the first smooth space the State set out to striate — through astronomical navigation, the reckoning of longitude, and the cartographic grid. Read through this distinction, *Waterworld*'s narrative is a contest over the striation of the sea. The Mariner is the nomad, who holds the ocean without measuring it and navigates by sensation rather than chart. The Deacon is the despot of the apparatus of capture, whose desire for Dryland is a desire for the striated *par excellence*: land that can be surveyed, parceled, and sold. And the tattoo on Enola's back — which Gregor at last deciphers as coordinates written with reversed directions (production record) — is the instrument of striation itself, a grid of latitude and longitude that converts the smooth sea into a measurable path toward property. The child's body becomes the terrain on which the smooth and the striated contend. That the coordinates must be read in reverse, on a girl whose name is "alone" spelled backward, is the film's most compressed emblem of the problem this dissertation pursues: the land is legible only in mirror-writing, and only to someone other than its bearer.

Hegel, in the geographical introduction to his *Lectures on the Philosophy of History*, describes the sea as the element that lifts humanity beyond the soil-bound dependencies of the valley-plain, and distinguishes the two possibilities it opens: "the sea invites man to conquest, and to piratical plunder, but also to honest gain and to commerce" (trans. Sibree). *Waterworld* distributes these possibilities between its antagonists. The Smokers are the piratical sea; the Mariner, who arrives

at the Atoll as a trader with soil to sell, is the commercial sea. Schmitt, for his part, adopted from the geographer Ernst Kapp a world-historical triad of potamic, thalassic, and oceanic civilizations — river cultures, inland-sea cultures, and the global maritime civilization inaugurated by the age of discovery. The film projects a fourth stage, which this dissertation names the **PANTHALASSIC**, after the superocean that encircled Pangaea in the late Paleozoic: a condition in which the ocean is no longer a medium between lands but the totality from which land has been subtracted. *Waterworld* depicts a Panthalassa without a Pangaea.

The analysis takes its place, finally, within what John Gillis, Steve Mentz, and others have taught us to call the blue humanities — the reorientation of humanistic inquiry from the land toward the sea — and within the oceanic turn in postcolonial theory, whose founding text for the Pacific is Epeli Hau'ofa's "Our Sea of Islands" (1993). Hau'ofa's distinction between "islands in a far sea," the continental view of Oceania as a scattering of small, isolated, dependent territories, and "a sea of islands," the Islander's view of a vast and connected world of voyaging kin, proves decisive for the argument of Chapter Five. The Atoll sees the ocean as Hau'ofa's continental observers did: as a void that isolates, a threat to be walled out. The Mariner inhabits it as Hau'ofa's voyagers did: as a road. Philip Steinberg's insistence that the ocean is not the absence of social space but a distinct form of it, and Steinberg and Kimberley Peters's call for "wet ontologies" attentive to the ocean's volume, motion, and materiality, complete the apparatus. *Waterworld* is a wet ontology rendered as spectacle.

1.6

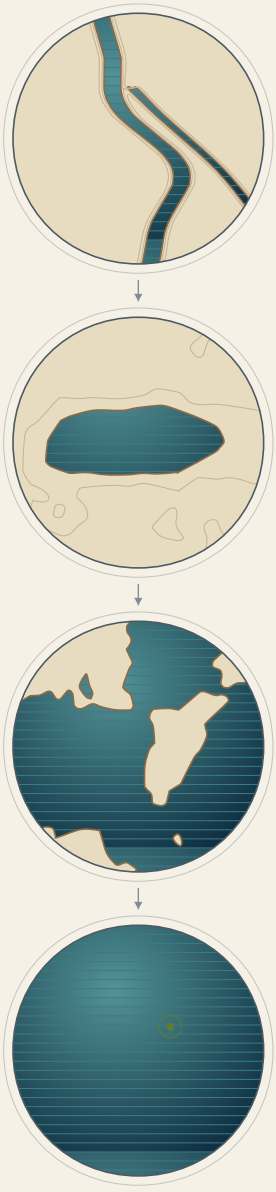
The Argument

Dorsal Nomos, the Counter-Ararat, and Thalassal Ethics

The foregoing coordinates permit a formal statement of the thesis. *Waterworld* stages an elemental political theology in which the disappearance of land compels the classical elements to function as rival foundations of order, each constituting a regime of value, a surface of inscription, a political form, and a temporality. The film's narrative is the contest among these regimes for possession of a fifth term — a child whose skin bears the only remaining inscription of the land — and its resolution is the refusal, by the one figure capable of founding a new order on that inscription, to do so. Three concepts carry the argument.

FIGURE 3

Four Conditions of Water



I *Potamic*

KAPP · SCHMITT

river cultures

II *Thalassic*

KAPP · SCHMITT

inland-sea cultures

III *Oceanic*

KAPP · SCHMITT

the global maritime civilization inaugurated by the age of discovery

IV *Panthalassic*

THIS STUDY

the ocean no longer a medium between lands but the totality from which land has been subtracted: a Panthalassa without a Pangaea

The world-historical triad Schmitt adopted from Ernst Kapp — potamic, thalassic, oceanic — and the fourth condition the film projects, here named panthalassic (§1.5).

The first is **DORSAL NOMOS**: the inscription of territorial law upon a surface its bearer cannot read. The back is the body's blind side, the one surface the self can never see without a mirror or another's eyes; to write the land upon it is to make the bearer the carrier of a text legible only to others, and thereby to install, at the heart of the subject, a structural dependence on interpretation. It also renders the bearer an object of capture, since whoever reads the back possesses the land. Enola is pursued, abducted, examined, and bargained over not for who she is but for what is written on her; the Deacon's interest in her is cartographic, and his advisers' failure to decipher the tattoo is the failure of a regime of fire to read a text of earth. The genealogy of dorsal nomos, reconstructed in Chapter Four, runs through several traditions at once. The Turtle Island cosmogony places the world upon a back. Ovid's Deucalion and Pyrrha generate humanity *post tergum*. Polynesian *tatau*, which entered English as "tattoo" through the journals of Cook's first Pacific voyage, and which Alfred Gell analyzed as a technique of "wrapping in images," makes skin a site of protective, genealogical, and political inscription. Melville's Queequeg bears upon his body "a complete theory of the heavens and the earth, and a mystical treatise on the art of attaining truth," a text "whose mysteries not even himself could read, though his own live heart beat against them" (*Moby-Dick*, ch. 110), and he transfers it to the coffin that becomes Ishmael's life-buoy. Kafka's harrow, in "In the Penal Colony" (1919), writes the sentence into the back of a prisoner who learns it only through his wounds. To these must be added the feminization of land that Annette Kolodny traced through American pastoral in *The Lay of the Land* (1975), and its Columbian prototype: the letter on the third voyage (1498) in which Columbus surmised that the Earth was shaped like a pear, or like a breast, with the Terrestrial Paradise at its nipple. Enola's back is where these traditions converge: the land written on a girl, legible only to the men who would take it.

The second concept is the **COUNTER-ARARAT**. The diluvial archive culminates, in its Mesopotamian, Hebraic, Greek, and Indic forms alike, in a landing: the vessel grounds upon a mountain, the remnant disembarks, and order is refounded on the summit — in Genesis, with a covenant of dominion; in Ovid, with the regeneration of humanity from stones; in the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa, with Manu's sacrifice and the generation of a new posterity. *Waterworld* reproduces the landing and then breaks the pattern. The Mariner delivers Enola and Helen to the summit, surveys the trees, the horses, the fresh water, the hut with its two skeletons, and departs alone on an old wooden catamaran found on the island. The founder declines to found. The counter-Ararat names this refusal: the refusal of

the Noahic re-founding of terrestrial dominion, of the covenant that sets the fear and dread of humankind upon every beast and every fish, and, at the level of genre, of the homecoming (*nostos*) that closes the *Odyssey* and the homestead that closes the settler Western. Chapter Six situates the refusal in its full genealogy: Dante's Ulysses and Tennyson's; the doorway that closes upon Ethan Edwards at the end of John Ford's *The Searchers* (1956); the departing rider of *Shane* (1953); the fields of Ausonia that Aeneas must seek though they forever recede (*Aeneid* 3.496); and the stage Joseph Campbell called the refusal of the return.

The third concept is **THALASSAL ETHICS**. In *Thalassa: A Theory of Genitality* (1924), Sándor Ferenczi proposed that every organism harbors a thalassal regressive trend, a phylogenetic longing to return to the sea from which terrestrial life emerged, and that the mammalian womb, with its amniotic fluid, is an internalized ocean — evolution's substitute for the lost marine environment. In Ferenczi's bioanalysis, regression is the deepest current of the drives. *Waterworld* realizes the thalassal trend in a single body — the Mariner's gills are phylogenetic regression become phenotype — and then revalues it ethically. His return to the sea is not a retreat from the world but a refusal to appropriate it: he inhabits without owning, moves without striating, saves without settling. Thalassal ethics names that disposition. Its epistemological correlate is Neurath's boat, the recognition that there is no dry dock in which knowledge, or a polity, can be rebuilt upon secure foundations. Its philosophical antagonist is the passage of the *Critique of Pure Reason* (A235–36/B294–95) in which Kant, having surveyed the territory of the pure understanding, declares it an island — "the land of truth—enchanting name!—surrounded by a wide and stormy ocean, the native home of illusion" (trans. Kemp Smith) — where swiftly melting icebergs deceive the adventurous seafarer with the semblance of farther shores. Kant counsels the voyager to remain upon the island. The Mariner, having reached the land of truth, returns to the ocean of illusion. The ending is therefore not merely the lonesome hero's generic exit; it is a philosophical choice of the unfinishable voyage over the closed domain.

The three concepts rest on a structural opposition that the film inherits from myth and that Claude Lévi-Strauss, in "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955), identified as fundamental: the opposition between autochthony, the belief that humans are born from the earth, and the knowledge that each is born of a man and a woman. The Oedipus myth, on Lévi-Strauss's reading, works through this contradiction in a code of the foot: the earth-born are lame, and Oedipus is "swollen-foot." *Waterworld* recodes the opposition elementally. Enola, born on Dryland and bearing its map, is autochthonous. The Mariner — whose webbed

feet mark not lameness on land but fitness for water — is what this dissertation calls THALASSOCHTHONOUS, born of the sea. The film's narrative is the myth's attempt to mediate between the two: the sea-born delivers the earth-born to her earth and returns to his own element. The mediation does not reconcile the opposition; it distributes it, and in that distribution lies the film's ethics.

The elemental pentad that organizes the argument is summarized below. Each row anticipates a chapter; the order of the rows is the order of the argument, from the regimes that would refound the land (earth, fire), through those that would read it (air, skin), to the element that declines to own it (water).

Stated in a sentence: *Waterworld* is not a film about the loss of land but about what law becomes when it can no longer be written on the earth — and its answer, delivered through the body of a child and the departure of a man, is that the deepest fidelity to the land may consist in refusing to own it.

1.7

Architecture of the Dissertation

THE REMAINING CHAPTERS FOLLOW the elemental order of the table. CHAPTER TWO, "Dirt: The Atoll as Compost Commonwealth," reads the Atoll as a polity of earth without ground. It sets the film's sacralization of soil against Mary Douglas's definition of dirt as matter out of place — in a world without place, dirt becomes the holy — and reads the Atoll's horror of the Mariner through the Levitical prohibition, analyzed by Douglas, of water-creatures lacking fins and scales: the gilled man is an abomination in the strict taxonomic sense. Garrett Hardin's lifeboat ethics and Elinor Ostrom's institutional analysis of the commons frame the Atoll's management of water; René Girard's scapegoat mechanism frames its sentence upon the stranger; Kenneth Boulding's "spaceman economy" (1966), Buckminster Fuller's *Operating Manual for Spaceship Earth* (1969), and the troubled closed-system experiment of Biosphere 2, unfolding in the Arizona desert as *Waterworld* went into production, frame its closed-loop metabolism; and Thomas More's Utopians, who fashion chamber pots of gold, supply the model of its transvaluation of value.

CHAPTER THREE, "Smoke: The Church of Saint Joe and the Petro-Theology of the *Deez*," reads the Smokers as a church of combustion housed in the hulk of the *Exxon Valdez*, whose 1989 spill in Prince William Sound supplied the film with

TABLE 1

The Elemental Pentad

Earth

Compost commonwealth: the Atoll (Ch. 2)

VALUE-FORM
Dirt traded by weight; fresh water rationed

SURFACE OF INSCRIPTION
Wall, gate, ledger

POLITICAL FORM
Lifeboat commonwealth; the camp

MYTHIC ANALOGUES
Gun's stolen soil; Thales's floating earth; *Atrahasis*

PRINCIPAL INTERLOCUTORS
Hobbes, Malthus, Douglas, Hardin, Ostrom, Girard, Agamben

Fire

Petro-theology: the Smokers and the Deacon (Ch. 3)

VALUE-FORM
Fuel, ammunition, cigarettes

SURFACE OF INSCRIPTION
The icon of "Saint Joe" Hazelwood

POLITICAL FORM
Pirate theocracy; would-be *Landnahme*

MYTHIC ANALOGUES
Tata and Nene's smoke; Heraclitus B90

PRINCIPAL INTERLOCUTORS
Bataille, Benjamin, Weber, Ghosh, LeMenager, Daggett

Air

Aeronautical hermeneutics: Gregor (Ch. 4)

VALUE-FORM
Invention, decipherment

SURFACE OF INSCRIPTION
The aerial view; the chart

POLITICAL FORM
Republic of letters; minor science

MYTHIC ANALOGUES
Noah's dove; Daedalus; Hermes

PRINCIPAL INTERLOCUTORS
Bacon, Swift, Verne, Borges, Korzybski

Skin

Dorsal nomos: Enola (Ch. 4)

VALUE-FORM
The map as the land itself

SURFACE OF INSCRIPTION
The back

POLITICAL FORM
The child as territory

MYTHIC ANALOGUES
Turtle Island; Deucalion's stones; Queequeg

PRINCIPAL INTERLOCUTORS
Kafka, Melville, Gell, Kolodny, Anzieu

Water

Amphibious somatics: the Mariner (Ch. 5–6)

VALUE-FORM
The body's own water

SURFACE OF INSCRIPTION
None: the sea has no character (Schmitt)

POLITICAL FORM
Nomadism; *mare liberum*

MYTHIC ANALOGUES
Matsya; Varāha; Yu; Utnapishtim; the fish-people of Nahui Atl

PRINCIPAL INTERLOCUTORS
Ferenczi, Deleuze and Guattari, Hau'ofa, Neimanis, Alaimo

Each row anticipates a chapter; the order of the rows is the order of the argument (§1.6).

its sharpest topicality and whose captain, Joseph Hazelwood, the Smokers venerate as a saint. Walter Benjamin's fragment "Capitalism as Religion" (1921), Georges Bataille's general economy of expenditure, Max Weber's Protestant ethic, Amitav Ghosh's diagnosis of the scarcity of "petrofiction" (1992), Stephanie LeMenager's *Living Oil* (2014), and Cara Daggett's petro-masculinity frame the Deacon's sermons, his rowing galley, and his would-be *Landnahme*. Its comparative corpus runs from Melville's *Pequod*, a floating refinery of the whale-oil age, through Upton Sinclair's *Oil!* and *There Will Be Blood* (2007) to the War Boys of *Fury Road* and Margaret Atwood's God's Gardeners, whose calendar of ecological saints the Smokers' Saint Joe precisely inverts.

Chapter Four, "Air and Skin: Gregor's Balloon, Enola's Back, and the Theory of Dorsal Nomos," pairs the film's two hermeneutic figures. Gregor — inventor, aeronaut, and finally decipherer — is read through the genealogy of the Enlightenment savant: Bacon's Salomon's House, Swift's Laputa, the Montgolfier brothers, and Verne's *Five Weeks in a Balloon* (1863) and *The Mysterious Island* (1874–75). Enola's back is read through Kafka, Melville, Gell, Anzieu, and Kolodny, and through a corpus of inscribed bodies extending from Ray Bradbury's *The Illustrated Man* (1951) to Christopher Nolan's *Memento* (2000). The chapter argues that hermeneutics in *Waterworld* is never innocent: to read the land is already to claim it, and the film's ethical question is who is permitted to read.

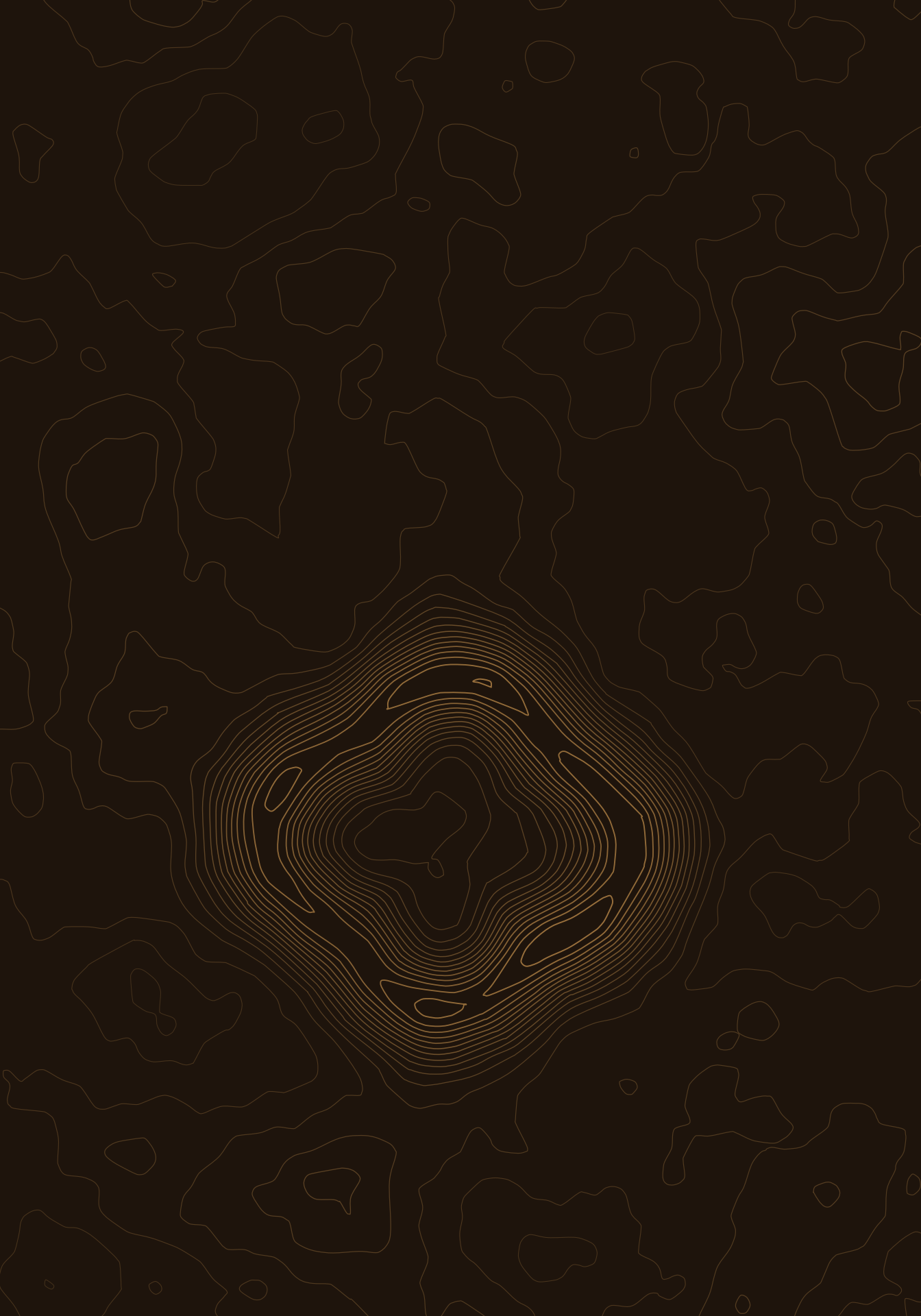
Chapter Five, "Water: The Mariner, the Gill, and the Thalassal Body," reads the Mariner as a posthuman body. It assembles Ferenczi's *Thalassa*; Freud's "oceanic feeling" in *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930); the aquatic-ape hypothesis of Alister Hardy and Elaine Morgan; Lovecraft's "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1936) and its xenophobic horror of hybridity; Namor the Sub-Mariner (1939); *Creature from the Black Lagoon* (1954) and *The Shape of Water* (2017); Hayao Miyazaki's *Future Boy Conan* (1978) and *Ponyo* (2008); Astrida Neimanis's hydrofeminism; and physiological studies of the Bajau and Moken sea-nomads of Southeast Asia, whose adaptations to diving lend the Mariner's mutation an unexpected empirical horizon.

Chapter Six, "Dryland: The Counter-Ararat and the Ethics of Departure," reads the ending through its Dantean, Tennysonian, Virgilian, and Western genealogies; through Columbus's breast-shaped paradise, Frederick Jackson Turner's frontier thesis (1893), and Henry Nash Smith's *Virgin Land* (1950). It also confronts the film's limits: the whiteness of its wayfinder in a Pacific setting whose voyaging traditions supplied the very multihull on which he sails, and the West-

ern's habit of resolving the problem of land by sending its hero away rather than by questioning the settlement that remains.

Chapter Seven, "Thalassonomy: *Waterworld* after the Waterline," follows the film into its afterlives — the theme-park spectacle whose sequel restores the Deacon and returns the Mariner to Dryland, reversing the counter-Ararat for the sake of perpetual performance; the 1997 sequel comic *Children of Leviathan*, whose villain bears the name of Hobbes's sovereign; the survival game *Raft* — and sets it against the Pacific's present: the Maldivian cabinet meeting held underwater in 2009, Kiribati's purchase of land in Fiji, Tuvalu's address to the 2021 climate summit delivered from knee-deep sea, and the Pacific Islands Forum's 2023 declaration on the continuity of statehood in the face of sea-level rise. It proposes, finally, the concept of **thalassonomy** — a law of the sea in the strong sense, a law that does not presuppose the land — as the film's untaken legacy.

A note on the text. Unless otherwise indicated, references are to the theatrical version released by Universal in 1995 (c. 135 minutes). The extended version, prepared for television broadcast and later circulated as the "Ulysses Cut," is cited where its additional material bears on the argument — chiefly its identification of Dryland as the summit of Everest and its concluding bestowal of the name Ulysses. Dialogue is paraphrased rather than quoted, both to avoid the textual instability that attends a film existing in several versions and because the argument concerns the film's structures rather than its lines. Translations from Greek are my own unless otherwise attributed; biblical quotations follow the Authorized Version.





II

DIRT

The Atoll as Compost Commonwealth

II

In the sweat of thy face shalt thou eat bread, till thou return unto the ground; for out of it wast thou taken: for dust thou art, and unto dust shalt thou return.

— Genesis 3:19 (Authorized Version)

Whatsoever hath no fins nor scales in the waters, that shall be an abomination unto you.

— Leviticus 11:12 (Authorized Version)

In such condition, there is no place for Industry; because the fruit thereof is uncertain: and consequently no Culture of the Earth; no Navigation, nor use of the commodities that may be imported by Sea; no commodious Building; no Instruments of moving, and removing such things as require much force; no Knowledge of the face of the Earth; no account of Time; no Arts; no Letters; no Society; and which is worst of all, continuall feare, and danger of violent death; And the life of man, solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short.

— Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan* (1651), ch. 13

2.1

Matter in No Place

Dirt and the Transvaluation of Value

The Atoll admits the Mariner on the strength of a jar. Before its gates an old man pleads to trade his own hair for water and is turned away; the Mariner's first offer, artifacts salvaged from the drowned world, is refused as well; only when he produces a jar of soil do the gates swing open, and close behind him (scene-by-scene guide). Inside, the soil is weighed, assayed — by taste — and exchanged: 3.2 kilograms for 124 chits, the Atoll's scrip (plot summary), which the Mariner promptly converts into fresh water, line, and a tomato plant. The sequence establishes, with an economy worthy of a theorem, the Atoll's order of value. The body's own matter is nearly worthless; the debris of the vanished civilization is worthless at the gate; earth is a fortune. In this world the most abject of substances has become the most precious, and the chapter's first task is to understand the transvaluation.

Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) takes as its point of departure the old definition of dirt as matter out of place, and draws from it a structural theory. Dirt is not a substance but a relation, the by-product of a classificatory order that assigns things to their places and treats whatever eludes its categories as polluting; where there is dirt, there is system. *Waterworld* poses the limit case of this theory. In a world without land, soil has no place to be out of. The category of the terrestrial has dissolved, and with it the system that consigned earth to the floor, the boot-sole, and the grave. Dirt can no longer be matter out of place because there is no longer any place — and so it becomes, by a reversal Douglas's own logic predicts, the sacred: the anomalous substance that every surviving classification must labor to contain. The Atollers do not merely value soil. They handle it with the reverence and anxiety of a people for whom the ground has become a relic.

The reversal has an etymological depth that the film's biblical substrate makes available. The Hebrew *'ādām*, the earthling, is drawn from *'ădāmâ*, the ground from which he is taken and to which, in the curse of Genesis 3:19, he must return. The Latin *homo* and *humanus* descend from the same Indo-European root as *humus*, soil, and so does *humilis*, low, near the ground: in the languages from which the West drew its anthropology, to be human is to be of the earth. The Atoll's veneration of soil is therefore a veneration of the stuff from which the human is named, and its jars are reliquaries of the species' definition. The Mariner,

who supplies the soil but is not of it — whose body was made for water — occupies a position the etymology cannot accommodate: the inhuman purveyor of humus, who brings the ground to those named for it and is excluded by them as insufficiently human.

Karl Polanyi argued in *The Great Transformation* (1944) that market society rests upon three fictitious commodities — labor, land, and money — none of which is produced for sale, and each of which can be subordinated to the market only at the cost of social catastrophe. Land, for Polanyi, is nature itself, woven into every institution of human life; to sell it by the acre is already a violence against the social fabric. *Waterworld* carries Polanyi's fiction to its literal terminus. Land is no longer sold by the acre, as title to a portion of the earth's surface, but by the kilogram, as a substance scooped into jars and carried in the hold of a boat. The fictitious commodity has become a real one; the earth has been detached from the Earth. Thomas More's Utopians, to cultivate contempt for gold, make of it their chamber pots and the fetters of their bondsmen. *Waterworld* achieves the inverse transvaluation by catastrophe rather than by policy, raising to the summit of value the very substance a terrestrial civilization tramples underfoot. Both inversions expose the conventionality of value. But More's is pedagogical, a lesson in the arbitrariness of desire, while the film's is ontological: soil is precious because it is the medium of growth, and growth is the medium of any future at all. The Chinese diluvial cycle had grasped this in its image of the *xirang*, the self-swelling soil Gun stole from heaven: in a drowning world, the earth that can multiply itself is the only treasure that matters.

The economic history of the modern world supplies a closer analogue than myth. From the 1840s to the 1870s the fertility of European and North American agriculture came to depend upon guano — the accumulated excrement of seabirds, quarried from arid islands off the Peruvian coast, largely by indentured Chinese laborers under notoriously brutal conditions, and shipped across oceans as the most valuable fertilizer on earth. The United States Guano Islands Act of 1856 authorized citizens to claim, on behalf of the nation, any unoccupied island bearing guano deposits; a scatter of Pacific and Caribbean islets thereby became American possessions, and the republic's first overseas territories were acquired not for their land but for their dung. The guano age is the historical rehearsal of the Atoll's economy: a world in which fertility is a substance mined at sea, carried by ship, and contested by navies. It was also the occasion of the century's most penetrating analysis of agricultural metabolism. Justus von Liebig's agricultural chemistry showed that crops withdraw from the soil mineral nutrients that must be

returned if fertility is to endure, and Marx, reading Liebig, diagnosed an irreparable rift in the metabolism (*Stoffwechsel*) between society and the soil: the nutrients of the countryside, carried to the cities as food, were discharged as sewage into rivers instead of returning to the land (*Capital*, vol. I, ch. 15; vol. III, ch. 47). John Bellamy Foster's reconstruction of this "metabolic rift" (1999) has since made it a founding concept of ecological Marxism.

Read through Liebig and Marx, the Atoll is a society that has closed the metabolic rift. Nothing it produces is discharged; everything, its dead included, returns to the organic matrix from which its tomatoes grow. F. H. King's *Farmers of Forty Centuries* (1911), the American soil scientist's admiring account of the "permanent agriculture" of China, Korea, and Japan, attributed the millennial fertility of East Asian fields to exactly such a regime — the scrupulous return of every organic residue, human excrement included, to the land. The Atoll is King's permanent agriculture compressed onto a raft. But the closure that heals the rift also engenders the Atoll's pathology. A metabolism that wastes nothing must admit nothing it cannot digest; a commonwealth organized around the return of all matter to the communal soil must regard any body whose matter is anomalous as a threat to the cycle itself. The remainder of this chapter traces how the Atoll's virtue becomes its violence.

2.2

The Floating Earth

The Architecture of the Atoll

The Atoll is the first thing *Waterworld* builds, and its architecture is an argument. Seen from the sea it is a ring of rusted plate and lashed timber, palisaded and buttressed, fitted with watchtowers and a counterweighted gate — a fortress whose silhouette borrows equally from the medieval castle, the stockade of the Western, and the offshore oil platform. Seen from within it is a lagoon city: butchers working the carcass of a sea creature, a trading barge whose shelves are nearly bare, an assembly hall, a cage hoisted above a vat of sludge, and, high in a windmill, the workshop of an inventor. It is built entirely of salvage. Claude Lévi-Strauss, in *The Savage Mind* (1962), distinguished the engineer, who conceives a project and procures the materials adequate to it, from the *bricoleur*, who must make do with a finite and heterogeneous stock of odds and ends left over from earlier construc-

tions, each element retaining a trace of its former use. Lévi-Strauss's idiom for that stock — *les moyens du bord*, the means available on board — is nautical: bricolage is, at the level of the phrase, a shipboard improvisation. The Atoll is the *bricoleur*'s polity, a city assembled from the debris of a civilization whose purposes it no longer understands, every plank and pipe a fragment of an older world reassigned to a newer one. Its architecture is the material form of its epistemology. Plato's children live inside the reused fragments of a past they cannot remember.

The defining structure is the wall. Ursula K. Le Guin opened *The Dispossessed* (1974), her "ambiguous utopia" of an anarchist society on an arid moon, with a wall around a spaceport which, depending on the side from which one regarded it, enclosed either the port or the entire world beyond it — the wall as the first and most equivocal political object. James C. Scott's *Against the Grain* (2017) has argued that the walls of the earliest agrarian states were built as much to keep their subjects in as to keep their enemies out: the wall as an instrument of capture as well as of defense. The Atoll's gate exhibits both functions. It keeps out the sea, the drifters, and the Smokers; it also keeps in the Atollers, as Helen's preparations to flee with Enola, and Gregor's long labor on a balloon, make plain. The only exits from the Atoll are upward, by air, or downward, by recycling. When the Smokers breach the wall, it is the protagonists who must open the gate from within — not, as at Troy, to admit the enemy, but to escape the city.

Gaston Bachelard's *Earth and Reveries of Repose* (1948) and *The Poetics of Space* (1958) theorize the house as the primal reverie of shelter: the shell, the nest, the cellar, the enclosure that protects the dreamer from the cosmos. The Atoll is a house built against the sea, and like every such house it dreams of permanence. But it floats. The reverie of repose is founded upon a ground that moves; the shelter is itself adrift. This contradiction — an architecture of enclosure without the fixity that enclosure presupposes — is the formal correlate of the Atoll's politics, which, as the following sections show, combine the closure of the fortress with the precarity of the raft. Thales imagined the earth as a log afloat upon water; the Atoll is the Thalesian earth made literal, and it suffers the anxiety Aristotle was quick to press against Thales: if the earth rests on water, on what does the water rest?

The Atoll belongs to a long lineage of imagined and engineered floating cities. Jules Verne's *Propeller Island* (*L'Île à hélice*, 1895) imagines Standard Island, an artificial floating city of American millionaires that cruises the Pacific, calling at the archipelagos of Polynesia as a tourist enclave; it is destroyed when the rivalry of its two leading families, each determined to steer the island toward its own destination, tears it apart in a storm. Verne's fable already contains the Atoll's lesson: an

artificial ground is only as stable as the consensus that holds it together. In the 1960s the Japanese Metabolist architects, Kiyonori Kikutake foremost among them, designed marine cities that would grow, shed, and replace their components in the manner of organisms, and Kikutake's Aquapolis, a floating module moored off Okinawa for the Ocean Expo of 1975, briefly realized the dream; Buckminster Fuller's Triton City offered a late-1960s design for a floating community. The seasteading movement of the twenty-first century, with its ambition of floating polities beyond the reach of territorial states, has recapitulated the dream in the libertarian idiom of exit. The Atoll is the dystopian residue of these utopias: a floating city built not by design but by necessity, not of modular steel but of scrap, and not to escape the state but because there is nowhere else to go. That the Metabolists named their movement after the biological exchange between organism and environment is a coincidence the Atoll converts into a program, as the next section shows.

Twenty-first-century fiction has returned to the floating polity with renewed intensity. China Miéville's *The Scar* (2002) imagines Armada, a pirate city of thousands of captured ships lashed together, which press-gangs the crews of the vessels it seizes and harnesses a colossal sea creature to drag it toward a rupture in the fabric of the world: a city that combines the Atoll's architecture of salvage with the Smokers' politics of capture. Rapture, the submarine city of *BioShock* (2007), built as a refuge from state and church, disintegrates under the pressure of the very self-interest it was designed to liberate. These are the Atoll's descendants, and their common theme is the one the Atoll inaugurates: an artificial ground does not escape the contradictions of the society that builds it but amplifies them, because it removes the one thing a terrestrial polity can take for granted — that the floor will hold.

Finally, the Atoll's architecture carries the Trojan coding identified in Chapter One. A walled city, home to a man named Priam, besieged by an armada from the sea, sheltering a woman named Helen and the child whose presence draws the besiegers: the Atoll is Troy rebuilt from salvage, and its fall, examined in section 2.6, follows the Homeric and Virgilian pattern with a fidelity that confirms Rader's account of his sources. Helen even plays, at the Atoll's assembly, the role Troy assigned to Cassandra. She warns that fewer and fewer atolls are seen and that the processes sustaining civilization are failing, and the assembly, urged on by the Gatesman, turns against her (scene-by-scene guide). The prophetess of decline is disbelieved within the walls she alone sees falling.

2.3

The Compost Commonwealth

Metabolism and the Closed Loop

The Atoll's institutions are metabolic before they are political. Among the first things the Mariner witnesses inside the gate is a funeral, in which the elders commit a body to the "organo barge," the floating vat of organic sludge into which the Atoll returns its dead and from which it draws the fertility of its gardens (scene-by-scene guide). The same vat is the instrument of the Atoll's capital punishment: the condemned are lowered into it in a cage, to be recycled according to custom. Burial, execution, and agriculture are a single institution. The Atoll's compost is at once its cemetery, its scaffold, and its farm, and the identity of the three is the key to the commonwealth's character.

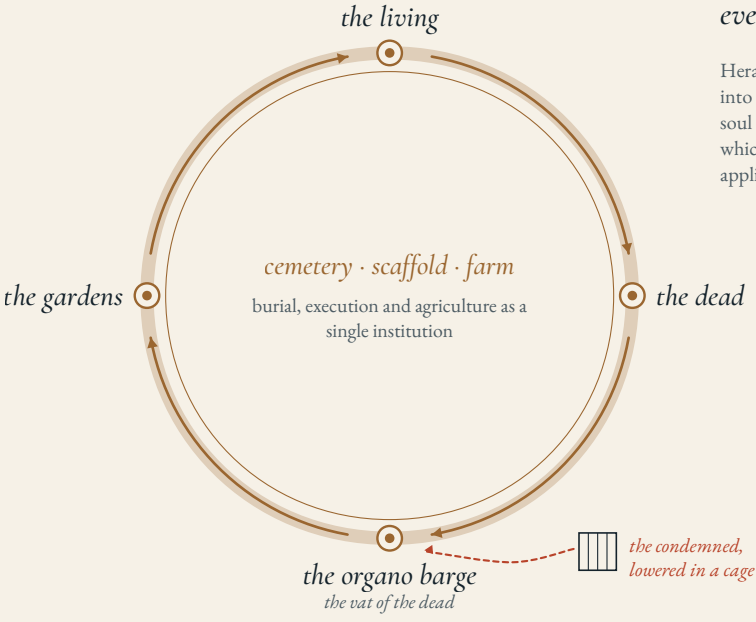
The Atoll's metabolism realizes, with grim literalism, the program of the closed-loop economy that environmental thought had articulated in the generation before the film. Kenneth Boulding's essay "The Economics of the Coming Spaceship Earth" (1966) contrasted the "cowboy economy" of the open frontier — reckless, exploitative, measuring success by throughput — with the "spaceman economy" a finite planet would require, in which the earth is conceived as a single vessel without inexhaustible reservoirs of anything, and humanity must find its place within a cyclical system capable of continuously reproducing its own material conditions. Buckminster Fuller's *Operating Manual for Spaceship Earth* (1969) popularized the figure, and the planet as sealed craft became one of the governing tropes of the environmental movement. *Waterworld* literalizes Boulding's dichotomy as a conflict between factions. The Smokers are the cowboy economy, burning a finite reserve in pursuit of a frontier; the Atoll is the spaceman economy, a sealed vessel recycling every molecule. The film's distinctive pessimism lies in its refusal to choose between them. The cowboys will burn themselves out; the spacemen, as this section and the next show, will purify themselves toward extinction.

The closest contemporary analogue to the Atoll was being enacted in the Arizona desert while the film was conceived and made. Biosphere 2, a sealed ecological enclosure near Oracle, Arizona, housed eight "biospherians" for two years from September 1991, in an experiment designed to demonstrate the feasibility of a materially closed human habitat. The enclosure's oxygen declined so far that sup-

FIGURE 4

The Spaceman and the Cowboy

THE ATOLL · THE SPACEMAN ECONOMY

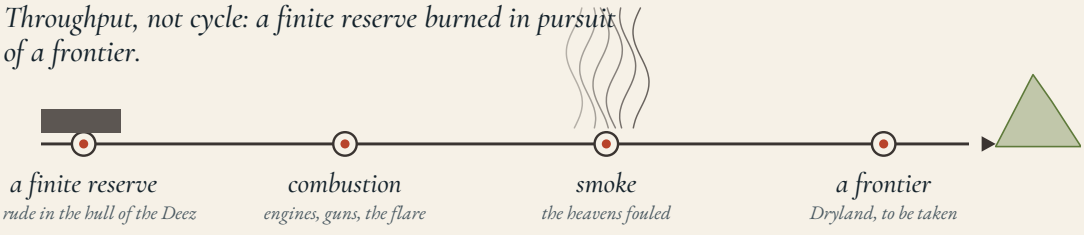


A sealed vessel recycling every molecule.

Heraclitus, B36: soul into water, water into earth, earth back into water and soul — the cosmological formula of which the vat is the municipal application.

THE SMOKERS · THE COWBOY ECONOMY

Throughput, not cycle: a finite reserve burned in pursuit of a frontier.



Kenneth Boulding's 'spaceman economy' and 'cowboy economy' (1966), as the film distributes them between the Atoll and the Smokers (§2.3).

plementary oxygen had to be pumped in; harvests fell short and the crew went hungry; ants and cockroaches flourished while pollinators died; and the human community split into mutually hostile factions. A second mission, begun in March 1994, collapsed within months amid a hostile change of management and an episode in which former crew members broke the enclosure's seals. The experiment's lesson was the Atoll's: a closed system fails less through physics than through politics, and the sealed community turns upon itself long before its atmosphere gives out.

The literary and cinematic precedents for the Atoll's metabolism form a coherent series. Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) — *Waterworld*'s mirror image, a planet of sand rather than sea, organized around the scarcity of the same substance — supplies its most rigorous antecedent. The Fremen of Arrakis wear stillsuits that reclaim the body's water from sweat and urine, and they render their dead in deathstills, reclaiming their water for the tribe on the principle that a man's flesh is his own but his water belongs to his people. The Mariner's urine filter is a stillsuit in hardware; the Atoll's organo barge is a deathstill for soil. Richard Fleischer's *Soylent Green* (1973), adapted from Harry Harrison's overpopulation novel *Make Room! Make Room!* (1966), supplies the dystopian version: a starving megacity whose ration wafers are, as its notorious final revelation discloses, manufactured from the bodies of the dead. The difference between the two films is instructive. In *Soylent Green* the horror lies in concealment; the recycling of the dead is the state's secret, and its disclosure is the climax. In *Waterworld* nothing is concealed. The recycling of the dead is the Atoll's public liturgy, conducted by its elders before the assembled community. The horror has migrated from secrecy to normality, and the migration measures the distance between a society that still requires the fiction of its own decency and one that has made necessity its creed. *Mad Max Beyond Thunderdome* (1985), whose Bartertown draws its power from methane produced by pigs in the Underworld beneath it, completes the series in the register of energy, and Bong Joon-ho's *Snowpiercer* (2013), whose sealed ark-train feeds its rear carriages on protein blocks rendered from insects and preserves its ecological balance by periodically culling its own population, extends it into the twenty-first century. Heraclitus's fragment B36, with its cycle of soul into water, water into earth, and earth back into water and soul, is the cosmological formula of which these institutions are the municipal application.

Cybernetics explains why such systems fail. W. Ross Ashby, whose homeostat of 1948 was among the first machines designed to maintain its own equilibrium against disturbance, formulated in *An Introduction to Cybernetics* (1956) the law of

requisite variety: a regulator can hold a system stable only if it commands at least as much variety as the disturbances it must absorb — only variety, in Ashby's formula, can destroy variety. The Atoll is a homeostat built to resist a single disturbance, the sea, and it has purchased its stability by reducing its variety. It admits no strangers, tolerates no anomalies, and recycles whatever deviates. When a new disturbance arrives — the Smokers, with their engines, firearms, and aircraft — the Atoll lacks the variety to absorb it. The irony, which the film registers without stating, is that the variety the commonwealth required was hanging in its cage. As the Smoker armada closes on the walls, the Mariner pleads to be released so that he can fight for the Atoll, and his pleas go unheeded (scene-by-scene guide). The requisite variety has been condemned to the compost.

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) theorizes the abject as that which the subject must expel in order to constitute itself: excrement, decay, and the corpse above all, which confronts the living with the very thing they must continually reject in order to go on living. The Atoll's compost economy refuses this expulsion. It keeps the abject at the center of the city, in the vat from which its food derives; it lives in permanent proximity to its own corpse. Bachelard's analysis of composite waters — the reverie of paste, of water kneaded with earth into the dough from which forms are made — supplies the image of what the vat contains: the primordial mixture, the *pâte* of creation, from which the Atoll hopes to draw its future. But the mixture is also a tomb. The Atoll's metabolism has healed the rift between the living and the soil by abolishing the distance between the cemetery and the garden; its people eat what their dead have become. The compost commonwealth is the earth regime's most coherent achievement and its most unsettling one, and the coherence and the unsettlement share a source: a polity that has made the cycle sacred must treat whatever interrupts the cycle as sacrilege.

2.4

Lifeboat Ethics

Scarcity as Constitution

The Atoll's crisis is demographic before it is military, and the film discloses it in an exchange that commentary has largely passed over. As the Mariner carries his purchases back to his boat, the elders stop him and ask that he father a child with a young woman of the community (scene-by-scene guide). The request is a

confession. A closed population, cut off from exchange with other communities by the dispersal of the atolls and the predation of the Smokers, has begun to fear the consequences of its own enclosure, and it values the stranger not as a prospective citizen but as a source of new blood. His refusal precipitates the discovery of his gills, and the community that a moment earlier solicited his seed now demands his death. The sequence condenses the Atoll's reproductive politics into a single reversal: the outsider is first a genetic resource and then a genetic contaminant, and both valuations treat him as matter rather than as a person.

The structure is ancient. The *Atrahasis* epic, as Chapter One observed, is the oldest literary theory of overpopulation, and its post-diluvial settlement institutionalizes the control of human fertility as divine law. Thomas Robert Malthus's *Essay on the Principle of Population* (1798) gave the theory its modern form: "Population, when unchecked, increases in a geometrical ratio. Subsistence increases only in an arithmetical ratio." Malthus's positive checks — famine, disease, war — are the instruments by which nature restores the balance human prudence fails to keep, and in the second edition of 1803 he gave the doctrine its most notorious image, declaring of the man born into a world already possessed, whose labor society does not want, that "at nature's mighty feast there is no vacant cover for him." The Atoll is a Malthusian polity in the strict sense. Its subsistence is fixed by the volume of its soil and the capacity of its stills; its population must be held within those limits; and the stranger, unless he can be converted into a resource, has no place at the feast. *Waterworld* complicates the Malthusian picture, however, by staging two inverse demographic crises. The Atoll fears depletion: too few, too closely related. The Smokers, as Chapter Three shows, face the opposite. Their leader speaks of a parish outgrowing its tanker, waves away Enola's suggestion of population control, and seeks instead a new land to absorb the surplus (scene-by-scene guide). The film thus enacts both of Malthus's nightmares at once: the closed community starving in its enclosure, and the expanding horde consuming the world in search of room.

Hobbes supplies the political theory of the Atoll's founding. The thirteenth chapter of *Leviathan*, quoted in this chapter's third epigraph, describes the natural condition of mankind as one without industry, without culture of the earth, without navigation, without knowledge of the face of the earth, without an account of time — a condition of continual fear in which the life of man is solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short. The list is uncannily apposite. Hobbes's state of nature lacks precisely what the drowned world lacks: agriculture, cartography, chronology. The Atoll is the commonwealth instituted against that condition, a covenant

of the frightened, who surrender their natural liberty to a common power — the elders, the Enforcer, the gate — in exchange for protection from the sea and from one another. The engraved frontispiece of *Leviathan* depicts the sovereign as a colossal body composed of the bodies of his subjects, rising behind a landscape of town and field beneath the Vulgate's verse from Job, that there is no power upon the earth (*super terram*) to be compared with him. The Atoll is that body without the landscape: a Leviathan assembled from salvage, a sovereign with no land to rise behind and no earth upon which to be incomparable. The name Hobbes borrowed from Job's sea monster is apt in a sense he could not have intended. The Atoll is a Leviathan returned to the sea, and its sovereignty is exercised over a ground that floats.

Garrett Hardin's "Lifeboat Ethics: The Case Against Helping the Poor" (1974) provides the Atoll with its moral philosophy. Hardin, already the author of "The Tragedy of the Commons" (1968), proposed that affluent nations regard themselves as lifeboats of limited capacity surrounded by swimmers: to take the swimmers aboard would swamp the boat and drown everyone, so the ethical course, he argued, is to refuse them. The metaphor is the Atoll's architecture. The gate admits those who bring soil and excludes those who bring only hair; the community that asks the stranger for his seed condemns him for his gills; and the survivors of the Atoll's fall, regrouped on a makeshift raft, reject Helen's plea to rescue Enola, since a child pursued by the Smokers endangers the boat (scene-by-scene guide). The Atoll's ethics is lifeboat ethics, and the film's judgment upon it is unequivocal: the lifeboat that refuses every swimmer sinks anyway. Hardin's tragedy of the commons — a shared pasture ruined by the rational self-interest of each herdsman — is not the Atoll's failure mode. Its failure is the inverse tragedy, which might be called the tragedy of the enclosure: a community that hoards its commons against every outsider forfeits the alliances and the variety it would need to survive a stronger predator.

Elinor Ostrom's *Governing the Commons* (1990), written against Hardin's fatalism, demonstrated that communities across the world had sustained common-pool resources for generations through institutions of their own devising, and distilled from their successes a set of design principles: clearly defined boundaries; rules fitted to local conditions; collective choice by those the rules affect; monitoring; graduated sanctions; accessible means of resolving conflict; recognition of the community's right to organize; and, for larger systems, nested enterprises linking local institutions into wider federations. Measured against these principles, the Atoll is a revealing case. Its boundaries are defined to the point of fortification. Its

rules — the rationing of hydro, the valuation of soil — fit its conditions. Its assembly practices a form of collective choice, and its Enforcer monitors the community and, notably, takes the Mariner from the mob in the name of order rather than vengeance (scene-by-scene guide). But its sanctions are not graduated — the penalty for anomaly is death — and it lacks entirely the nested enterprises that would link it to other atolls. The Smokers have raided the atolls one by one, and the atolls, each walled against every other, have fallen one by one. The Atoll fails not because it is a commons but because it is an isolated commons: an island in a far sea, in Hau'ofa's phrase, rather than a node in a sea of islands. Its constitution is scarcity, and a polity constituted by scarcity cannot afford the generosity on which federation depends.

2.5

The Abomination of the Gill

Taxonomy, Scapegoat, Bare Life

The Mariner's crime is taxonomic. Exposed by the Gatesman — the guardian of the Atoll's threshold — his gills and webbed feet place him outside the categories by which the community distinguishes kinds, and the assembly convened to judge him is shown the instruments taken from his trimaran as further evidence of his alienness (scene-by-scene guide). Mary Douglas's celebrated chapter on "The Abominations of Leviticus" explains the logic. The dietary laws of Leviticus 11, Douglas argued, are not arbitrary hygiene but a system of classification in which holiness is wholeness and every creature must conform to the class proper to its element: in the waters, creatures with fins and scales; on land, four-footed creatures that walk; in the air, winged creatures that fly. Creatures that confound the classes — that live in water yet lack fins and scales, that creep or swarm — are abominable not because they are dirty but because they are anomalous. The verse that supplies this chapter's second epigraph states the rule with stark economy. The Mariner is at once the inverse of the Levitical abomination and its perfect instance: a land creature that has acquired the organs of the water, a man with gills and webbing and no scales, a being who belongs wholly to no element. In a world where the boundary between land and water has become the boundary between life and death, his body is that boundary transgressed.

The film's vocabulary of mutation drew on a decade in which the mutant had become American popular culture's privileged figure for persecuted difference. Marvel's X-Men, created by Stan Lee and Jack Kirby in 1963 and developed during Chris Claremont's long tenure into an allegory of prejudice, reached a mass audience through the animated series that began broadcasting in 1992; by the mid-1990s the mutant was a legible cipher for the racialized, the queer, and the stigmatized. The Atollers' epithet for the Mariner, "muto," belongs to this lexicon, and their terror inverts the older horror of hybridity that H. P. Lovecraft encoded in "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1936), where the fish-featured "Innsmouth look" marks a lineage of human intercourse with the Deep Ones and serves as the vehicle of its author's dread of racial mixture. Lovecraft's narrator discovers that he himself bears the taint and ends by resolving to join the creatures of the deep; the tale's horror and its consummation are the same discovery. *Waterworld* reverses the valence. It aligns the spectator with the hybrid and presents the Atollers' purity as the pathology. Chapter Five returns to this genealogy; here it suffices to observe that the Atoll's judgment is an act of racialized classification, and that the film's sympathies lie with the abomination.

René Girard's theory of the scapegoat explains what the taxonomy is for. In *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) and *The Scapegoat* (1982), Girard argued that communities in crisis — when the differences that structure social life dissolve into undifferentiated rivalry — restore order by converging their violence upon a single victim, whose expulsion produces a unanimity that is afterward sacralized. *The Scapegoat* identifies the stereotypes of persecution that recur in texts of collective violence: a crisis experienced as the collapse of social distinctions; accusations of crimes that strike at the foundations of the community; and the selection of victims bearing what Girard calls victimary signs — foreignness, physical anomaly, infirmity — that mark them as preferential targets. Every stereotype is present at the Atoll. The crisis is explicit, for Helen tells the assembly that the atolls are dwindling and the processes of civilization failing. The accusation is the stranger's danger to this and to other atolls. The victimary signs are written on his body: he is foreign, and he is physically anomalous. The Atoll's sentence is a scapegoating in Girard's precise sense, an attempt to restore the community's coherence by the unanimous expulsion of a marked other.

A biblical paradigm lies close at hand. In the first chapter of Jonah, the sailors of a storm-tossed ship cast lots to discover on whose account the evil has come upon them; the lot falls upon the stranger, the Hebrew in flight from his god; they cast him into the sea, and the sea ceases from her raging. The Atoll lowers the

Mariner into its vat as the sailors cast Jonah overboard, and with a comparable expectation: that the expulsion of the anomaly will still the storm. The storm comes anyway, in the form of the Smoker armada, and the scapegoat survives his immersion. Later the parallel is completed. At sea with Helen and Enola, the Mariner is swallowed whole by a great creature of the deep and emerges alive, its flesh their meal (scene-by-scene guide). The scapegoat is the one who survives the element appointed to dispose of him — and who, like Jonah, becomes the reluctant instrument of others' deliverance.

Agamben's figure of *homo sacer*, introduced in Chapter One, sharpens the analysis of the sentence itself. *Homo sacer*, in archaic Roman law, was one who could be killed with impunity but not sacrificed — excluded from both human and divine law and reduced to bare life. The Atoll's recycling is the precise juridical form of this exclusion. The Mariner is not executed as a criminal, which would acknowledge him as a subject of law, nor sacrificed, which would acknowledge him as an offering to the sacred; he is composted, returned to the organic economy as matter. Michel Foucault, in his lectures of 1975–76 at the Collège de France, described modern biopower as the power to make live and let die, and located the birth of state racism at the moment when the sovereign right to kill is rearticulated as biological necessity: the elimination of whatever threatens the health of the population. The Atoll's sentence is biopolitical in exactly this sense. The killing of the anomalous is recoded as the hygiene of the cycle, and the vat that feeds the gardens becomes the instrument of the community's purification. The compost commonwealth has discovered, at its center, the camp.

Two voices dissent from the unanimity, and their dissent anticipates the film's ethics. Helen objects before the assembly, warning that the atolls are dwindling and the processes of civilization failing — an argument whose implication is that the stranger and his soil may be the community's only link to a future — and the crowd, urged on by the Gatesman, turns on her. Gregor visits the cage by night and, unable to contain his delight at seeing a mutation up close, dissolves into giggles (scene-by-scene guide). Helen's dissent is pragmatic and Gregor's aesthetic — the one sees in the anomaly a use, the other a wonder — but both refuse the Atoll's classification. Together they form the nucleus of the alternative community that will assemble on the trimaran and in the balloon: a community that admits the abomination, and that will, for that reason, be the only one to reach the land.

2.6

The Fall of the Wall

Troy, Siege, and the Portable Atoll

The Atoll falls on the morning of the Mariner's execution. As the Enforcer lowers the cage into the vat, a lookout sights the Smoker armada; the Atollers man their walls with what amounts to medieval weaponry against jet skis, firearms, siege ladders, a gunboat, and a seaplane towing raiders on water skis; and a kamikaze craft blasts a breach in the wall through which the Smokers pour into the lagoon (scene-by-scene guide). The iconography is that of the fall of a city: the walls, the breach, the burning, the looting, the hunt through captives and corpses for the single prize the besiegers came to seize. The second book of the *Aeneid* is the template, and the film's Trojan nomenclature makes the allusion explicit. Troy fell through a gift admitted within its walls; the Atoll falls through a breach opened by a suicide vessel — a horse of the Smokers' own petro-theology, consuming itself in order to open the city. The asymmetry of the combatants is the asymmetry of the regimes. The Atoll fights with weapons powered by muscle; the Smokers fight with weapons powered by combustion — the engine, the cartridge, the explosive.

The protagonists' escape inverts the Trojan pattern. At Troy, the Greeks concealed in the horse descend by night to open the gates from within and admit the army. At the Atoll, Helen — having bargained the Mariner's freedom for passage on his boat — climbs with Enola to the gate's mechanism and opens one leaf from within, the Mariner forcing the other, so that the trimaran can escape to open water (scene-by-scene guide). The gate that kept the Atollers in becomes, in the hands of the abomination, a woman, and a child, the exit from the dying city. Helen's flight with the child on whom the future depends is in this respect less Homeric than Virgilian: it is Aeneas's flight from burning Troy, bearing his father and leading his son toward a land the gods promise and the sea withholds. The difference is that Aeneas founds Rome. Whether anyone will found anything at the end of *Waterworld* is the question reserved for Chapter Six.

The aftermath belongs to the Smokers. Amid the ruins the Deacon interrogates the Atoll's Commerce Elder, learns that the girl has escaped in the company of a mutant, seizes the occasion to preach to his men, and has the elder disposed of (scene-by-scene guide). The fate of the Commerce Elder — the officer of the soil

economy, liquidated by the prophet of the fuel economy — stages in miniature the confrontation of regimes that Chapter Three examines: the economy of earth, which values what grows, overrun by the economy of fire, which values what burns. It also discloses an affinity that the antagonism conceals. The Deacon's theology, like the Atoll's, is a theology of land; the two differ not in their object but in their means. The Atoll hoards the residue of the earth; the Smokers would conquer the earth itself.

Yet the Atoll does not simply perish. Its survivors regroup on a makeshift raft, a second and smaller Atoll, and the film's portrait of them is the chapter's final evidence. When Helen pleads for help in rescuing Enola, the survivors refuse; when the Mariner and Gregor speak of the world's drowning, the survivors dispute that there was ever a flood, and Helen must affirm it as truth (scene-by-scene guide). Reduced to its remnant, the earth regime retains its two defining traits: the lifeboat ethic that refuses the endangered, and the Platonic amnesia that has forgotten the catastrophe from which it was born. The Atoll is portable. It can be destroyed and reassembled because it was never a place but a form of life — a set of practices for hoarding soil, rationing water, recycling the dead, and excluding the anomalous — and that form of life survives the loss of any particular raft.

The form of life even reaches Dryland. Among those who arrive at the summit is the Atoll's Enforcer, who joins Gregor's balloon for the rescue of Enola and who, on discovering the skeletons of her parents in the hut, proposes to bury them in the earth (plot summary). The proposal is both touching and exact. The officer who presided over the Atoll's vat extends to the new land the Atoll's metabolic piety: the dead belong to the soil. The earth regime's law arrives at Dryland intact, borne by its enforcer. In the extended version, Gregor presses a bag of dirt into the departing Mariner's hands as a parting gift (scene-by-scene guide) — the currency of the Atoll offered, at the summit of the world, to the one man who has no use for it, as though the habits of scarcity could not believe in their own abolition. Whether the new land will be governed by the Atoll's law, or by something the Mariner's departure makes possible, is a question the film leaves open and Chapter Six takes up.

2.7

Conclusion

Gun's Dam

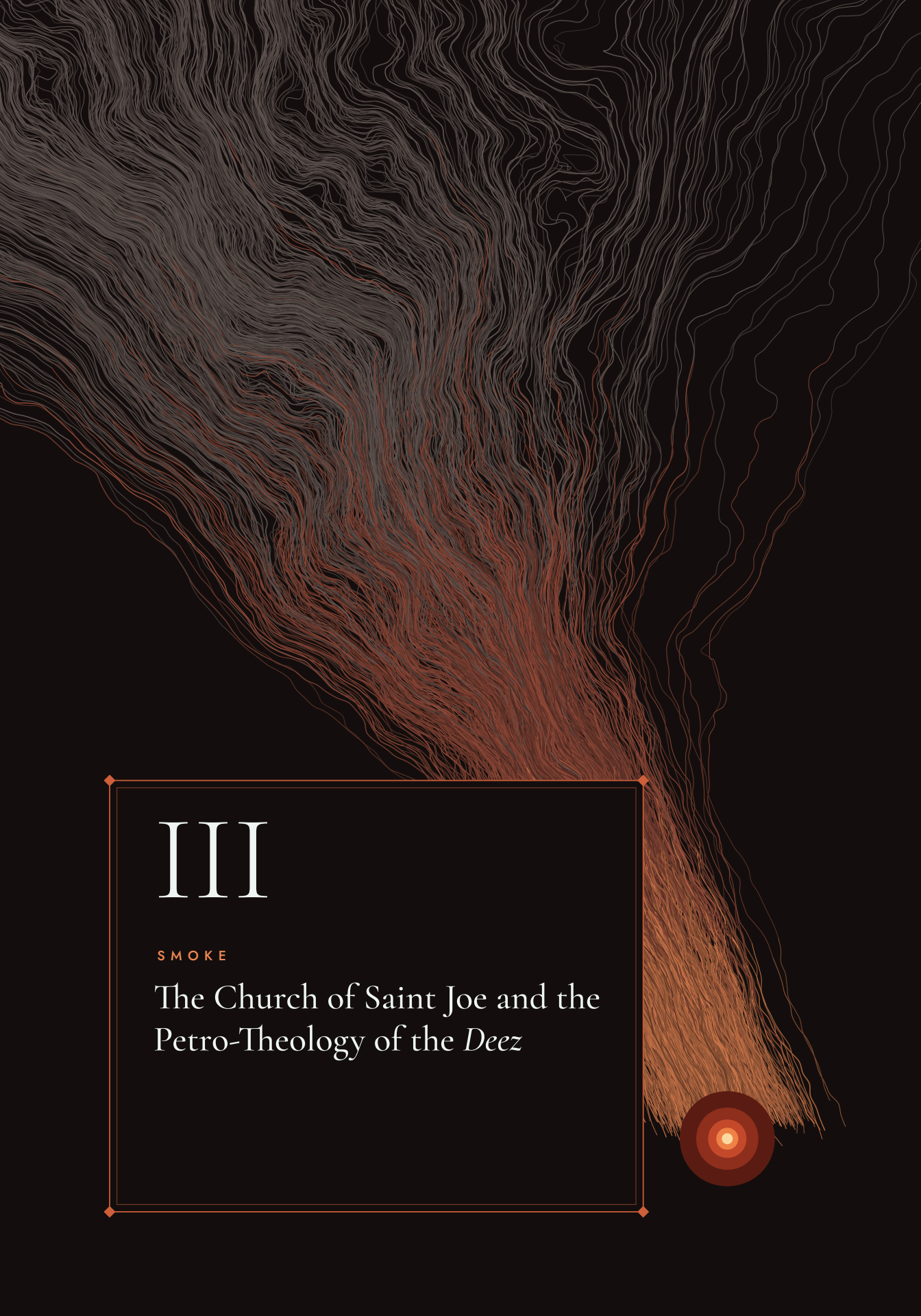
The Atoll is the earth regime's answer to the panthalassic condition, and its achievement should not be underestimated. In a world without ground, it has reconstituted the three moments Schmitt assigned to the nomos of the earth: it has appropriated (the soil in its jars), divided (the rations of hydro, the chits of its bank), and produced (the gardens fed by its vat). It has closed the metabolic rift Marx diagnosed in the agriculture of capitalism, realized the spaceman economy Boulding prescribed for a finite planet, and instituted a commonwealth against the Hobbesian sea. It maintains assemblies, procedures, and an officer who shields even the anomaly from the mob until judgment is rendered. By any reasonable measure it is a civilization, and the film, for all its antipathy, does not pretend otherwise.

Its limit is the limit of Gun's dam. The first engineer of the Chinese flood cycle stole the self-swelling soil of heaven to wall out the waters and was executed when the waters prevailed; his son succeeded by channeling the flood rather than obstructing it. The Atoll is a dam of soil against the sea, and its politics are the politics of obstruction: walls against the drifter, taxonomy against the anomaly, the vat against the stranger. Each obstruction preserves the community's coherence and diminishes its variety, until a commonwealth that has purified itself of every deviance finds itself unable to absorb the one disturbance that matters. The Atoll can preserve, but it cannot found. It can keep the earth in jars, but it cannot find the earth; it can recycle its dead, but it cannot imagine a future that differs from its past. Its relation to Dryland is therefore one of disbelief: the Atollers regard the promised land as a fable, and their survivors deny even the flood that made them.

And yet the Atoll harbors, without understanding it, the inscription that will lead to the land. Enola lives within its walls; Helen shelters her; Gregor, in his windmill, labors to decipher her back. The earth regime contains the map of the earth but cannot read it, because reading it would require what the Atoll forbids: commerce with the anomalous, trust in the stranger, the willingness to leave. The map departs the Atoll in the company of the abomination the Atoll condemned, and this is the chapter's final finding. The earth regime's fidelity to soil is real, but

it is a fidelity that has mistaken the jar for the ground. The land, when it is found, will be reached not by those who hoarded its residue but by those who could move.

Before the land is found, however, it must be fought over, and its most powerful claimant is not the Atoll but the force that sacked it. Chapter Three turns from earth to fire — from the compost commonwealth to the church of combustion that burned it: the Smokers, their Deacon, and the hulk of the *Exxon Valdez* on which they venerate the patron saint of spilled oil.



III

SMOKE

The Church of Saint Joe and the Petro-Theology of the *Deez*

III

And he opened the bottomless pit; and there arose a smoke out of the pit, as the smoke of a great furnace; and the sun and the air were darkened by reason of the smoke of the pit.

— Revelation 9:2 (Authorized Version)

All things are an exchange for fire, and fire for all things, as goods for gold and gold for goods.

— Heraclitus, DK 22 B90 (trans. mine)

We shall sing the great crowds stirred by work, by pleasure, or by revolt; … the gluttonous railway stations, swallowers of smoking serpents.

— F. T. Marinetti, "The Founding and Manifesto of Futurism," *Le Figaro*, 20 February 1909 (trans. mine)

3.1

The Church in the Hull

The Deez as Cathedral of Petroleum

The Smokers' fortress is withheld until the film's final act, and its revelation is staged as a theophany. Following a trail of fire across the night sea, the Mariner emerges from a bank of cloud at the foot of a towering wall of rusted steel, scales the hull through its wounds, and finds himself on the deck of a supertanker where a congregation of thousands is assembling for worship (scene-by-scene guide). On the conning tower, red letters left by the vessel's former owners can still be made out: NO SMOKING (PopApostle episode study). Only as the ship sinks does the name on its stern confirm what the dialogue has implied throughout. This is the *Exxon Valdez*, the "Deez" of the Smokers' idiom, and the church of the Smokers is housed in the most notorious tanker of the late twentieth century. A sign forbidding smoke presides over a people named for it, like a commandment carved by a dead god over the temple of his successor.

The real *Exxon Valdez* ran aground on Bligh Reef in Prince William Sound shortly after midnight on 24 March 1989, outbound from the pipeline terminal at Valdez with some fifty-three million gallons of North Slope crude, and released a quantity of oil still disputed — officially about eleven million gallons, by some estimates nearly three times as much (ship history). The spill fouled some fifteen hundred miles of coastline and killed, by contemporary estimates, a quarter of a million seabirds, thousands of sea otters, hundreds of harbor seals and bald eagles, and as many as twenty-two orcas (Seattle Times, 1999). In 1994, while *Waterworld* was in production, a jury awarded five billion dollars in punitive damages against Exxon — a sum the courts would reduce, after fourteen years of appeals, to about half a billion (ship history). The spill was the defining environmental image of the years in which Rader's script was written and rewritten, and its tanker was the defining object within that image: a single-hulled vessel nearly a thousand feet long, the largest ship ever built on the American West Coast, its name a fusion of corporation and place.

The real ship's afterlife is a parable the film could not have known and nonetheless anticipated. Repaired in San Diego, the tanker was renamed *Exxon Mediterranean*, then *SeaRiver Mediterranean*, then simply *Mediterranean*. Barred by law from returning to Prince William Sound, and later by European regulation from European ports, it worked the waters of the Middle East and Asia

under a flag of convenience until, in 2008, a Hong Kong company converted it into an ore carrier and renamed it *Dong Fang Ocean* — "Oriental Sea." In 2012, sold for scrap and renamed once more as *Oriental Nicety*, it was beached at Alang in Gujarat, after India's Supreme Court declined to block its dismantling under the Basel Convention on hazardous waste (ship history). The ship whose name had become a synonym for petroleum catastrophe spent its life shedding that name, and ended it on a tidal beach where laborers take apart the world's obsolete vessels by hand for their steel. *Waterworld* imagined the *Valdez* surviving into the drowned future as a cathedral; history dissolved it into salvage. Paolo Bacigalupi's *Ship Breaker* (2010), in which children scavenge copper from wrecked tankers on a flooded Gulf Coast, imagines a third possibility: that the cathedral and the salvage yard are the same place, seen from different classes.

Within the hull the film builds a church. Its nave is the deck, where the congregation gathers. Its pulpit is a balcony on the bridge, from which the Deacon addresses his parish through a microphone. Its crypt is "the Pit," the tank of residual crude in the vessel's bowels, to which the Deacon is conveyed by car — a 1961 Lincoln Continental convertible, the model of car in which an American president was assassinated, driven through the ship's corridors to Henry Mancini's theme from *Peter Gunn* (PopApostle episode study; scene-by-scene guide). Its sacristy holds the sacraments of the old world in commercial quantity: cases of whiskey, rum, and vodka, cartons of cigarettes, crates of canned meat. Its liturgy is industrial. The Smokers refine fuel, manufacture ammunition, and make cigarettes within the hull (production record), and they propel the tanker itself by oar, the engine having given way to banks of rowers below deck. The supertanker has become a galley. Its relic is a portrait, hung on the bridge, of the vessel's last captain. This is the church of Saint Joe.

The galley deserves emphasis, because it is the film's most acute economic image. The Smokers' civilization is founded on combustion, yet its flagship moves by human muscle. What fuel remains is too precious to spend on propulsion; it is reserved for the jet skis, the seaplane, the gunboats — for the instruments of raid and spectacle rather than for the labor of motion. Even the Smokers' auxiliary craft are hybrids of the highway and the sea: one gunboat is a paddle-steamer driven by the engine of a salvaged semi-truck, its paddles fashioned from automobile tires (PopApostle episode study). The rowers below deck are the hidden proletariat of petro-modernity, the bodies that must supply motive power when the fossil reserve runs low, and the sermon delivered to them from above, through loudspeakers, by a preacher who promises them land, is the oldest form of labor discipline. The

image recalls the galley slaves of *Ben-Hur*, but its deeper resonance is with the energy history of capitalism itself, to which section 3.4 returns. When the fossil fuel runs out, the master does not abandon mastery. He returns to the oar.

3.2

Saint Joe

Hagiography of the Despoiler

Joseph Hazelwood, master of the *Exxon Valdez*, had gone below to do paperwork, leaving his third mate on the bridge, when the ship failed to complete a ten-degree turn and drove onto Bligh Reef. Prosecutors alleged that he had been drinking; a jury acquitted him of the felony charges and convicted him only of the misdemeanor of negligent discharge of oil, for which he was sentenced to a thousand hours of community service, to be served over later summers picking up litter in Alaska (Seattle Times, 1999). The court of public opinion was harsher. Hazelwood became the face of the catastrophe, the drunken captain of late-night monologues, and a decade later he complained that the world had cast him as the Antichrist. *Waterworld* takes this figure, already a secular devil, and canonizes him. His portrait hangs on the bridge of the Deez; the Deacon swears by his name on learning how little crude remains in the Pit, addresses the painted face as Saint Joe, and assures it, as the final voyage begins, that the faithful are close (PopApostle episode study; scene-by-scene guide). Asked about the film, Hazelwood called his role "the patron saint of the bad guys" and judged the conceit dopey (Seattle Times, 1999).

Reviewers took the canonization as a gag. But the gag has a structure, and René Girard supplies it. The scapegoat, on Girard's account, undergoes a double transference. The community first holds the victim responsible for the crisis that afflicts it; then, when the victim's expulsion restores peace, it credits the same victim with the restoration, so that the figure once execrated becomes sacred. The sacred, for Girard, is born precisely here, in the retroactive divinization of the one who was blamed. Hazelwood's trajectory traces this double movement with uncanny exactness. The world made him its scapegoat — some of the investigators who studied the disaster would later describe him as a corporate scapegoat, the pawn upon whom the failures of a company and a regulatory system were heaped (Seattle Times, 1999) — and the Smokers, completing the Girardian cycle, have made him

a saint. In the drowned world, where the age of oil survives only as a lost golden age, the man who embodied its catastrophe has become the patron of its memory. The Antichrist of 1989 is the Saint Joe of the panthalassic future.

Walter Benjamin's fragment "Capitalism as Religion" (1921) supplies the theology. Capitalism, Benjamin argued, is not merely conditioned by religion, as Weber had shown; it is itself a religion, and a singular one. It is a purely cultic religion, without dogma or theology. Its cult is permanent, every day a feast day, without respite. And, uniquely among cults, it does not expiate guilt but produces it — the German *Schuld* meaning both guilt and debt — universalizing that guilt until it implicates God himself. The Smokers' religion fulfils each criterion. It has no doctrine beyond the promise of land. Its cult is continuous, a perpetual festival of consumption in which cigarettes are lit, cans are opened, and fuel is burned without a sabbath. And it is a religion of guilt rather than atonement, whose saint is the man who, in the world's eyes, incurred the heaviest debt of the oil age. The faithful do not seek forgiveness for the spill. They seek its consummation: the land the debt was incurred to reach. In Benjamin's terms, the Smokers' god is implicated in their guilt, because their saint is its author.

The Smokers' hagiography acquires its full meaning beside the fiction that would later invert it. Margaret Atwood's *The Year of the Flood* (2009), the second volume of the MaddAddam trilogy, follows God's Gardeners, an ecological sect whose calendar honors a pantheon of environmental saints — Saint Rachel Carson, Saint Dian Fossey, Saint Euell Gibbons, among others — and whose eschatology awaits a "Waterless Flood" that will purge the world. The Gardeners canonize the defenders of the biosphere; the Smokers canonize its despoiler. The two hagiographies are mirror images, and together they map the two theological responses to ecological catastrophe that late modernity has produced: the sanctification of those who resisted it, and the sanctification of the catastrophe itself. Atwood's Gardeners compost, recycle, and keep bees, and they are the Atoll's spiritual cousins. The Smokers are their antipodes: a church that venerates the spill.

Medieval hagiography, codified in Jacobus de Voragine's *Golden Legend* (c. 1260), organized the lives of the saints around martyrdom, miracle, and relic. The Smokers' cult preserves the form and reverses the content. Their saint's martyrdom is his public disgrace; his miracle is the spill, which loosed the sacred substance upon the waters; his relic is a portrait salvaged with the ship. Their sacrament is smoke. The Deacon smokes a brand called Black Death, and the Deez's stores hold cartons of cigarettes beside the whiskey and the canned meat (PopApostle episode study). Tobacco was the first great cash crop of English America —

the "brown gold" of the Virginia colony, whose cultivation drove the expansion of the plantation and of the Atlantic slave trade — and it was, among the peoples of the Americas from whom Europeans learned its use, a sacred plant whose smoke carried prayer to the heavens. The Smokers inherit both meanings at once, tobacco as commodity and tobacco as offering, and their prayers rise as smoke: the very offense that, in the Aztec Legend of the Suns, first provoked the gods after the flood.

3.3

The Deacon's Sermon

Petro-Evangelism and the Noble Lie

The Smokers' leader bears an ecclesiastical title, and its etymology is exact. The Greek *diakonos* means servant, and in the sixth chapter of Acts the diaconate is instituted when the apostles, finding that the daily distribution of food to the community's widows distracts them from preaching, appoint seven men to "serve tables" (Acts 6:2). The deacon is the minister of distribution. Before Dennis Hopper's Deacon ascends to his balcony to preach, he passes among his congregation handing out cans of meat (scene-by-scene guide) — the diaconal office performed to the letter and emptied of its spirit. The distribution of the community's sustenance has become the instrument of its subjection. The minister of tables has become the master of the house.

The casting supplied the role with a genealogy. Hopper had directed and co-starred in *Easy Rider* (1969), the counterculture's elegy for the open road, in which two bikers ride east across an America that kills them for their freedom; the motorcycle, there, was the vehicle of a utopia of mobility powered by gasoline. In the decades that followed, Hopper's screen persona curdled: the manic photojournalist of *Apocalypse Now* (1979), the gas-huffing sadist Frank Booth of *Blue Velvet* (1986), the extortionist bomber of *Speed* (1994). The Deacon gathers these figures into a single ministry. He is the biker grown old and ordained as a bishop of the fuel he once burned for freedom, and his jet-ski cavalry is *Easy Rider*'s highway translated onto the sea, its liberation converted into a raid.

His idiom is the American revival. The late 1980s had witnessed the spectacular collapse of the televangelist empires — Jim Bakker's ministry in fraud and scandal, Jimmy Swaggart's tearful confession of sin before his television congregation —

and the Deacon's sermons, delivered through a public-address system to a crowd that roars back on cue, parody the mass-mediated revival in which salvation and acquisition had become indistinguishable. The prosperity gospel's promise that faith will be rewarded with wealth becomes the Deacon's promise that faith will be rewarded with land. He tells his parish that one day they will dominate Dryland; he holds up the captured child as their salvation; and he smashes a bottle against the railing — the gesture with which ships are christened at their launching — before sending the congregation to the oars (scene-by-scene guide). The voyage so launched has no destination. His advisers have failed to decipher the tattoo, and the Deacon, to keep his followers' minds off their dwindling stores, has simply announced that he has decoded it (production record).

The sermon is a noble lie, and the Platonic precedent is more exact than the phrase usually implies. In the third book of the *Republic* (414b–415d), Socrates proposes that the citizens of the ideal city be told a Phoenician tale: that they were fashioned and nurtured within the earth, which is their mother, and that the god who formed them mixed gold into the rulers, silver into the auxiliaries, and iron and bronze into the farmers and craftsmen. The noble lie is a myth of autochthony, a fiction of birth from the land that binds the citizens to their territory and to their rank. The Deacon's lie is its precise inverse. Plato's rulers tell the citizens that they came from the earth; the Deacon tells his rowers that they are going to it. The one legitimates a hierarchy by a fiction of origin, the other by a fiction of destination — but both secure obedience by a story about land, and both assign the laborers to the base metals. The rowers in the hold are Plato's men of iron and bronze, and the land toward which they row is as fictive as the earth from which Plato's citizens were told they sprang.

Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, in *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), names the three powers by which the Church, correcting Christ, has made humanity content in its servitude — miracle, mystery, and authority — and grounds all three in bread, the earthly sustenance Christ refused to make from stones. The Deacon wields the same triad. His bread is canned meat; his miracle is Dryland; his mystery is the tattoo, whose meaning only he claims to know; his authority is the microphone. The Inquisitor's cynicism, which knows the promised kingdom to be a fiction and administers it as a mercy, is the Deacon's cynicism. What the Inquisitor lacks and the Deacon possesses is a deadline. A functionary called the Depth Gauge, whose office is to sound the crude remaining in the Pit, reports that the reserve will last only about two "lunars"; the Deacon invokes his saint, orders an end to the burning of fuel on entertainments, and bends every effort on finding

the girl (PopApostle episode study). Petro-evangelism is an eschatology with a gauge, and its calendar is lunar: the fire regime counts its remaining time in moons.

Max Weber's *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (1905) closes with an image that might have been composed for the Deez. Puritan asceticism, Weber argued, had helped to build the tremendous cosmos of the modern economic order, which now determines the lives of all born into it with irresistible force: "Perhaps it will so determine them until the last ton of fossilized coal is burnt." The Puritan divine Richard Baxter had taught that the care for external goods should lie on the shoulders of the saint like a light cloak, to be thrown aside at any moment; "But fate decreed that the cloak should become an iron cage" (trans. Parsons, 1930). The Deez is Weber's iron cage made literal: a steel hull inside which a congregation is bound to the economy of fossil fuel until its last ton is burnt. Its saint — Weber's word — wears not a light cloak but the weight of the carbon age. And the film's ending, in which the Deez burns, sinks, and takes its congregation down with it, is the scene Weber's sentence projects: the last of the fossil fuel burnt, and the cage going down with it.

3.4

Fossil Sunlight

Expenditure, the Accursed Share, and the Grease Feast

If Benjamin and Weber supply the theology of the Deez, Georges Bataille supplies its physics. *The Accursed Share* (1949) begins from the observation that the sun dispenses energy without return, and that every living system, receiving more energy than it needs to sustain itself, must dispose of the surplus — productively, through growth, or, when growth meets its limits, unproductively, through luxury, sacrifice, and war. Bataille's general economy takes the standpoint of the whole rather than the individual, and from that standpoint the decisive problem is not scarcity but excess: not how to acquire what is lacking but how to spend what cannot be kept. Petroleum is the purest instance of the accursed share. It is fossil sunlight — solar energy captured by ancient organisms, buried, compressed, and stored across hundreds of millions of years — and industrial civilization's two centuries of combustion are, in Bataille's terms, the release in an instant of a solar surplus accumulated over geological time. The Smokers are that release in its terminal

phase: a society whose whole life consists in burning what remains of the ancient sun.

Bataille's anthropological model of expenditure was the potlatch of the Pacific Northwest, which Marcel Mauss had analyzed in *The Gift* (1925) on the basis of Franz Boas's Kwakwaka'wakw ethnography: a ceremonial distribution and destruction of wealth by which a chief asserts his rank, humbling rivals by giving or destroying more than they can match. Among the forms of destruction the ethnographers recorded — and Ruth Benedict made famous in *Patterns of Culture* (1934) — was the grease feast, at which the host poured quantities of precious eulachon oil, rendered from candlefish, onto the fire until the flames leapt to the rafters and the guests had to endure the heat without flinching; the more oil burned, the greater the host's prestige. The Smokers' combustion is a grease feast on the scale of a civilization. Their raids, their jet-ski charges, their gunboats and suicide craft spend fuel not for production but for display, and the Deacon's order to stop burning it on entertainments (PopApostle episode study) confirms how much of the Smokers' oil had gone to spectacle. Their end is the potlatch's consummation, in which the giver destroys not a portion of his wealth but all of it: the Deez, once ignited, burns its whole reserve at once.

The consummation is forced by the Mariner. Confronting the Deacon on the deck, he holds a flare over the hatch to the oil reserve and demands the child's release; the Deacon, certain that no one would destroy the ship on which he stands, calls the bluff; the Mariner drops the flare (production record). Bachelard's *Psychoanalysis of Fire* named the fascination with annihilation in flame after Empedocles, who by legend leapt into Etna so as to vanish without trace and be thought a god. The Deacon's wager is that his antagonist shares the regime's attachment to fuel — that no one would burn the last of the oil. The Mariner, who has no use for fuel, does not share it. His flare enacts the Empedocles complex on the regime's behalf, forcing upon the church of combustion the total expenditure its theology had always implied and always deferred. The fire regime is destroyed by its own element, set loose by a man who belongs to another.

Andreas Malm's *Fossil Capital* (2016) has argued that the British cotton industry's transition from water power to steam in the 1820s and 1830s was driven not by any scarcity of water but by the needs of capital in its struggle with labor. The waterwheel tied the mill to the river, its seasons, and the sparse labor of remote valleys; coal-fired steam could be installed in towns, where a disciplined workforce was abundant and replaceable. Fossil fuel was, from the outset, a technology of labor control as much as a source of energy. *Waterworld*'s galley inverts Malm's

history with an almost diagrammatic precision. The Smokers, a civilization of fossil fuel, have exhausted the fuel and returned not to the waterwheel but to the oar — to the most extreme form of labor discipline, the galley crew driven by a preacher's promise. Run backward, the energy history of capitalism does not return to the commons of the river. It returns to slavery.

Timothy Mitchell's *Carbon Democracy* (2011) supplies the political corollary. The coal economy, Mitchell argued, concentrated energy in mines, railways, and docks that workers could shut down, and the strikes this leverage made possible were among the forces that won mass democracy in the industrial West; oil, by contrast, flowed through pipelines and tankers that required few workers and could be rerouted around any blockade, so that the shift to oil weakened labor's democratic leverage. The tanker is, in Mitchell's analysis, an instrument of de-democratization — the vessel by which energy escaped the hands of those who produced it. The Deez completes the arc. Its rowers supply its motion and have no voice; its energy is held by a single man, who alone knows, or claims to know, where the voyage is going. Carbon democracy has become carbon theocracy.

Reza Negarestani's theory-fiction *Cyclonopedia* (2008) pushes the analysis to its speculative limit, treating petroleum as an autonomous chthonic agent — the "Tellurian Lube" — that lubricates the motions of history and possesses the polities that believe they possess it. In Negarestani's hallucinatory geophilosophy, the wars of the Middle East are fought not over oil but by it. The Deez is a Negarestanian object: a vessel in which a people imagines that it commands its fuel while the fuel commands it, setting the rhythm of its raids, the urgency of its sermons, and the date of its doom. When the Deacon cries out to his saint on learning how little crude remains, he speaks as one possessed by the substance he serves.

3.5

The Engine Cult

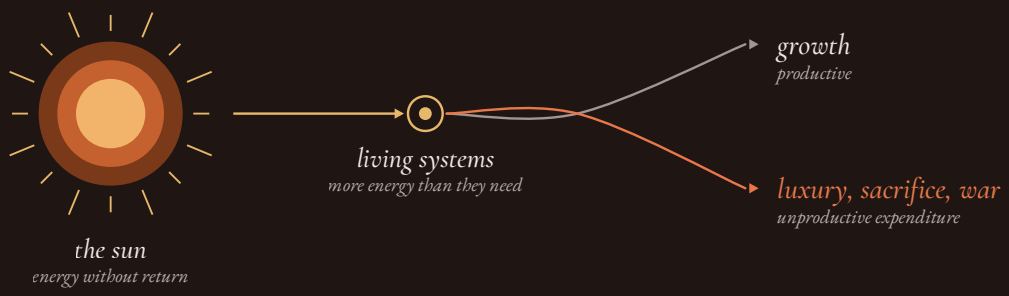
From the Pequod's Try-Works to the War Boys

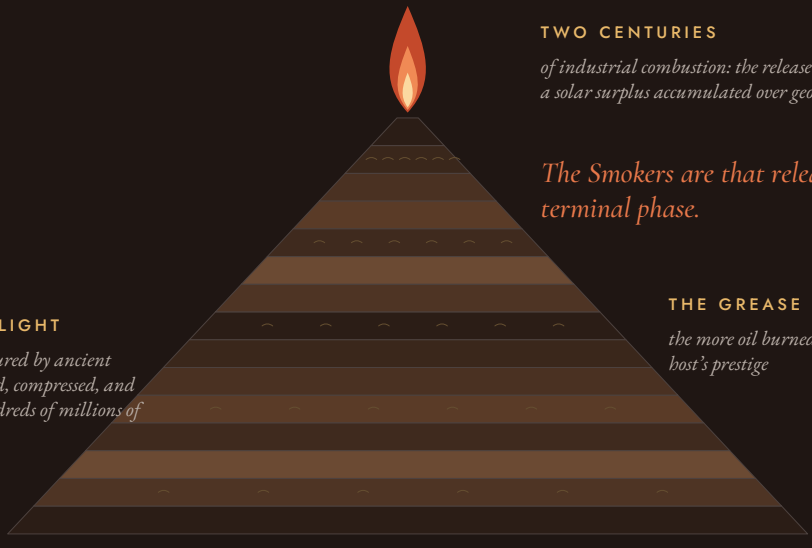
The Deez has a nineteenth-century ancestor. Before petroleum, the oil that lit the lamps and greased the machines of the industrial West was rendered from whales, and the American whaling fleet of Nantucket and New Bedford was the oil industry of its age. Ishmael, in the chapter of *Moby-Dick* (1851) called "The Advocate," boasts that the world unwittingly worships the whalemen, since

FIGURE 5

Fossil Sunlight

THE ACCURSED SHARE · BATAILLE





TWO CENTURIES

of industrial combustion: the release in an instant of a solar surplus accumulated over geological time

The Smokers are that release in its terminal phase.

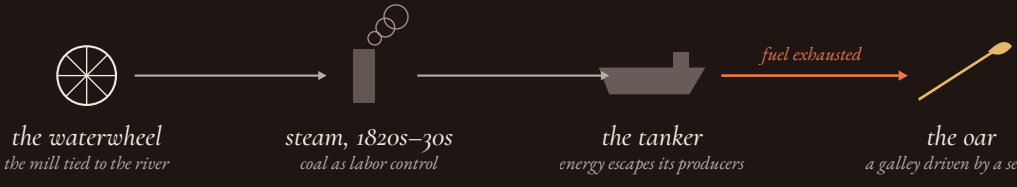
FOSSIL SUNLIGHT

solar energy captured by ancient organisms, buried, compressed, and stored across hundreds of millions of years

THE GREASE FEAST

the more oil burned, the greater the host's prestige

THE ENERGY HISTORY, RUN BACKWARD · MALM · MITCHELL



Run backward, the energy history of capitalism does not return to the commons of the river. It returns to slavery.

Bataille's general economy and the burning of the ancient sun (§3.4); below, the energy history of Malm and Mitchell, which the Smokers' galley runs in reverse.

"almost all the tapers, lamps, and candles that burn round the globe, burn, as before so many shrines, to our glory!" The light of the oil economy was, from the beginning, a light of worship. The novel's most visionary chapter, "The Try-Works" (ch. 96), describes the ship at night with the furnaces of its rendering plant ablaze on deck, the harpooneers stoking them with scraps of blubber, smoke and stench pouring into the dark: the *Pequod*, "freighted with savages, and laden with fire, and burning a corpse, and plunging into that blackness of darkness, seemed the material counterpart of her monomaniac commander's soul." Ishmael, entranced at the helm, turns his back on the compass and nearly capsizes the ship, and draws the moral: "Look not too long in the face of the fire, O man!" The Deez is the try-works become an entire vessel, a floating refinery whose congregation has looked too long in the face of the fire. Its commander's monomania is acquisition rather than vengeance, but the structure is Ahab's: a ship's whole company bent, by the rhetoric of a single will, toward a quarry whose pursuit will destroy them all. Schmitt regarded the whalers as the elemental heroes of maritime existence and Melville as its Homer. *Waterworld* shows what becomes of the whalers' heirs when the sea has swallowed the land. They no longer hunt the leviathan; they live inside it.

The twentieth-century oil narrative fused the preacher and the oilman long before the Deacon. Upton Sinclair's *Oil!* (1927) follows the son of a California oil baron through the boom years of the Southern California fields; Paul Thomas Anderson's loose adaptation, *There Will Be Blood* (2007), compresses the novel's social panorama into the duel between Daniel Plainview, the oilman, and Eli Sunday, the faith-healing preacher of the Church of the Third Revelation, who need and despise each other and whose rivalry ends in murder in the private bowling alley of Plainview's mansion. The Deacon is Plainview and Sunday fused in a single body — prophet and prospector, pulpit and derrick — and the fusion is the film's sharpest claim: that petro-modernity's religion and its economy were never two things.

The aesthetics of the Smokers' combustion have their manifesto. F. T. Marinetti's founding text of Futurism, printed on the front page of *Le Figaro* in February 1909, declared that a roaring automobile, which seems to run on machine-gun fire, is more beautiful than the Victory of Samothrace, and glorified war as the world's only hygiene. The comparison Marinetti chose is telling. The Nike of Samothrace, a Hellenistic marble of the winged goddess alighting upon the prow of a ship, is the classical emblem of maritime victory, and Marinetti dethroned it in favor of the internal-combustion engine. The Smokers complete

the substitution on the water itself. Their jet skis, gunboats, and seaplane are the Futurist automobile set loose upon the sea; their raids are war as hygiene; their crowds, roused by a microphone, are the great crowds stirred by work, pleasure, and revolt that the manifesto promised to sing. The Smokers are Futurism's afterlife: the cult of speed and combustion surviving the end of the roads.

Cara Daggett's concept of petro-masculinity (2018) names the affective bond between fossil fuels and authoritarian masculinity — the investment of a threatened and aggrieved masculinity in the burning of fuel as an assertion of mastery, and its hostility to the ecological limits that would curb the burning. The Smokers are petro-masculinity's paradigm: a horde of men on engines, ruled by a father-preacher, hostile to every limit, their highest pleasure the explosive consumption of fuel. George Miller's *Mad Max: Fury Road* (2015), co-written by Brendan McCarthy, whose *Freakwave* figures among *Waterworld*'s precursors, gave the type its definitive form in the War Boys: young men raised in a cult of the V8 engine, who spray their mouths with chrome before dying in glorious crashes and expect to ride eternal in Valhalla. Immortan Joe, their god-king, hoards both water and fuel, and in him the Atoll and the Deez are combined in a single tyranny. *Fury Road* is in this respect *Waterworld*'s sequel in all but name — the film in which the regimes of earth and fire, held apart in Reynolds's ocean, fuse into one Citadel.

Amitav Ghosh, reviewing Abdelrahman Munif's *Cities of Salt* in 1992, observed that the encounter between the West and the oil-producing world had generated almost no literature — that petroleum, for all its world-historical consequence, had remained nearly invisible to fiction — and coined the term "petrofiction" for the rare works that took it as their subject. *Waterworld*, released three years later, is among the most extravagant answers to Ghosh's complaint: a film whose antagonists are a church of oil. Stephanie LeMenager's *Living Oil* (2014) has since described the petromelancholia of a culture that grieves the passing of the oil age even as it continues to burn — an attachment to cars, plastics, and the forms of life oil made possible, mourned in advance of their loss. The Smokers are petromelancholia incarnate. They cling to the relics of oil modernity — cigarettes, canned meat, whiskey, a 1961 Lincoln — with the devotion of a people for whom the past is the only paradise they can imagine, and their eschatology is a return: the restoration of the oil age's conquest of the land.

3.6

Lebensraum on the Sea

Landnahme, Growth, and the Theology of Dryland

The Smokers' theology is, at bottom, a theology of land, and its occasion is demographic. The Deacon tells his captive that his parish is outgrowing the Deez; when the child suggests that they might simply have fewer people, he dismisses the idea out of hand (scene-by-scene guide). The exchange is the hinge of the film's political economy. The Atoll, as Chapter Two showed, fears depletion — too few, too closely related. The Smokers fear the opposite, and they refuse the remedy a finite world would impose. Their answer to overpopulation is not restraint but expansion: a new land to absorb the surplus. The Deacon's Dryland is the frontier as safety valve.

In Schmitt's terms, the Deacon's project is a *Landnahme*, the constitutive appropriation with which every new nomos begins. In the vocabulary of the German geographer Friedrich Ratzel, whose essay "Der Lebensraum" (1901) treated states as organisms requiring space in proportion to their growth, it is a demand for living space — a concept whose later career in the ideology of National Socialist expansion stands as a permanent warning against the innocence of biological metaphors in politics. The Deacon's sermon promises that the faithful will dominate Dryland (scene-by-scene guide), and the verb compresses the theology of Genesis 1:28 — "replenish the earth, and subdue it: and have dominion" — into a slogan. The Hebrew *kābaš*, rendered "subdue," carries a sense of forcible subjugation, and the Deacon's gospel restores to the dominion mandate the violence that centuries of stewardship theology had labored to soften.

John Locke's *Second Treatise of Government* (1689) furnished the modern *Landnahme* with its moral philosophy. Property, Locke argued, arises when a man mixes his labor with the common gifts of nature; land lying waste and uncultivated is open to appropriation by whoever will improve it; and the world in its original condition resembled the American wilderness — "in the beginning all the World was America" (§49). Locke's America is a land imagined as empty, awaiting the labor that will make it property, and the imagination of emptiness licensed the dispossession of the peoples who already lived there. The Deacon's Dryland is Locke's America restored: a land imagined as vacant and waiting, whose discovery

will entitle its discoverers to possess it. That the summit is not empty — that it holds a hut, two skeletons, and the evidence of a family's life — is precisely the fact the Lockean imagination is constituted to overlook.

Frederick Jackson Turner's frontier thesis (1893) gave that imagination its American historiography. "The existence of an area of free land, its continuous recession, and the advance of American settlement westward," Turner declared, "explain American development"; and the frontier, in the corollary his followers made famous, served as a safety valve, draining the discontents of the crowded East into the open West. Turner's address announced the frontier's closing on the evidence of the census of 1890, and the anxiety it voiced — what becomes of a democracy formed by free land when the free land is gone? — haunted the century that followed. The Deacon's congregation lives the Turnerian nightmare in its extreme form. Its frontier has not merely closed; it has drowned. Its crowded hull has no West to drain into. Dryland is the reopening of the frontier, and the Deacon's sermon is Turner's thesis converted into eschatology: free land as salvation.

The Smokers' refusal of limits places them on one side of the defining argument of late-twentieth-century environmental economics. *The Limits to Growth* (1972), the report commissioned by the Club of Rome and modeled by Donella Meadows, Dennis Meadows, and their colleagues at MIT, projected that the continuation of exponential growth in population, industrial output, and resource consumption on a finite planet would end in overshoot and collapse within the following century, and urged a deliberate transition to equilibrium; Herman Daly's steady-state economics proposed the institutions such an equilibrium would require. The report's critics answered that technology and new resources would always extend the limits — that there would always be another frontier. The Deacon is the critics' position made flesh. His answer to the exhaustion of the Pit and the crowding of the hull is not equilibrium but discovery: a new land whose existence is an article of faith. Boulding's cowboy economy, which Chapter Two set against the Atoll's spaceman economy, has found its preacher.

The Deacon's theology of land has a last and older source: the theology of discovery itself. The papal bulls of the fifteenth century, *Romanus Pontifex* (1455) and *Inter caetera* (1493), authorized Christian monarchs to claim lands not ruled by Christian princes, and their logic, absorbed into Anglo-American law as the doctrine of discovery — most consequentially in the United States Supreme Court's decision in *Johnson v. M'Intosh* (1823) — held that discovery by a Christian power conferred title to the land and reduced the rights of its inhabitants to mere occupancy. Columbus, sailing under this theology, believed on his third voyage that he

had come near the Terrestrial Paradise. The Deacon is the last discoverer: a preacher-captain who holds up a child as the key to a paradise he intends to subdue. Chapter Six argues that the film answers him not with a rival claim but with a refusal — that the one man able to find the land declines to claim it. Here it suffices to observe that the regime of fire and the doctrine of discovery share a premise: that land exists to be taken, and that taking it is a form of salvation.

3.7

Conclusion

The Flare

The fire regime ends as it lived, by combustion. The flare falls into the Pit; explosions tear through the hull; the congregation panics; the Deez begins to sink, its name legible at last on the stern as it goes down (scene-by-scene guide; PopApostle episode study). The Deacon, who clings to the rope of Gregor's balloon until Helen strikes him loose, survives the ship only to pursue the child across the water, and his end is self-inflicted. As he and two of his men race on jet skis toward Enola, shaken from the balloon into the sea, the Mariner snatches her from the surface on a bungee line, and the Smokers collide and perish in the explosion of their own machines (production record). The regime of fire is destroyed by fire, and the destruction is reflexive: the Smokers do not fall to an enemy so much as into one another. The cowboy economy, deprived of its frontier, burns itself out.

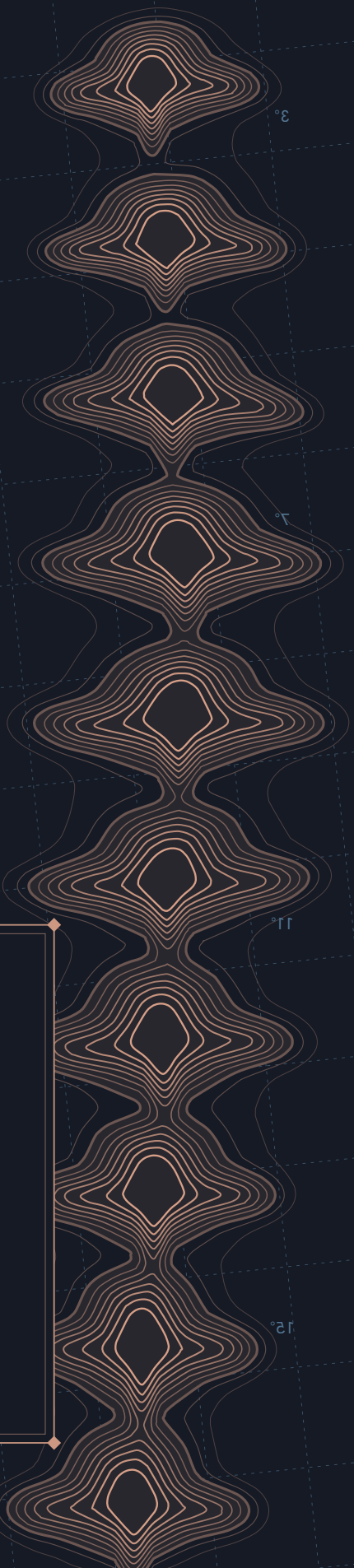
History supplies an uncanny gloss. In 1999, reflecting on the Coast Guard's decision to burn the fuel of another ship stranded off the Oregon coast, Joseph Hazelwood wondered whether it would have been better to set the *Exxon Valdez* ablaze than to let its oil wash ashore, and concluded that it would (Seattle Times, 1999). The film's climax, in which the *Valdez*'s last oil is ignited by a single flare, is the counterfactual its patron saint later endorsed. The saint, in the end, sided with the arsonist.

The image has a cosmological dimension. The Stoics taught that the cosmos is periodically consumed by fire — the *ekpyrōsis* — and reborn from it, and Seneca's *Natural Questions* (III.27–30), describing the destined deluge that will one day drown the world, treats flood and conflagration as the twin instruments by which nature ends and restarts its cycles; Plato's Egyptian priest, as Chapter One recalled, spoke of destructions by fire and by water alike. *Waterworld* stages both catastro-

phes, one inside the other: within the deluge that has drowned the earth burns a conflagration that consumes the last of the fire. The Heraclitean economy of B90, in which all things are exchanged for fire, reaches its final transaction when the fire is exchanged for water — the tanker's steel and its congregation sinking into the sea, beneath which, in the deep time of the planet, its fuel was first laid down. The smoke that rises from the Pit, like the smoke of the bottomless pit in Revelation, darkens the sky for a moment and is gone.

The fire regime's limit is not only that it burns out. It is that it cannot read. The Deacon's lieutenants, the Nord and the Doctor, labor over Enola's tattoo and fail; the Deacon conceals the failure behind a sermon (scene-by-scene guide). A regime whose relation to the earth is appropriation cannot decipher a text whose meaning is a home; a church that venerates the spill cannot read a map drawn by a dying family to deliver its child. The tattoo is read, in the end, by an inventor in a balloon, and the land is reached by a woman, a child, an enforcer, an inventor, and a fish-man — none of whom wishes to dominate it. The church of Saint Joe ends at the bottom of the sea it profaned.

Chapter Four turns, accordingly, from the regimes that would refound the land to those that would read it: to Gregor, the aeronaut and hermeneut whose balloon carries the film's only working knowledge, and to the inscription he deciphers — the map on Enola's back, and the theory of dorsal nomos it demands.



IV

AIR AND SKIN

Gregor's Balloon, Enola's Back, and the Theory of Dorsal Nomos

IV

And the dove came in to him in the evening; and, lo, in her mouth was an olive leaf pluckt off: so Noah knew that the waters were abated from off the earth.

— Genesis 8:11 (Authorized Version)

Though he block the land and the waves, the sky at least lies open: that way we shall go. Minos may possess all things; he does not possess the air.

— Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 8.185–87 (trans. mine)

There would be no point in announcing it to him. He learns it, after all, on his body.

— Franz Kafka, "In the Penal Colony" (1919) (trans. mine)

4.1

The Aeronaut

Gregor and the Genealogy of the Savant

Between the Atoll and the Deez, the regimes of earth and fire, *Waterworld* places a figure who belongs to neither: Gregor, the Atoll's resident engineer, played by Michael Jeter as an elderly enthusiast whose workshop occupies the top of a windmill and whose life's work is a balloon. He is the film's comic relief and its only scientist, and the two functions are not unrelated. Gregor is introduced laboring over a drawing of Enola's tattoo, convinced one moment that he has cracked it — is it a map, a calendar, a set of symbols, a language? — and cursing the heavens the next, when the solution collapses (scene-by-scene guide). When the Atoll cages the Mariner, Gregor visits by night, unable to suppress his giggles at the sight of a mutation, and bestows on the prisoner a Linnaean binomial, *Icthyo sapien* (PopApostle episode study). When the Smokers breach the walls, his prematurely inflated balloon carries him off alone, leaving Helen and Enola behind; when the trimaran burns, he finds the survivors by following its smoke; when the Mariner seizes Enola from the Deez, it is Gregor's balloon that lifts them clear; and it is Gregor, with a map and a sextant, who steers across the empty sea to Dryland (scene-by-scene guide).

Gregor is the regime of air, and his attributes are those the classical tradition assigned to that element: lightness, mobility, intellect, the capacity to see from above. Where the Atoll hoards the earth and the Smokers burn the fire, Gregor neither hoards nor burns; he rises. His is the only faction in the film that consists of a single person, and the only one whose relation to the land is neither possession nor conquest but knowledge. He wants to find Dryland, but what he wants from it, on the film's evidence, is the satisfaction of having been right — and fresh water, whose discovery on the summit sends him into raptures (plot summary).

His genealogy begins with Daedalus, the artificer of Greek myth, builder of the Cretan labyrinth and the first man to fly. Imprisoned with his son on the island of Minos, Daedalus reasons in Ovid's telling that though the king may close the land and the sea, the sky lies open; Minos may possess all things, but he does not possess the air. The verses, which supply this chapter's second epigraph, are the charter of the aeronautical regime. Gregor's balloon is a Daedalian escape from an island prison — the Atoll, walled against the sea and besieged by the Smokers — and it carries the same lesson: the air is the one element the regimes of earth and fire can-

not appropriate. Ovid's Daedalus also instructs his son to fly the middle course, since the sea's moisture will weigh down wings that fly too low and the sun's heat will melt the wax of wings that fly too high: *inter utrumque vola*, fly between the two (*Metamorphoses* 8.203–6). The aeronaut's path runs between water and fire, and Gregor's balloon, suspended between the Mariner's ocean and the Smokers' flames, keeps to it. Icarus, who flew too near the sun, fell into the sea that bears his name. Gregor, who flies low and slowly and laughs at himself, does not fall.

The early-modern savant supplies the next layer. Francis Bacon's *New Atlantis* (1627) opens with a ship lost and starving in the Pacific that comes upon an unknown island governed by a college of natural philosophers, Salomon's House, whose Father enumerates its works: furnaces, perspective-houses, sound-houses, engine-houses. "We imitate also flights of birds; we have some degrees of flying in the air. We have ships and boats for going under water, and brooking of seas." Bacon's utopia is a polity found by castaways on the open sea, whose sovereign is knowledge and whose instruments include both flight and submersion. Gregor is a Salomon's House of one, an institution of research reduced to a single eccentric in a windmill, and the film's quiet suggestion is that in the panthalassic world the Baconian program survives only as a private vocation, unsupported by any polity. The Atoll tolerates Gregor; it does not fund him. His balloon is built, like the Atoll itself, of salvage.

Jonathan Swift's satire of the Royal Society supplies the comic counter-image. The third voyage of *Gulliver's Travels* (1726) brings Gulliver to Laputa, a flying island of mathematicians and astronomers so absorbed in speculation that servants must rouse them with bladders, and thence to the Grand Academy of Lagado, where projectors labor to extract sunbeams from cucumbers and to reduce human excrement to its original food — the Atoll's recycling satirized two and a half centuries in advance. Gregor inherits the Laputan's absent-mindedness (he inflates his balloon too soon and departs without the passengers he meant to save) and the projector's devotion to improbable schemes. But Swift's flying scientists hover over a land they exploit, their king punishing rebellious towns by blocking their sun and rain or lowering the island upon them, whereas Gregor's balloon serves those below. The satire of science as domination becomes, in Gregor, an affectionate portrait of science as service.

The balloon itself has a precise history. The Montgolfier brothers flew the first public hot-air balloon at Annonay in June 1783, and that November Pilatre de Rozier and the Marquis d'Arlandes made the first manned free flight over Paris; within days Jacques Charles ascended in a balloon filled with hydrogen, the type of

the gas balloon Gregor flies (production record). Benjamin Franklin, who witnessed the Paris ascents, is reported to have answered a skeptic who asked what use a balloon might be by asking what use a newborn baby might be. The anecdote, whatever its authenticity, defines the epistemic status of Gregor's craft: the balloon is pure possibility, an instrument whose use has not yet been decided. Its decisive application came with photography. In 1858 Nadar — the photographer Gaspard-Félix Tournachon, whom Verne honored in the anagrammatic figure of Michel Ardan — made the first aerial photograph from a tethered balloon on the outskirts of Paris, inaugurating the view from above that would become, through the reconnaissance flights of the First World War and the satellite imagery of the late twentieth century, the dominant mode of modern cartographic power.

Verne gave the balloon its literary destiny, and his two balloon novels frame Gregor's function with remarkable precision. In *Five Weeks in a Balloon* (1863), Dr. Samuel Fergusson crosses Africa from east to west in a hydrogen balloon in order to link the routes of earlier explorers and fill in the blank spaces of the European map: the aerial view as an instrument of imperial cartography. In *The Mysterious Island* (1874–75), five Union prisoners escape the Confederate siege of Richmond in a balloon during a hurricane and are cast upon an uncharted Pacific island, where, under the direction of the engineer Cyrus Smith, they rebuild civilization from nothing, aided by an unseen benefactor who proves to be Captain Nemo, the self-exiled sovereign of the sea, sheltering with his *Nautilus* in a cavern beneath the island; at the end the island is destroyed by an eruption and sinks. The correspondences with *Waterworld* are structural rather than incidental: a balloon escape from a besieged city; landfall on an unknown island; a nameless benefactor from the sea who protects the castaways and declines to join them; and an island whose permanence is not guaranteed. Gregor is Cyrus Smith's comic heir, the engineer whose balloon carries the remnant of a besieged city to a new land. The Mariner is his Nemo.

Deleuze and Guattari's distinction between royal science and nomad or minor science names the epistemology Gregor practices. Royal science, the science of the State, seeks constant laws and axiomatic certainty; minor science follows problems rather than theorems, works with flows and turbulence, and proceeds by experiment, approximation, and bricolage, its paradigm a hydraulics that follows the water rather than confining it. Gregor's science is minor in exactly this sense — problematic, improvisatory, bound to material accident, as likely to fail comically as to succeed — and it begins where Plato and Aristotle said philosophy begins, in wonder (*thaumazein*: *Theaetetus* 155d; *Metaphysics* 982b). The Atoll responds to

the Mariner's gills with horror and condemns him; Gregor responds with delight and names him. The difference is that between a taxonomy that excludes and a taxonomy that marvels, and it is the condition of everything that follows. Only the one who wonders at the anomaly will be able to read the map.

4.2

The View from Above

Dove, Raven, Seagull, and Two Epistemologies of the Sea

Every flood narrative needs a bird. Utnapishtim releases a dove, a swallow, and a raven; the first two return, finding no place to perch, and the raven, finding the waters abated, does not. Noah sends forth a raven, which goes to and fro until the waters dry up, and then a dove, which returns the first time empty, the second time with an olive leaf in her beak — the sign, quoted as this chapter's first epigraph, by which Noah knew that the waters were abated (Genesis 8:11) — and the third time does not return at all. The bird is the flood's instrument of reconnaissance, the airborne sense-organ by which survivors in their vessel learn what they cannot see: that land has reappeared somewhere beyond the horizon. The Norse settlement tradition preserved the technique as history. The *Landnámabók*, the medieval Icelandic Book of Settlements, records that Flóki Vilgerðarson, sailing in search of the island, released three ravens: the first flew back toward the land he had left, the second circled and returned to the ship, and the third flew forward, and he followed it to Iceland — for which he was remembered as Hrafna-Flóki, Raven-Flóki. The book's title names the act its ravens served: *landnám*, land-taking, the Old Norse cognate of Schmitt's *Landnahme*. In this tradition the bird that finds the land is the herald of appropriation.

Waterworld reserves its bird for the final approach. After days aloft, with provisions failing, the Mariner wakes in the balloon's basket to find a seagull perched on its rail, and looks up to see a mountain rising through the clouds (scene-by-scene guide; plot summary). The gull is the film's dove, the sign that the waters have abated somewhere and the proof that the map is true. But the bird lands on the balloon rather than the balloon following the bird. In the flood tradition the vessel waits upon the water while the bird flies; in *Waterworld* the vessel itself flies, and the bird comes to it. The aeronautical regime has internalized the dove. Gregor's balloon is not a ship that sends out a bird but a bird that carries the ship's com-

pany — Noah's dove enlarged to bear the remnant of humanity in place of the olive leaf.

The view from above is the aeronautical regime's distinctive privilege, and its politics are ambivalent. Michel de Certeau, opening "Walking in the City" (*The Practice of Everyday Life*, 1980) from the top floor of the World Trade Center, described the pleasure of the totalizing gaze that transforms the city into a legible text and its viewer into a kind of solar eye, a voyeur-god, and opposed to it the practices of the walkers below, whose itineraries escape the panorama. Donna Haraway's "Situated Knowledges" (1988) named the same pretension "the god trick": the fantasy of seeing everything from nowhere, an objectivity purchased by the denial of the observer's embodiment. Verne's Fergusson practiced the god trick over Africa. Gregor does not. His balloon is precarious, slow, crowded, and comic; his knowledge is assembled from the Mariner's salvaged magazines, Helen's testimony, and Enola's memories; and his view from above discloses nothing, because over a panthalassic ocean there is nothing to see. The aerial gaze, which over land converts territory into map, yields over the open sea only a uniform blue. This is the deep reason the map must be written on a body and in numbers. Where the earth has no features, location can be expressed only abstractly, as coordinates, and the coordinates must be carried by someone.

The history of those coordinates is the history of the sea's striation. Ptolemy's *Geography* (c. 150 CE) gave the ancient world its grid of latitude and longitude; latitude could be read from the stars, but longitude at sea defeated navigators for centuries, until the British Longitude Act of 1714 offered a prize for its solution and the clockmaker John Harrison answered with a sequence of marine chronometers perfected in the 1760s. Dava Sobel's *Longitude*, which made Harrison's story a bestseller, appeared in 1995, the year of *Waterworld*'s release. Deleuze and Guattari treat the determination of longitude as a decisive moment in the State's striation of the sea: the conversion of a smooth space of winds, currents, and stars into a gridded space of measurable positions. Enola's tattoo belongs to this history. It is a grid reference, a pair of coordinates — the film's fans have even reported that its characters can be read as numbers close to the latitude and longitude of Everest (PopApostle episode study) — and its decipherment requires the instruments of the striated sea, a map and a sextant.

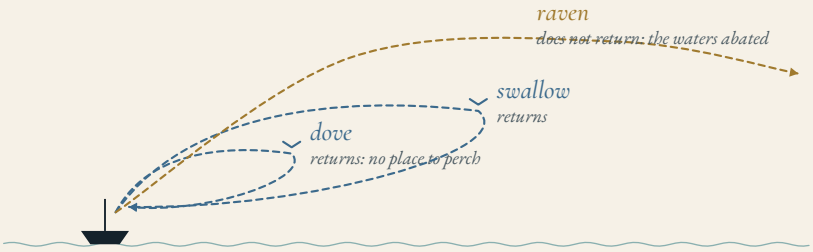
Against this epistemology the Pacific developed another, which the film's own setting places within reach. The navigators of Micronesia and Polynesia crossed thousands of miles of open ocean without instruments, reading the rising and setting points of stars, the patterns of swells refracted by unseen islands, the flight of

FIGURE 6

Birds of the Flood

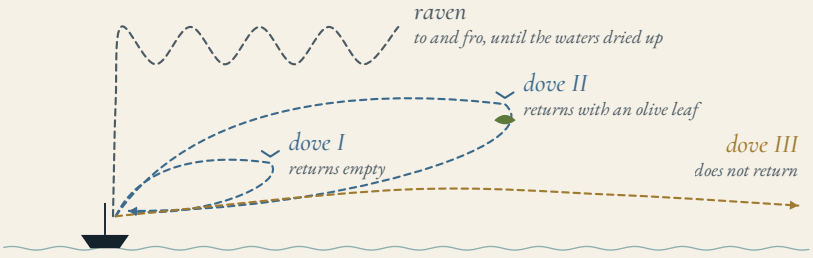
Gilgamesh XI

Utnapishtim, on Mount Nimush



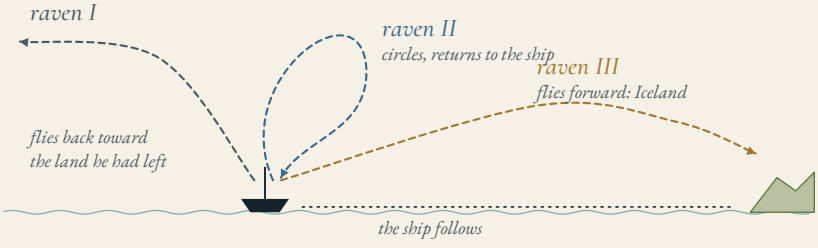
Genesis 8

Noah, in the ark



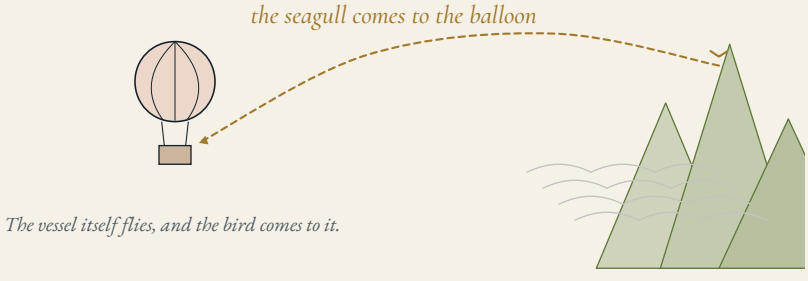
Landnámabók

Flóki Vilgerðarson, in search of the island



Waterworld

Gregor's balloon, after days aloft



The bird as the flood's instrument of reconnaissance (§4.2): Utnapishtim's dove, swallow and raven; Noah's raven and dove; the three ravens of Hrafna-Flóki; and the seagull that comes to Gregor's balloon.

land-nesting birds at dawn and dusk, and the color of clouds over distant lagoons. Thomas Gladwin's *East Is a Big Bird* (1970) and David Lewis's *We, the Navigators* (1972) documented these techniques as they survived in the Caroline Islands, and in 1976 the Micronesian navigator Mau Piailug guided the voyaging canoe *Hōkūleʻa* from Hawaiʻi to Tahiti by them alone. Central to Carolinian navigation is the conceptual system called *etak*, in which the canoe is imagined as stationary while the islands move: a reference island, out of sight below the horizon, is conceived as sliding backward beneath a sequence of star-points as the voyage proceeds. In the etak system it is the land that travels and the vessel that stays. Helen, after the trimaran burns and her faith in Dryland has been shaken, muses on the possibility of a Dryland that moves (scene-by-scene guide). The idea, which the film treats as a symptom of her despair, is in the Oceanic tradition a sophisticated navigational truth. Two epistemologies of the sea thus meet in the film without acknowledging each other: the Ptolemaic grid, by which Gregor reads the tattoo, and the relational knowledge of the wayfinder, by which the Mariner lives. The first locates the land. The second never needed to.

The tattoo joins the two epistemologies in a single object. Its medium is Oceanic — the English word "tattoo" derives from the Polynesian *tatau*, recorded during Cook's first Pacific voyage — while its content, according to the fans who have deciphered its characters, is a Ptolemaic grid written in a Chinese script. The map to the last land is a hybrid of the world's maritime traditions: a Pacific technique of inscription bearing a Eurasian technique of location. The next section follows Gregor from the possession of these coordinates to the moment of reading them, and finds that the land can be reached only by turning the world upside down.

4.3

Reading Reversed

Decipherment, Mirror-Writing, and the World Turned Upside Down

Gregor's decipherment arrives in two stages, and its key is inversion. Before the assault on the Deez he tells the Mariner that the numbers are upside down (scene-by-scene guide); after Enola's rescue he identifies the tattoo as coordinates whose directions are reversed (production record), and sets the balloon's course accordingly. The map has been legible all along to anyone willing to turn it

over. Its unreadability was a property not of the inscription but of the reader's orientation. And the girl who bears it is named, as more than one commentator has noticed, by a reversal: Enola is "alone" read backward. The film's two mirror-writings, the name and the map, face each other across the child's body. Her name, read forward, is solitude; read backward, it is a person. Her map, read forward, is nonsense; read backward, it is the way home.

Decipherment has a heroic history, and Gregor belongs to its comic branch. Jean-François Champollion, who announced his reading of the Egyptian hieroglyphs in 1822, is said to have rushed into his brother's office crying that he had it and then collapsed; Michael Ventris, the architect who deciphered the Mycenaean script Linear B in 1952, was an amateur who overturned the experts' conviction that its language could not be Greek. Decipherment is the triumph of the outsider who refuses an inherited orientation. Gregor's breakthrough is of this kind. The Smokers' Doctor and the Nord have stared at the tattoo the right way up and failed; the Atoll's lone engineer succeeds because he is willing to read against the grain — literally, upside down.

The most resonant precedent lies on the island where Reynolds made his previous picture. Rapa Nui possesses the only indigenous script known from Oceania, *rongorongo*, inscribed on a few dozen wooden tablets and objects and still undeciphered. Its glyphs are written in reverse boustrophedon: alternate lines stand upside down, so that the reader must rotate the tablet through a half-turn at the end of each line. To read rongorongo is to turn the text over, again and again; its sense is available only to a reader willing to invert his orientation at the end of every line. Whether or not anyone involved in *Waterworld* had rongorongo in mind, the film's map belongs to the same Oceanic grammar of inscription. The knowledge of how to read the tablets was lost after the slave raids and epidemics that devastated the island's population in the 1860s; the readers died, and the writing outlived them. Enola's map is a rongorongo tablet in flesh: an inscription whose authors are dead and whose reading requires the reader to turn the world over.

Mirror-writing has its own philosophical history. Leonardo da Vinci kept his notebooks in a script that runs from right to left and is most easily read in a mirror; whatever its motive, it made his private knowledge legible only through a reflecting surface. Jacques Lacan's account of the mirror stage (1936; 1949) holds that the infant first assembles its identity from its reflection, an external image the child jubilantly assumes as its own, so that the self is constituted from the outset outside itself, in an image it can see. The back is the one region of the body the mirror

stage never captures. No single mirror shows it; to see one's own back requires a second mirror reflecting the first — a reversal of a reversal. Gregor's decipherment is that second mirror. The tattoo's directions are written inverted, as if seen in a glass, and the reader who turns them back restores what a single reflection reversed. Enola, who can never see her map, depends for its meaning on a double reflection performed by someone else.

The convention that north lies at the top of the map is younger and more arbitrary than it appears. Medieval *mappae mundi* placed east at the top, where the Earthly Paradise lay — the Hereford map of about 1300 sets Eden on a ringed island at the eastern summit of the world — and the very word "orientation" preserves the practice of turning a map toward the Orient. In 1943 the Uruguayan painter Joaquín Torres-García drew South America upside down, its southern tip at the top, declaring that for the artists of the Americas the south must serve as north: an act of cartographic decolonization that refused the hemisphere's place at the bottom of a European picture of the world. Stuart McArthur's south-up *Universal Corrective Map of the World* (1979) made the same refusal from Australia. Enola's map belongs to this lineage of inversion. To find the land one must turn the inherited picture of the world upside down — which, in a film that opens by drowning a Hollywood studio's corporate globe, has the force of a methodological principle. The way to Dryland is not found by reading the old map more carefully but by reorienting it.

The world turned upside down has both a cosmological and a political pedigree, and the film touches both. In Plato's *Statesman* (268e–274e), the Eleatic Stranger tells a myth in which the cosmos periodically reverses its rotation; in the reversed age the ordinary sequence of life runs backward, the old grow young, and a race of earth-born humans rises from the ground — autochthony as the sign of a world turned around. Some viewers have read Gregor's reversed coordinates as evidence that the planet's poles have flipped, a catastrophe that would explain the flood (plot summary); the film does not confirm the reading, but it accords with the Platonic association of cosmic reversal with catastrophe and autochthony. The political pedigree runs through the English Revolution, whose radical sects Christopher Hill gathered under the title *The World Turned Upside Down* (1972), after a ballad of the 1640s. Among them were Gerrard Winstanley's Diggers, who in 1649 began to cultivate the common land of St George's Hill in Surrey, proclaiming that the earth had been made a common treasury for all, beasts and men alike. The world turned upside down, in this tradition, is a world in which the land

ceases to be property. Chapter Six argues that this is precisely the world the Mariner's departure leaves behind on Dryland.

4.4

The Map on the Back

The Theory of Dorsal Nomos

What, then, is written on Enola? The film supplies the facts sparingly. Enola drifted into the Atoll as an infant, Helen tells the Mariner, and Helen has protected her ever since at personal cost (scene-by-scene guide). She cannot swim, and with the crayons she finds aboard the trimaran she draws trees, horses, and other things no one in the drowned world has seen (PopApostle episode study; production record). Across her back runs a tattoo of symbols and numerals that the Atoll whispers is a map to Dryland. At the summit, in the hut where the skeletons of her parents lie hand in hand, the travelers find a table covered with tattooing implements and papers bearing the same symbols as her back (PopApostle episode study; plot summary). The meaning of the scene is unmistakable. Enola's parents, dying on the last land, wrote its location on their daughter's body and, the film implies, set her adrift on the sea. The map is their testament.

The structure is Mosaic. In Exodus 2:3 the infant Moses is placed by his mother in an ark of bulrushes and set among the reeds of the Nile; the Hebrew word for that basket, *tēḇāh*, occurs elsewhere in scripture only as the name of Noah's ark. The child set adrift to survive a catastrophe is a one-person ark, and Enola is such a child, a vessel launched by parents who could not themselves be saved. But the Mosaic parallel extends to the law. Moses receives the covenant on "tables of stone, written with the finger of God" (Exodus 31:18). The prophets imagine a second inscription: "I will put my law in their inward parts, and write it in their hearts" (Jeremiah 31:33). And Paul calls the community to which he writes "our epistle written in our hearts, known and read of all men … written not with ink, but with the Spirit of the living God; not in tables of stone, but in fleshy tables of the heart" (2 Corinthians 3:2–3). The history of covenantal inscription passes from stone to heart, from an external law to an internal one. *Waterworld* adds a third term the tradition did not foresee. Enola's law is written neither on stone nor on the heart but on the skin — on the outer surface of the body, and on the one region of that surface its bearer cannot see. Like Paul's epistle, it is known and read

of all men; unlike Paul's, it is not read by the one who bears it. This is the inscription this dissertation calls dorsal nomos.

Dorsal nomos may now be defined with precision. It is an inscription of the land's law — its location, and with it the possibility of its appropriation — borne on a living body rather than on the earth, because the earth that would bear it has been drowned. It is placed on the back, the surface the bearer cannot read, and is therefore legible only through another, which makes the bearer dependent on interpretation and exposes her to capture, since whoever reads her back possesses the land. It is authored by the dead, whose last act it records. And it is at once a gift and a danger. Each of these features has a genealogy, and the genealogies converge on Enola.

The oldest precedent is a stratagem recorded by Herodotus (5.35). Histiaeus of Miletus, detained at the Persian court and wishing to urge his son-in-law Aristagoras to revolt, shaved the head of his most trusted slave, pricked a message into his scalp, waited for the hair to grow back, and sent him to Miletus with instructions that Aristagoras should shave the man's head and look. The message was the signal for the Ionian Revolt. The slave carried on his own body a text he could not see, whose meaning — rebellion — was destined for another, and whose delivery depended on his remaining ignorant of it. Herodotus's slave is dorsal nomos in its political form: a body made into a medium, a bearer conscripted into a history he cannot read.

Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" gives the structure its juridical form. The apparatus of the colony's former commandant consists of a Bed, on which the condemned man lies face down; a Designer, which holds the pattern of the sentence; and a Harrow, whose needles write the sentence into his back over twelve hours. The condemned is never told his sentence. As the officer explains in the words quoted as this chapter's third epigraph, he learns it on his body, deciphering the script through his wounds; about the sixth hour, the officer insists, understanding dawns even on the dullest. When the visiting explorer declines to endorse the apparatus, the officer frees the prisoner, sets the injunction *Be just!* in the Designer, and places himself beneath the Harrow, which malfunctions and kills him without enlightenment. Kafka's harrow is a tattoo machine of the law, and its victim, like Enola, bears on his back a text inscribed by others that he can read only through suffering. The difference is the content. Kafka's needles write a commandment; the needles on the table in the hut on Dryland wrote a way home. Dorsal nomos is the harrow turned to love — and yet it retains the harrow's structure, for the child

who carries the way home is pursued, abducted, held up before a cheering horde, and nearly drowned because of what her parents wrote.

Melville's Queequeg gives dorsal nomos its cosmological form. His tattoos, the work of a prophet of his island, record "a complete theory of the heavens and the earth, and a mystical treatise on the art of attaining truth," yet their mysteries "not even himself could read" (*Moby-Dick*, ch. 110). Believing himself dying, Queequeg has a coffin made and carves the designs of his skin upon its lid; he recovers, and the coffin, caulked and sealed, becomes the *Pequod*'s life-buoy, which at the novel's end rises from the vortex of the sinking ship to bear up Ishmael, the sole survivor. The inscription outlives the body that bore it and becomes the vessel of survival. Enola's parents are Queequeg's carvers: their knowledge, transferred from their failing bodies to the surface of their child, becomes the buoy that carries the survivors to land.

Polynesian tattooing supplies dorsal nomos with its political anthropology. Alfred Gell's *Wrapping in Images* (1993) read Polynesian *tatau* as a technique of wrapping the body in protective images, closing it against sacred danger while binding it into hierarchies of rank and genealogy; tattoo, on this analysis, is a political technology, a writing of the social order onto skin. The colonial history of the Pacific gave the technology an unforeseen function. In Aotearoa New Zealand, when missionaries and traders sought written title to Māori land, rangatira signed the deeds by drawing their *tā moko*, the facial tattoos that recorded their genealogy and authority. The practice was first noted by Samuel Marsden in 1815 and became common in the 1830s, as land transactions accelerated, in agreements whose compensation, the archivists of the Hocken Collections observe, was trivial beside the value of the land conveyed (Hocken Collections). The tattoo, the inscription of identity and authority on skin, became the signature by which land was alienated. Here dorsal nomos appears in its historical form: the body's inscription transferred to a document of title, the skin's authority converted into an instrument of dispossession. Enola's tattoo condenses this history. It is a moko turned outward toward the land, an inscription of origin that, once read by others, becomes a title to be seized.

Two traditions introduced in Chapter One complete the genealogy. In the Turtle Island cosmogony the earth is spread upon a back, and in Ovid the stones that become humanity are thrown behind the back: the world and its people both originate dorsally, in the direction the actor cannot see. And Marcel Mauss observed, in a short essay of 1924, that the Germanic word *Gift* signifies both a present and a poison — the double edge of every gift, which binds as it gives.

Enola's tattoo is a gift in both senses. It gives her the land and makes her a target; it is her parents' love and the cause of her abduction; it is the means of the remnant's salvation and the object of the Deacon's desire. The double nature of dorsal nomos, remedy and poison at once, is the subject of the next section.

4.5

Archive Fever

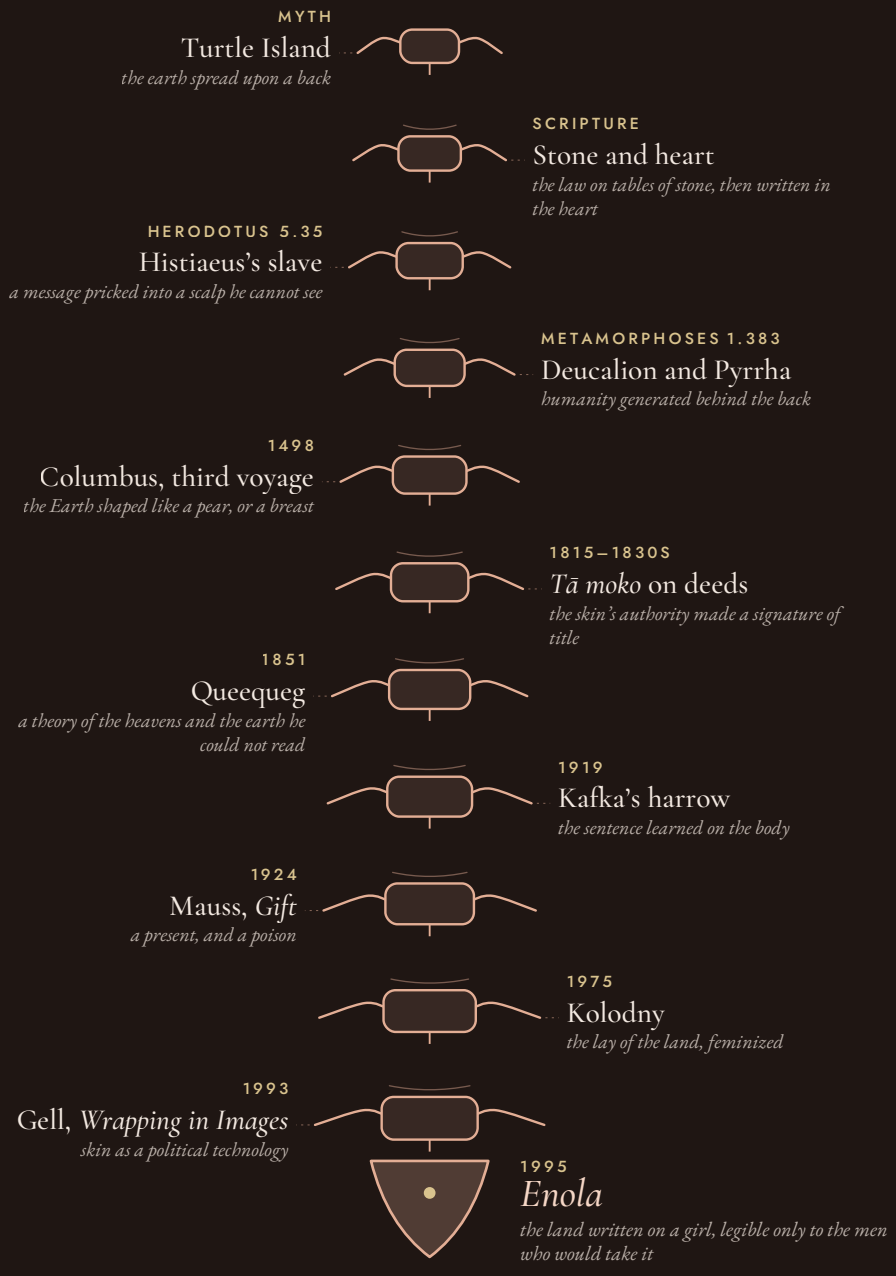
Memory, Pharmakon, and the Body as Lieu de Mémoire

Enola bears two inscriptions, and the film distinguishes them with care. The first is the tattoo, written on her back by others, which she cannot see. The second is her drawings, made with her own hand in crayon on the surfaces of the Mariner's boat, depicting things she remembers from the land where she was born (scene-by-scene guide). The tattoo is a code; the drawings are images. The tattoo is law; the drawings are memory. The tattoo is read by Gregor, the drawings by the Mariner, who first rages at the child for defacing his boat and later, sifting the wreckage of the burned trimaran, finds the drawings, compares them with the photographs in his salvaged *National Geographic* magazines, and realizes that she has seen what they depict (production record; scene-by-scene guide). The film's two hermeneuts divide the child's two texts between them: the scientist decodes her inscription; the sea-man recognizes her memory.

The distinction is as old as Western reflection on writing. In Plato's *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), Socrates tells of the Egyptian god Theuth, who offered King Thamus the invention of letters as a *pharmakon*, a drug, for memory and wisdom, and of the king's reply: that writing would produce forgetfulness in the souls of those who learned it, since they would trust to external marks rather than remember from within; that it was a drug not of memory (*mnēmē*) but of reminding (*hypomnēsis*). Jacques Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) drew out the ambivalence of the word: *pharmakon* means both remedy and poison, and writing, the supplement that preserves memory by externalizing it, endangers the living memory it serves. Enola carries both terms of Thamus's distinction on a single body. Her drawings are *mnēmē* — recollection from within, partial, childlike, and true. Her tattoo is *hypomnēsis* — an external mark written by others, exact and unreadable to her. The two must be joined for the land to be found. Gregor's decoding of the coordinates is confirmed only when the travelers arrive and Enola, winding a music

FIGURE 7

A Genealogy of Dorsal Nomos



Inscriptions borne on a surface the bearer cannot read, from cosmogony to the film (§1.6, §4.4).

box she finds in the hut, declares that she is home (PopApostle episode study). The memory authenticates the map.

The film multiplies its archives. The Mariner hoards salvaged magazines, in which he looks up words he does not know — "pity," at one point — and photographs of a world he has never seen (scene-by-scene guide). The half-mad drifter who trades with him prizes paper above everything, paying with a few pages of a salvaged magazine for half an hour with Helen (PopApostle episode study; scene-by-scene guide). The hut on the summit holds papers inscribed with the tattoo's symbols, and a music box whose pinned cylinder — a drum studded with metal points that pluck a comb as it turns — is itself an inscription in relief, a mechanical memory of a melody. The pins of the cylinder and the needles on the tattooist's table are kindred technologies: both fix a sequence on a surface by puncture, to be read later by a mechanism or a person. In a world where nothing on the water can be engraved, every surviving archive is portable and most are fragile. Enola's skin is the most durable of them, and the only one that walks.

Pierre Nora's distinction between *milieux de mémoire* and *lieux de mémoire* (1984–92) names Enola's function. Real environments of memory, in Nora's account, are the settings in which a community lived its past as present: the village, the ritual calendar, the gesture handed down. Sites of memory arise when those environments have vanished, as deliberate supports for a memory that no longer sustains itself — archives, monuments, commemorations. The drowned world has lost its supreme *milieu de mémoire*, the land itself, and the Atollers, as Chapter Two showed, have forgotten even the flood. Enola is the land's *lieu de mémoire*: a site of memory that walks, a monument inscribed on a child. And like every *lieu de mémoire*, she is invested with a significance that exceeds and distorts the life she lives. The Deacon's congregation hails her as salvation; residents of the Atoll prepare to do her harm (scene-by-scene guide); the Mariner, at first, would throw her overboard. The site of memory becomes the site of contest.

Derrida's *Archive Fever* (*Mal d'archive*), published in 1995, the year of the film's release, supplies the final term. The Greek *arkheion*, Derrida observes, was the house of the archons, the magistrates who held and interpreted the documents of the law, and *arkhē* names both commencement and commandment, the origin and the order. The archive is where beginning and law coincide. Enola's back is an archive in exactly this double sense: it records her origin, where she was born, and it commands the way, where the land is. Derrida's archive fever is the compulsive, repetitive, nostalgic desire to return to the origin, a desire inseparable, in his reading of Freud, from the death drive that destroys the archive even as it institutes it.

The Deacon's pursuit of Enola is archive fever in its most violent form, a burning desire to possess the origin that consumes the very church that pursues it. And it is telling that Derrida's book circles, through Freud, around circumcision, a mark of the covenant inscribed on the body — an archive in the flesh. The film and the treatise, appearing in the same year, converge on the same figure: the body as the last archive of a law whose ground has been lost.

The skin as archive has both a psychoanalytic theory and a popular iconography. Didier Anzieu's *The Skin-Ego* (1985) argued that the ego is first constituted on the model of the body's surface: the skin contains, protects, individuates, and records, and among its psychic functions is that of a surface on which the traces of early experience are inscribed. Enola's skin-ego carries an alien text — her parents' knowledge, written on her body before she could consent or remember — and her psychic envelope is, in the most literal sense, a map of the world. The iconography of the inscribed body extends from Ray Bradbury's *The Illustrated Man* (1951), whose living tattoos enact stories and, in one empty patch of skin, show the viewer his own future, through Christopher Nolan's *Memento* (2000), whose amnesiac protagonist tattoos his investigation onto his body because he cannot form new memories, to the television series *Prison Break* (2005–09), whose hero tattoos the plan of a prison over his torso in order to escape it. Each is a variation on dorsal nomos: the skin as prophecy, as prosthetic memory, as escape map. *Waterworld* combines all three. Enola's tattoo is a prophecy that the land exists, a memory of where it lies, and a map by which to escape the sea.

4.6

Who May Read?

Testimony, Territory, and the Ethics of Interpretation

Every reader of Enola's back in *Waterworld* wants something from it, and the film ranks them by motive. The Atoll's residents, who see in the tattoo a curse that draws the Smokers, would rather be rid of the child than read her. The Smokers want her for her map: the Nord and the Doctor labor over the tattoo, and the Deacon, questioning her in his quarters, offers her first a cigarette and then a marker — the fire regime's sacrament, and then an instrument of writing, as if the child might be induced to draw the way herself (scene-by-scene guide). Gregor wants the solution for its own sake, and the fresh water at the end of it. Helen

wants the land as a future for the child and for herself. And the Mariner, who could read her as well as anyone, wants for most of the film nothing from her at all; when he finally reads her, it is her drawings he reads, not her back.

This ranking can be described in the vocabulary of twentieth-century hermeneutics. Hans-Georg Gadamer's *Truth and Method* (1960) described understanding as a fusion of horizons, in which the interpreter's prejudices are put at risk by the claim of the text; Paul Ricoeur, in *Freud and Philosophy* (1965), set against this hermeneutics of faith a hermeneutics of suspicion, practiced by Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud, which reads every text for what it conceals. The Deacon practices neither. His is a hermeneutics of extraction, which seeks in the text only the resource it contains and treats the text's bearer as a container to be opened. Gregor practices a hermeneutics of wonder: he is changed by what he reads, and he reads in alliance with others, with the Mariner's magazines and Helen's testimony. The film's judgment is plain. The extractive reading fails, and the reading in wonder succeeds.

The most neglected reader of Enola is Enola. She insists that she has seen Dryland; she tells the Deacon that the tattoo is the way there, while admitting she does not know how to decipher it (scene-by-scene guide); she draws its trees and horses from memory. No one believes her until the Mariner matches her drawings with his photographs. Miranda Fricker's *Epistemic Injustice* (2007) named the wrong done to such a speaker: testimonial injustice, in which a hearer assigns a speaker less credibility than she deserves because of prejudice about the kind of person she is — here, a child, and a girl. The film's adults commit this injustice again and again, and it is notable that the one adult who credits her, Helen, has herself been disbelieved as a Cassandra by the Atoll's assembly. Enola is, moreover, the film's sharpest political mind. Told by the Deacon that his parish is outgrowing its tanker, she proposes, with a child's directness, that they have fewer people — the very solution the whole apparatus of the fire regime exists to refuse (scene-by-scene guide). She taunts the Nord with a myth of the Mariner's invulnerability, explaining that he has no name so that Death cannot find him (PopApostle episode study) — a theology of anonymity that Chapter Five takes seriously. The child who cannot read her own back reads her captors with ease.

The danger to which dorsal nomos exposes its bearer is gendered, and the American critical tradition has given it a name. Annette Kolodny's *The Lay of the Land* (1975) traced through American letters, from colonial promotional tracts to the pastoral novel, the persistent figuration of the landscape as a woman — mother, virgin, bride — whose possession was the settler's masculine fantasy and

whose violation was the guilty underside of the pastoral dream. Anne McClintock's *Imperial Leather* (1995), published the year of the film, opened its account of colonial discourse with Columbus's conjecture, in the letter on his third voyage, that the earth was shaped like a breast with the Earthly Paradise at its nipple, and named the imagined geography of feminized and sexualized lands the "porno-tropics." Enola is the land made female in the most literal way the tradition could devise: a girl on whose body the paradise is mapped. The Deacon's interest in her is the colonist's interest in virgin land, at once cartographic and predatory, seeking in the female body the route to a territory. That the film's hero, like Kolodny's dissenting pastoralists, refuses to treat her body as territory is the ground of its ethics. That the film nonetheless constructs her body as the map is the limit of its imagination.

The child as bearer of the future is a figure recent theory has subjected to scrutiny. Lee Edelman's *No Future* (2004) diagnosed in Western political discourse a "reproductive futurism" that organizes politics around the image of the Child, emblem of a future in whose name the present is governed and its dissidents disciplined. *Waterworld* literalizes the figure: the future is not merely embodied in the child but written on her. Alfonso Cuarón's *Children of Men* (2006), in which a world without births is redeemed by a single infant carried out to sea toward a ship named *Tomorrow*, would make the same equation a decade later, and with the same ambivalence. Enola's tattoo makes her the Child of reproductive futurism in its purest form, and the film's achievement, modest but real, is to give that Child a voice of her own — a capacity for mockery, refusal, and political judgment that the symbolic burden placed upon her never wholly absorbs.

Who, then, may read? The film's answer is implicit in the alliance that reaches the land. A reading is legitimate when it is undertaken in the bearer's interest, in alliance with her own testimony, and without the intention of possessing what is read. Gregor reads Enola's back to bring her home; the Mariner reads her drawings to understand her; neither seeks title. The question the film cannot resolve — that her parents inscribed a child's body without her consent, with a permanent mark that made her a target — is the question of all inheritance, since every child is written upon by the languages, names, debts, and laws of those who came before. Dorsal nomos makes visible on a single body the condition of every inheritor: to carry, on the side one cannot see, a text written by the dead and read by the living. What the film proposes is not an escape from that condition but a discipline for those who read: to read in wonder and in alliance, and to deliver rather than to possess.

4.7

Conclusion

The Last Field

The regime of air, alone among the film's regimes, succeeds. Gregor's balloon escapes the Atoll the Smokers destroy; it rescues the survivors of the burned trimaran; it lifts Enola from the sinking Deez; it carries the remnant to Dryland. Its success has a reason. The air is the element the other regimes cannot possess, and the aeronaut is the figure who has renounced possession in favor of knowledge. But the air regime does not succeed alone. Gregor's science depends on the Mariner's magazines, Helen's testimony, and Enola's memory, and his balloon requires the Mariner's plunge on a bungee line to recover the child who falls from it. The air regime is a regime of alliance, and its triumph is the triumph of a coalition that the earth regime excluded and the fire regime hunted.

The skin, the fifth term, has yielded the dissertation's governing concept, and its relation to Schmitt's nomos can now be stated. Schmitt derived the nomos of the earth from a triad of acts — appropriation, division, and production; to take, to divide, to pasture. Dorsal nomos substitutes another triad. In place of appropriation, *inscription*: the land is not taken but written, by those who lived on it, onto the body of one who will survive them. In place of division, *interpretation*: the land is not parceled out but read, by others, on behalf of the one who bears it. In place of production, *delivery*: the land is not worked for profit but reached, by a coalition that carries the bearer home. The panthalassic condition does not abolish nomos; it transforms its grammar. Where the earth cannot be engraved, the law of the earth survives as a text on skin, and its fulfillment requires not a conqueror but a courier.

The transformation is not innocent. Dorsal nomos is the law of the dead, authored by the parents and borne by the child, and Hegel's reading of *Antigone* in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) set the law of the family and its dead — the divine law of the household and the grave — against the human law of the city and the state. Antigone buries her brother against Creon's edict; at the summit, the Atoll's Enforcer proposes to bury Enola's parents in the earth. The law written on Enola's back is the household's law, the law of a family and its dead, and its antagonist is the Deacon's would-be state. In the drowned world the divine law of the

family has become the only law that can locate the land, and the human law of the would-be sovereign can only seize it. That the family's law nearly destroys the child it was meant to save is the tragedy dorsal nomos never escapes: the inscription that delivers is also the inscription that exposes.

The map on Enola's back is, in the end, the last field of the earth: the only surface in the drowned world on which the land can still be written, furrowed, and read. It is a field no one can plough, and for that reason it cannot be enclosed; but it can be captured, and the film's middle act is the story of its capture and recovery. When the travelers reach the summit and Enola declares herself home, the inscription has done its work, and the field has returned to the earth it described. What remains is the question of what the deliverer will do once the land is reached — whether he will settle it, found an order upon it, or leave.

That question belongs to the element the dissertation has so far approached only from outside. Chapter Five turns to water, and to the body that needs no map: the Mariner, whose gills, webbed feet, and closed circuit of filtered water constitute the film's most radical answer to the panthalassic condition — an answer that does not seek the land at all.

V

WATER

The Mariner, the Gill, and the Thalassal Body

V

O happy living things! no tongue / Their beauty might declare: / A spring of love gushed from my heart, / And I blessed them unaware.

— Samuel Taylor Coleridge, *The Rime of the Ancient Mariner* (text of 1834), Part IV

MOBILIS IN MOBILI

— Jules Verne, *Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea* (1870), the device of the *Nautilus*

It is the image of the ungraspable phantom of life; and this is the key to it all.

— Herman Melville, *Moby-Dick* (1851), ch. 1

5.1

Mobilis in Mobili

The Mariner as No-One

The Mariner has no name, and the film makes the absence a doctrine. When Helen asks his name, he answers that he has no need of one (scene-by-scene guide); when the Nord demands it of Enola aboard the Deez, she explains that he has no name, so that Death cannot find him (PopApostle episode study). Only in the extended version, at the last parting, does Helen give him one, telling him the story of Ulysses and making the name his to use among the people he will meet (scene-by-scene guide). Until then he is identified solely by his relation to the element: he is the one who goes to sea. The anonymity places him in a lineage of nameless heroes of the water that is among the oldest in Western narrative.

Its founder is Odysseus, who, trapped in the Cyclops's cave, gives his name as *Outis*, No-one, so that when the blinded Polyphemus cries out that No-one is killing him, his brothers conclude he suffers a sickness sent by the gods and leave him be (*Odyssey* 9.366–414). The pseudonym is an instrument of *mētis*, the cunning intelligence that is Odysseus's signature, and it saves him by making him unlocatable. Jules Verne's Captain Nemo, whose Latin name means "no one," inherits the trick as a mode of existence: a man who has renounced every national, legal, and familial identity to live beneath the sea in a vessel of his own design, and who tells his captive Professor Aronnax that the sea does not belong to despots — that on its surface men still fight and enslave one another, but a few fathoms down their power ceases, and there alone he is free. The emblem of the *Nautilus*, an N set within the motto *Mobilis in mobili*, "moving within the moving," is the device of a sovereignty founded not on territory but on motion. And Coleridge's Ancient Mariner, whose title the film borrows, is likewise known only by his relation to the sea and to his crime upon it. Enola's theology of anonymity — no name, so Death cannot find him — gathers these figures into a single idea: to be unnamed is to be unappropriable, beyond the reach of every power that works by naming, registering, and locating.

The Western supplied the nameless hero with his twentieth-century form, and the Mariner draws on it directly. Sergio Leone's "Dollars" trilogy (1964–66) made Clint Eastwood's Man with No Name the archetype of a figure without past, property, or loyalty, who drifts into a community at war with itself, sells his vio-

lence to both sides, and rides away; George Stevens's *Shane* (1953), whose drifter defends the homesteaders and departs while a boy calls after him, supplied the shape of the Mariner's bond with Enola. The Mariner's namelessness thus fuses two traditions. From Homer and Verne it takes the namelessness of the sea, which cannot be engraved and therefore cannot register a name; from the Western it takes the namelessness of the frontier, where the drifter's anonymity marks his exteriority to the settled order he serves. Chapter Six follows the second lineage to its ending in a doorway. This chapter follows the first into the body.

The intelligence the Mariner exercises is the one Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant reconstructed in *Cunning Intelligence in Greek Culture and Society* (*Les Ruses de l'intelligence: la mètis des Grecs*, 1974). *Mētis* is the practical, oblique, adaptive intelligence of the hunter, the fisherman, the navigator, and the politician: the intelligence of those who must act in shifting, ambiguous, fluid situations that cannot be mastered by fixed rules. Its emblems are the octopus and the cuttlefish, which change color and shape and vanish in their own ink, and its domain is above all the sea, where no path persists and every crossing must be improvised. It is Odysseus's intelligence, and it is the Mariner's. He reads the weather and predicts rain; he anticipates the habits of the creature that swallows him; he detects, by a slick of oil on the water, the Smokers' ambush concealed behind a trading post of propped-up corpses (scene-by-scene guide); and he survives each encounter by transformation rather than force. Where Gregor's minor science works with abstractions — coordinates, hypotheses — the Mariner's *mētis* works with the immediate and the particular. The film needs both: the scientist to read the map, and the man of *mētis* to survive the sea long enough for the map to be read.

Mētis has a material form in the film, and it is the trimaran. The production built two versions of a sixty-foot racing trimaran designed by Marc Van Peteghem and Vincent Lauriot-Prevost: a conventional racer for distance shots, which exceeded thirty knots in trials, and a transforming version for close work, which began as a raft topped by a three-bladed "egg-beater" wind turbine and, at the pull of a lever, flattened its blades, raised a concealed mast to full height, extended a hidden boom, and unfurled its sails (production record). The Mariner's boat changes shape: it is an octopus in fiberglass. Within it is a world of salvaged devices — the hand-pumped still that purifies his urine, the winch and timer that haul him up from his dives, the harpoon guns, a wind-powered player for salvaged music, the drawers of magazines from which he learns words, and a small lime tree whose fruit would have protected the sailors of the age of sail from scurvy (PopApostle episode study; scene-by-scene guide). The trimaran is Nemo's *Nautilus* rebuilt by

a *bricoleur*: a self-sufficient world in motion, independent of every port. *Mobilis in mobili*.

The film's debt to Coleridge goes beyond the epithet. The Ancient Mariner shoots the albatross, the bird of good omen, and brings a curse upon his ship; becalmed upon a rotting sea, he is redeemed only when, watching the water-snakes coil in the moonlight, a spring of love gushes from his heart and he blesses them unaware — the moment quoted as this chapter's first epigraph. Costner's Mariner undergoes the same conversion in reverse. He needs no instruction to love the creatures of the sea; it is the humans aboard his boat he cannot love. His albatrosses are his passengers. He heaves Helen's child overboard in a rage when she will not stop provoking him; he hacks off Helen's hair after the seaplane's attack; he eats his only tomato before their starving eyes; he bargains Helen's body to a drifter for a few sheets of paper before breaking off the deal (scene-by-scene guide). His redemption comes when, unaware, he begins to bless them: teaching Enola to swim, letting Helen drink her fill when he knows that rain is coming, giving Helen his breath beneath the burning wreck. The Ancient Mariner learns to love the sea's creatures as kin; the Mariner learns to love human beings as if they were the sea's creatures. Both conversions dissolve the line between the human and the marine, from opposite sides.

5.2

The Gill

Mutation, Hybridity, and the Posthuman Body

The Mariner's body announces a new kind. Behind his ears, where skull meets neck, open the slits of gills; his toes are webbed; he swims faster and dives deeper than any human and breathes beneath the surface as long as he pleases. The Atollers call him a muto, a mutation, as though such things had been seen before; Gregor gives him a taxonomic name (PopApostle episode study). The placement of the gills is anatomically suggestive. In the human embryo a series of pharyngeal arches forms in the region of the neck — structures homologous to the gill arches of fish — and develops into parts of the jaw, the small bones of the middle ear, and the larynx. The paleontologist Neil Shubin, whose team described the transitional fish-tetrapod *Tiktaalik* in 2006, made the point the title of a popular book, *Your*

Inner Fish (2008). The Mariner's gills, opening beside the ear, are not an alien graft but an atavism made functional: the inner fish turned outward.

Nineteenth-century biology dramatized this kinship in a famous and misleading formula. Ernst Haeckel's biogenetic law (1866) held that ontogeny recapitulates phylogeny — that the embryo passes through the adult forms of its ancestors, including, in the vertebrate case, a fish-like stage with gill slits. Embryologists abandoned the law in its strong form, but its cultural afterlife was immense: it underwrote Ferenczi's *Thalassa*, examined below, and it haunts every fiction in which a human body remembers the sea. The Mariner is recapitulation run forward. Haeckel's embryo passes through the fish on its way to the human; the Mariner has passed through the human on his way back to the fish.

As evolution, the Mariner is impossible. Production material dates the film's action to about the year 2500 (production record), which allows perhaps twenty or twenty-five human generations since the flood — nowhere near the span natural selection would require to equip a terrestrial mammal with functional gills. The impossibility is of a piece with the film's hydrology and invites the same reclassification: the gill is a mythic sign before it is a biological one. The 1997 sequel comic *Children of Leviathan* sought to rationalize it by hinting that the Mariner's mutation was engineered rather than evolved (production record), a hint that aligns him with the redesigned posthumans of earlier speculative fiction — Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930), whose eighteen successive human species include several deliberately remade for new planetary conditions. But the film itself declines to explain, and its silence matters. The Mariner's body is presented not as a technology but as a given, a fact of the new world as unquestionable as the sea.

Two earlier speculations frame that body. The first is the aquatic ape hypothesis, proposed by the marine biologist Alister Hardy in 1960 and championed for decades by the writer Elaine Morgan in *The Descent of Woman* (1972), *The Aquatic Ape* (1982), and later books, which argued that human hairlessness, subcutaneous fat, bipedalism, and voluntary breath control were adaptations to a semi-aquatic phase of hominid evolution. Mainstream paleoanthropology has not accepted it, but its cultural force lay in its narrative, which placed the sea at the origin of the human and, in Morgan's version, displaced the masculine myth of Man the Hunter with a story in which mothers and children wading in the shallows drove human evolution. The second is Kurt Vonnegut's *Galápagos* (1985), in which a handful of tourists stranded on a Galápagos island, after a global financial collapse and an epidemic of infertility, become over a million years the ancestors of a new humanity — small-brained, furred, flippered creatures who fish in the sea and are

happy, because the big brains that caused every human catastrophe have been selected away. *Waterworld* stands between the two. Like Hardy and Morgan, it imagines a human body remade by water; like Vonnegut, it imagines the remaking as the sequel to a catastrophe of humanity's own authorship. But the Mariner keeps his big brain. He is the aquatic human who has retained *mētis*, and the question his body poses is not whether humans can return to the sea but whether they can do so without ceasing to be the kind of creature that could found — or refuse to found — a world.

The Mariner belongs, finally, to a lineage of fish-men older than biology. Berossus, the Babylonian priest who wrote a history of his people in Greek in the third century BCE, recorded the tradition of Oannes, a creature with the body of a fish, a human head beneath the fish's head, and human feet joined to its tail, who emerged from the Erythraean Sea in the first age of the world and taught humanity letters, sciences, and arts of every kind — the founding of cities and temples, the making of laws, geometry, agriculture — returning each night into the sea. In the Mesopotamian tradition the fish-man is the civilizer, the amphibious mediator who brings culture out of the deep and goes back to it. The modern fish-man reversed his valence. Bill Everett's Namor the Sub-Mariner (1939), half-human and half-Atlantean, later styled Marvel's first mutant, was born hostile to a surface world that invaded and polluted his kingdom; Universal's own *Creature from the Black Lagoon* (1954) made the Gill-man a monster of the Amazon, desiring a woman and hunted to his destruction. *Waterworld*, from the studio that created the Gill-man, completes the inversion by making the gilled man the hero and the land-dwellers the monsters. Guillermo del Toro's *The Shape of Water* (2017), in which a captive amphibian god is rescued by a mute cleaning woman — herself a foundling, discovered as an infant beside a river with scars on her neck that open into gills when he carries her into the water at the end — takes the inversion to its romantic conclusion. And Mike Mignola's Abe Sapien, first catalogued in the *Hellboy* comics as an *Icthyo sapien*, offers a possible source for Gregor's binomial (PopApostle episode study). The Mariner is Oannes without the curriculum: the fish-man who brings a remnant to the land, teaches a child to swim, and returns to the sea.

Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) gives this hybridity its political theory. The cyborg, Haraway argued, is a creature of three broken boundaries — between human and animal, between organism and machine, between the physical and the non-physical — and its political promise lies in its refusal of the origin stories that have grounded Western identity, above all the story of a lost organic

wholeness to which one might return. The Mariner is a cyborg of the sea: human and fish, organism and apparatus, his body extended by the still that recycles his water, the winch that hauls him up, the transforming hull that carries him. He too lacks an origin story. The film never says where he came from, and the extended version's naming, at the very end, gives him a name drawn from a story not his own. The Atoll's horror is the boundary-keeper's horror before the cyborg; Gregor's delight is the scientist's recognition of a new kind. The Mariner, until the end, refuses both responses and simply lives as what he is.

5.3

The Real Sea-Nomads

Bajau, Moken, and Homo aquaticus

The Mariner's body has an empirical horizon the film could not have known. In 2018 a team led by Melissa Ilardo reported in *Cell* the first genetic adaptation to diving identified in any human population. The Bajau, the "Sea Nomads" dispersed among the islands of Indonesia, Malaysia, and the Philippines, traditionally lived on boats and harvested nearly everything they ate from the sea; some spend as much as sixty percent of a working day diving, to depths beyond seventy metres, with nothing but a wooden mask, and linguistic evidence suggests they have lived this way for more than a thousand years — a chronicler of Magellan's expedition recorded their way of life in 1521 (Sci.News report). Ultrasound scans showed that the Bajau have a median spleen half again as large as that of their land-dwelling neighbors, the Saluan, in non-divers as well as divers, and genetic analysis linked the difference to a variant of the gene *PDE10A*, thought to regulate thyroid hormone. The spleen matters because it is an organ of the human dive response: when the body is submerged, the heart slows, the vessels of the limbs constrict to reserve blood for the vital organs, and the spleen contracts, releasing a store of oxygenated red cells into circulation (Sci.News report). The Bajau have, in effect, evolved a larger oxygen tank.

The Bajau are not alone. The Moken of the Andaman Sea, another sea-nomad people, became known to science when a 2003 study found that their children see roughly twice as sharply underwater as European children, by constricting their pupils and accommodating their lenses in ways most people cannot; later work showed that European children could acquire the same skill with training, so that

the advantage proved to be practice rather than heredity (Sci.News report). The *haenyeo*, the women divers of Jeju Island in South Korea, have harvested the seabed without breathing apparatus for generations. These peoples demonstrate what the film's premise intuits and its biology exaggerates: that human bodies do bend toward the sea — by training within a lifetime and by selection across generations — when a people's livelihood is staked upon it. The Mariner's gills are an impossibility. His spleen would not be.

They also confirm the political meaning the film assigns to the aquatic body. In *The Art of Not Being Governed* (2009), James C. Scott described the hill peoples of the Southeast Asian massif, the region he called Zomia, as societies that had for centuries placed themselves beyond the reach of lowland states, adopting mobile livelihoods, flexible kinship, and oral cultures that resisted registration and taxation; the sea nomads of the archipelagos, he noted, played the same role on the water. The Bajau have lived for centuries at the margins of sultanates and colonial regimes, and many who live on boats today remain without citizenship. The sea nomad is the state's perennial outsider: unregistered, untaxed, unsettled. The Mariner, whom the Atoll condemns and the Smokers hunt, is a sea nomad of this kind, and his body is the somatic form of his statelessness. To breathe water is to be beyond the census.

The twentieth century also dreamed of making the aquatic human by design. In 1962, at the World Congress on Underwater Activities in London, Jacques Cousteau announced the coming of *Homo aquaticus*, a human species to be deliberately adapted, through technological intervention and eventually through natural adaptation, to live beneath the sea — a project summed up in the phrase, recorded by his biographer and taken by the historian Helen Rozwadowski as the title of her study, of bringing humanity full circle back into the sea (Rozwadowski 2022). Cousteau's Conshelf experiments of the early 1960s housed divers for weeks in habitats on the floor of the Mediterranean and the Red Sea, and the press of the period carried earnest speculation about implanted artificial gills. As Rozwadowski shows, the vision belonged to the optimistic postwar project of exploiting the ocean as a new frontier, and its later versions, in an age of environmental anxiety, have shrunk to a hope for mere survival (Rozwadowski 2022). *Waterworld* stands at the hinge of that shift. Its Mariner is Cousteau's *Homo aquaticus* realized — not as the triumphant colonist of the ocean frontier but as the survivor of a catastrophe, a figure in whom the dream of mastering the sea has become the necessity of living in it.

A more mystical version of the same dream shaped the decade before the film. The French freediver Jacques Mayol, the first to descend to a hundred metres on a single breath, in 1976, set out in *Homo Delphinus* (1983) a vision of the human as a latent marine mammal whose dormant aquatic capacities — the dive reflex, the tolerance of pressure, the kinship with dolphins — might be awakened by discipline and contemplation. Luc Besson's *Le Grand Bleu* (*The Big Blue*, 1988), loosely based on Mayol's rivalry with the Italian diver Enzo Maiorca, ends with its hero at the bottom of the sea letting go of the line that would return him to the surface, and to the pregnant woman who has begged him to stay, and swimming into the dark with a dolphin. The ending, released seven years before *Waterworld*, is the Mariner's ending in its regressive form: the man of the sea abandons the woman and the unborn child for the element. *Waterworld* revises it. The Mariner leaves too, but only after the child has been delivered and the woman brought ashore; his departure is not a surrender to the deep but a refusal of the land. Chapter Six argues that the difference is the whole difference between regression and ethics.

The Mariner's aquatic body was, finally, itself a composite. Many of his water scenes were performed by Laird Hamilton, the big-wave surfer then helping to pioneer tow-in surfing, in which riders are pulled by personal watercraft onto waves too large to paddle into; Hamilton, the production record notes, commuted to the set by jet ski (production record). The film's emblem of the body attuned to the sea was played in part by an athlete whose art depended on the Smokers' machine. The irony is instructive. There is no pure thalassal body in the Anthropocene ocean, only bodies more or less entangled with the machines and fuels of the land — which is why the question the Mariner poses is not whether a human can live in the sea, but how.

5.4

The Closed Circuit

Urine, Breath, and the Somatic Economy

The Mariner's body is an economy before it is a self. The film's first sequence shows him urinating into the still, pumping, and drinking; spitting the dregs onto his lime tree; diving with a timer that trips the winch to haul him up; trading with a drifter under what the film calls the code, by which every encounter must yield an exchange; and splitting the mast of a drifter who has stolen his limes,

leaving the thief to his fate (scene-by-scene guide). The principle of this economy, which he states to the drifter, is that nothing in his world is free (PopApostle episode study). The body that recycles its own water is the perfect subject of a regime of exchange. It needs nothing it cannot produce or buy, owes nothing to anyone, and gives nothing away.

The closed circuit has its literary prototype in the Fremen stillsuit of Herbert's *Dune*, which reclaims the body's water from sweat and urine so that a person may cross the desert drinking only what he has already drunk; on Arrakis, to spit before another is a mark of honor, a gift of the body's water. *Waterworld* inverts the desert's ethic. In the ocean world the Mariner's spit goes to his lime tree, the body's water given not to a person but to a plant. Psychoanalysis supplies a darker gloss. Ferenczi's *Thalassa*, examined below, opens with an analysis of the "amphimixis" of urethral and anal tendencies — the drives to release and to retain — in the genesis of genital sexuality, and the Mariner's apparatus reads as the triumph of retention: a body that releases nothing, that converts even its urine back into itself. His sexual refusals belong to the same economy. He declines the Atoll's request that he father a child, and he refuses Helen when she offers her body in exchange for passage (scene-by-scene guide). The closed circuit admits no exchange it does not control.

Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* distinguished the market exchange of equivalents from the archaic economy of the gift, in which giving creates obligation and binds the parties into a lasting relation; the gift, unlike the purchase, cannot be closed. The Mariner's arc is the passage from the one economy to the other, and its turning points are a sequence of gifts that escape the logic of equivalence. He kills the creature that swallowed him and shares its flesh. Knowing that rain will fall that night, he lets Helen drink her fill. At dawn he teaches Enola to swim, transmitting to a land-born child the competence that is his body's secret (scene-by-scene guide). None of these acts is paid for. Each opens the closed circuit a little further, and each binds him to people he had once bargained over as goods.

The decisive gift is breath. When the Smokers seize the trimaran and Helen and the Mariner dive to escape their gunfire, Helen runs out of air beneath the surface, and the Mariner, who can breathe the water, presses his mouth to hers and breathes for her while the trimaran burns overhead (scene-by-scene guide). The scene is the film's most intimate and its most theological. Peter Sloterdijk's *Bubbles* (1998), the first volume of his *Spheres* trilogy, begins its microspherology of human intimacy with the creation of Adam in Genesis 2:7, when the Lord God breathes into the nostrils of the figure of clay the breath of life; the primal human relation,

Sloterdijk argues, is pneumatic, a sharing of breath within an enclosed space of intimacy — a bubble. Beneath the burning trimaran the Mariner and Helen form such a bubble: two bodies, one breath, enclosed in the element that would kill one of them. The jury-rigged diving bell in which he earlier lowered her to see the drowned city held air enough for only one; now the bell is his body, and the air is shared. The closed circuit of the still, which recycled one body's water for itself, has become the open circuit of the kiss, in which one body's capacity is given to another. The economy of the Mariner's body has changed its sign.

The open circuit has a theory. The Pacific scholar Teresia Teaiwa liked to observe that because we sweat and cry salt water, we know that the ocean is really in our blood — a formulation that dissolves the boundary between body and sea into a shared chemistry. Astrida Neimanis's *Bodies of Water: Posthuman Feminist Phenomenology* (2017) developed the insight into a hydrofeminist ethics: human bodies are watery bodies, constituted by and leaking into the waters that pass through them and linked by hydrological cycles to every other body of water, so that the bounded, self-contained individual is a fiction that watery embodiment refutes. Read through Neimanis, the Mariner's still is a technology of denial, an attempt to make a watery body self-contained by recycling its water so as to owe nothing to any other body; his conversion is the discovery of what his body always was, a body of water among bodies of water, whose breath can become another's. Stacy Alaimo's trans-corporeality (*Bodily Natures*, 2010), the material interchange through which bodies are always already enmeshed with environments and with one another, names the same discovery. The gills that seemed to make the Mariner independent of every other human prove to be the organ by which he keeps another human alive.

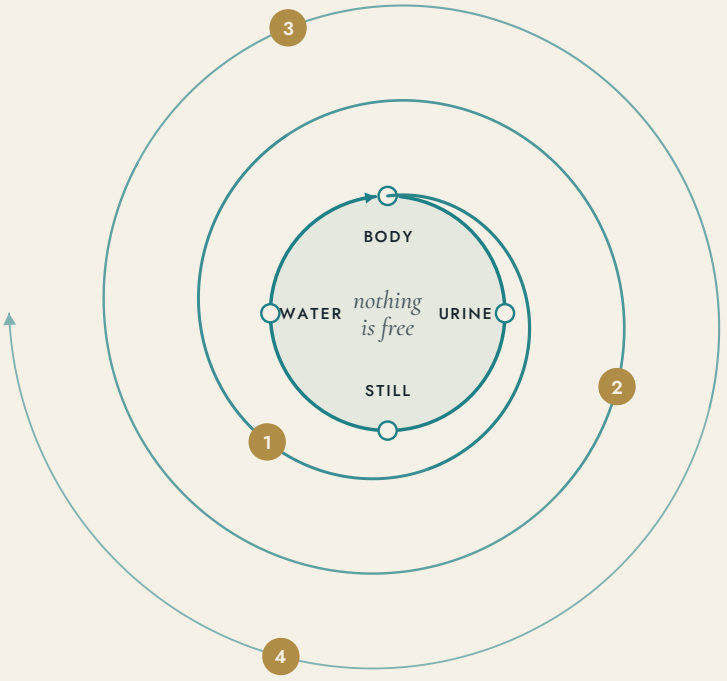
The film's opening image answered Coleridge's paradox — water everywhere, and not a drop to drink — with a technology of self-enclosure. Its middle answers it with a gift. The Mariner gives Helen the one thing more fundamental than water, the breath that water cannot supply to a human body, and so resolves the paradox in its other register. The Ancient Mariner's curse was a thirst the sea mocked, and his release came with rain, after he had blessed the creatures of the deep; *Waterworld*'s Mariner, too, foresees the rain that ends Helen's thirst. Poem and film share an ethical structure. The sea's mockery of human need is overcome not by technology but by love, and love begins as a gift that breaks the circuit of self-sufficiency.

FIGURE 8

Closed Circuit, Open Circuit

THE CLOSED CIRCUIT

the still



THE OPEN CIRCUIT

the gift, which cannot be closed

THE GIFTS

1. ***Flesh shared***
   he kills the creature that swallowed him and shares its flesh
2. ***Water given***
   knowing that rain will fall, he lets Helen drink her fill
3. ***Swimming taught***
   at dawn he teaches Enola to swim
4. ***Breath given***
   beneath the burning trimaran he breathes for Helen

The economy of the Mariner's body has changed its sign.

The Mariner's somatic economy (§5.4): the still that recycles one body's water for itself, and the gifts, none of them paid for, that open it.

5.5

Thalassa

Regression, the Oceanic Feeling, and the Return to the Sea

Sándor Ferenczi's *Thalassa: A Theory of Genitality* (*Versuch einer Genitaltheorie*, 1924) is the most audacious attempt in the psychoanalytic tradition to think the human relation to the sea, and it is this dissertation's principal key to the Mariner's body. Ferenczi, extending Haeckel's biogenetic law from the embryo to the drives, proposed what he called bioanalysis: the reading of present sexual life as the recapitulation of the species' remotest history. Life began in the sea; a geological catastrophe, the drying of the primeval oceans, forced certain creatures onto land; and the trauma of that exile, Ferenczi argued, is preserved in the organism's deepest tendency, a thalassal regressive trend that strives to restore the lost marine existence. The mammalian womb, with its amniotic fluid, is an internalized ocean in which the embryo relives the aquatic phase of life; birth repeats the primal catastrophe of desiccation; and coitus, in which the male partially and symbolically returns to the maternal body, is the adult's attempt to regain the sea. The drives, on this account, are oceanic at the root.

Waterworld reverses Ferenczi's primal catastrophe. Where he imagined the drying of the oceans as the trauma that drove life onto land, the film imagines the return of the oceans over the land — desiccation undone on a planetary scale. Its world fulfills the thalassal trend: the earth itself has regressed into the sea. And the Mariner is the trend embodied, a human in whom the internalized ocean has been externalized again, his body readapted to the element from which, in Ferenczi's myth, the species was exiled. Had the film ended with the Mariner diving into the deep and never surfacing, it would have been a Ferenczian fable without remainder. It does not end so. The question is what the film makes of the thalassal trend once it has realized it.

Freud, Ferenczi's teacher and correspondent, approached the same ground from another side. In the opening chapter of *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) he answered a letter from Romain Rolland, who had located the true source of religious sentiment in a feeling of eternity, of something limitless and unbounded — an "oceanic" feeling. Freud confessed that he could not find the feeling in himself and traced it to a residue of the infant's primary narcissism,

before the ego has separated itself from the external world; the oceanic feeling, on this reading, is a memory of undifferentiated unity that religion exploits as consolation. The Mariner is not oceanic in Rolland's sense. His relation to the sea is not a feeling of boundless unity but a practice of competence, *mētis* rather than mysticism; he is the least sentimental of men. His solitude at sea is hostile rather than ecstatic: he has made the ocean his element precisely in order to be separate from others. The film's paradox is that the most thalassal of bodies houses the least oceanic of souls — until the bubble of shared breath beneath the trimaran gives him, for an instant, the only oceanic feeling the film endorses: the dissolution of the boundary not between self and sea but between self and another.

The literature of the thalassal return is vast, and two of its registers bear directly on the Mariner. Algernon Charles Swinburne gave it its erotic and maternal form in "The Triumph of Time" (1866): "I will go back to the great sweet mother, / Mother and lover of men, the sea." Bachelard, who read Swinburne closely in *Water and Dreams*, found in his poetry of swimming a "Swinburne complex" — the swimmer's masochistic joy in the sea's blows, the struggle with the waves as an ecstasy of will. James Joyce opened *Ulysses* (1922) with Buck Mulligan quoting the line on the parapet of the Martello tower and naming the sea of Dublin Bay a great sweet mother — and Ulysses is the name Helen gives the Mariner at the end of the extended version. The coincidence resonates. Joyce's Ulysses is a modern Odysseus whose odyssey is a single day's wandering through a city, ending in a homecoming to a bed and a wife; the film's Ulysses ends by leaving the home he has found. Between Swinburne's return to the mother-sea and Joyce's return to Penelope, the Mariner chooses neither.

The other register of the thalassal return is death. Kate Chopin's *The Awakening* (1899) ends with Edna Pontellier, having refused the roles of wife and mother, swimming out into the Gulf of Mexico until her strength fails; the novel's sea speaks throughout in a voice "inviting the soul to wander for a spell in abysses of solitude," and Edna's last swim is at once liberation and suicide. Lovecraft's Innsmouth narrator resolves to swim out to the reef and descend to the city of the Deep Ones; Ballard's Kerans walks south into the drowned jungle toward a sun that will destroy him; Besson's diver lets go of the line. In each case the thalassal return is a dissolution of the self — into freedom, monstrosity, prehistory, or the deep — and in each it is undertaken alone, as a severance from human bonds. The Mariner's return differs on both counts. It is not a dissolution: he departs in a boat, provisioned, toward a destination he intends to find. And it is not a severance: it

follows, and depends upon, the completion of a bond. He goes back to the sea only after he has delivered those he came to love.

This is the point at which thalassal regression becomes thalassal ethics. Ferenczi's trend is a drive toward undifferentiation, a longing to dissolve the separated self back into the maternal sea. The Mariner's return is its opposite. It is a choice, made by a self that has become more distinct rather than less through its bonds with others, and it is a choice about the land rather than about the sea. He does not leave because the sea calls him back to the womb; he leaves because he will not take the land. The thalassal body, which in Ferenczi's myth is the vehicle of regression, becomes in *Waterworld* the vehicle of renunciation. What the trend sought as a return to origin, the ethic accomplishes as a refusal of possession. The next section asks what that refusal looks like from the Pacific whose waters the film borrowed — and whether a white American star is the right body to perform it.

5.6

A Sea of Islands

The Pacific, the Multihull, and the Whiteness of the Wayfinder

Epeli Hau'ofa's "Our Sea of Islands" (1993), written in Fiji two years before *Waterworld*'s release, is the decisive text for judging the film's oceanic imagination. Hau'ofa contrasted two ways of seeing Oceania. The first, inherited from the continental colonial powers and their economists, saw islands in a far sea: small, scattered, resource-poor territories, isolated by the ocean and condemned to dependency. The second, the view of the islanders' ancestors and of their mobile descendants, saw a sea of islands: a vast and connected world in which the ocean was not a barrier but a highway, traversed by voyagers who reckoned their homeland not by the dry land they occupied but by the expanse of water across which their kin, trade, and histories extended. Smallness, Hau'ofa argued, was a state of mind imposed by a colonial cartography of land.

Waterworld stages both views and takes sides. The Atoll is the colonial view internalized: a community that experiences the ocean as isolation and threat, walls itself against it, measures its wealth in hoarded soil, and dies of its smallness. The Mariner is Hau'ofa's voyager. For him the sea is not the absence of land but the medium of life, a road along which he trades, dives, harvests, and moves; he does not need land to have a world. The Smokers represent a third view, the extractive

one, which regards the ocean as a void to be crossed in pursuit of territory. In the panthalassic world, where all land has been subtracted, Hau'ofa's distinction becomes total. A people that sees itself as islands in a far sea has no islands left; only a people able to see a sea of islands — or a sea without them — can live.

The film's oceanic imagination is materially indebted to the Pacific in ways its narrative never acknowledges. The multihull is an Austronesian and Oceanic invention. The outrigger canoe and the double-hulled voyaging canoe — the *wa'a kaulua* of Hawai'i, the *drua* of Fiji, the *vaka* of Polynesia — carried the settlers of the remote Pacific across thousands of miles of open ocean centuries before European ships entered those waters; the English word "catamaran" comes from the Tamil *kattumaram*, a raft of tied logs; and the modern racing trimaran descends from twentieth-century Western adaptations of these designs. The Mariner's trimaran, built in France for an American studio, is a high-technology descendant of Oceanic boatbuilding. And at the film's end the Mariner departs from Dryland in an old wooden catamaran found on the island (production record): a double-hulled vessel of the kind the Polynesian Voyaging Society's *Hōkūle'a* revived in the mid-1970s, sailing from the shore of a valley that Hawaiian tradition associates with its chiefs. The film's last image restores, without naming it, the Pacific voyaging canoe.

The restoration comes at a cost the film does not reckon. Its wayfinder — the body that knows the sea, the hero of the sea of islands — is played by a white American star at the height of his celebrity, in waters whose own voyagers had spent the preceding two decades reviving navigational arts that colonial rule and missionary disapproval had nearly extinguished. The score first commissioned for the film was, by the production's own account, rejected as too ethnic and too bleak (production record), and replaced by an orchestral adventure score in the Hollywood manner. The Pacific supplied the film's waters, the lineage of its multihulls, the technique of its central inscription, its valley of kings, and its cosmogonic resonances; its principal roles went to Americans of European descent, and its sea of islands is peopled, in its leading figures, by heirs of the continental powers Hau'ofa wrote against. *Rapa Nui*, Reynolds's previous film, had already been faulted by some critics for telling an Easter Island story with leads who were not Rapa Nui. The pattern is consistent: the oceanic imagination of these films is Pacific in its materials and American in its protagonists.

Disney's *Moana* (2016) offers an instructive counterpoint. Developed in consultation with an Oceanic advisory group and voiced largely by actors of Pacific descent, it tells of a chief's daughter who discovers that her people were voyagers,

recovers the fleet of double-hulled canoes her ancestors had hidden away, and learns wayfinding in order to restore the heart of an island goddess. *Moana* makes the revival of voyaging its story; *Waterworld* makes it an unacknowledged backdrop. Yet the two films share a structure. In each the ocean is a living medium rather than a void, the hero's competence is a relational knowledge of wind and current, and the restoration of the land depends on a voyage. Read together, they suggest what *Waterworld* might have been had its sea of islands been imagined from the islands.

Teaiwa's dictum, quoted in the previous section, was itself a correction of continental thinking: a Pacific scholar's insistence that the ocean is not outside the islander but within. The Mariner's body, which literalizes the ocean within, thus enacts a Pacific idea in an American frame, and the concept of thalassal ethics that this dissertation proposes owes a debt that must be acknowledged here. The refusal of land as property, the inhabitation of the sea as a road and a relation, the reckoning of a homeland by water rather than by territory — these are not inventions of Western philosophy, which has more often theorized the sea as the land's other, but the inheritance of Oceanic peoples whose voyaging the film borrows without credit. If the Mariner's departure is an ethical act, its grammar was written by the navigators of the sea of islands. Chapter Seven returns to this debt in the present, where the sea of islands faces the rising ocean the film imagined.

5.7

Conclusion

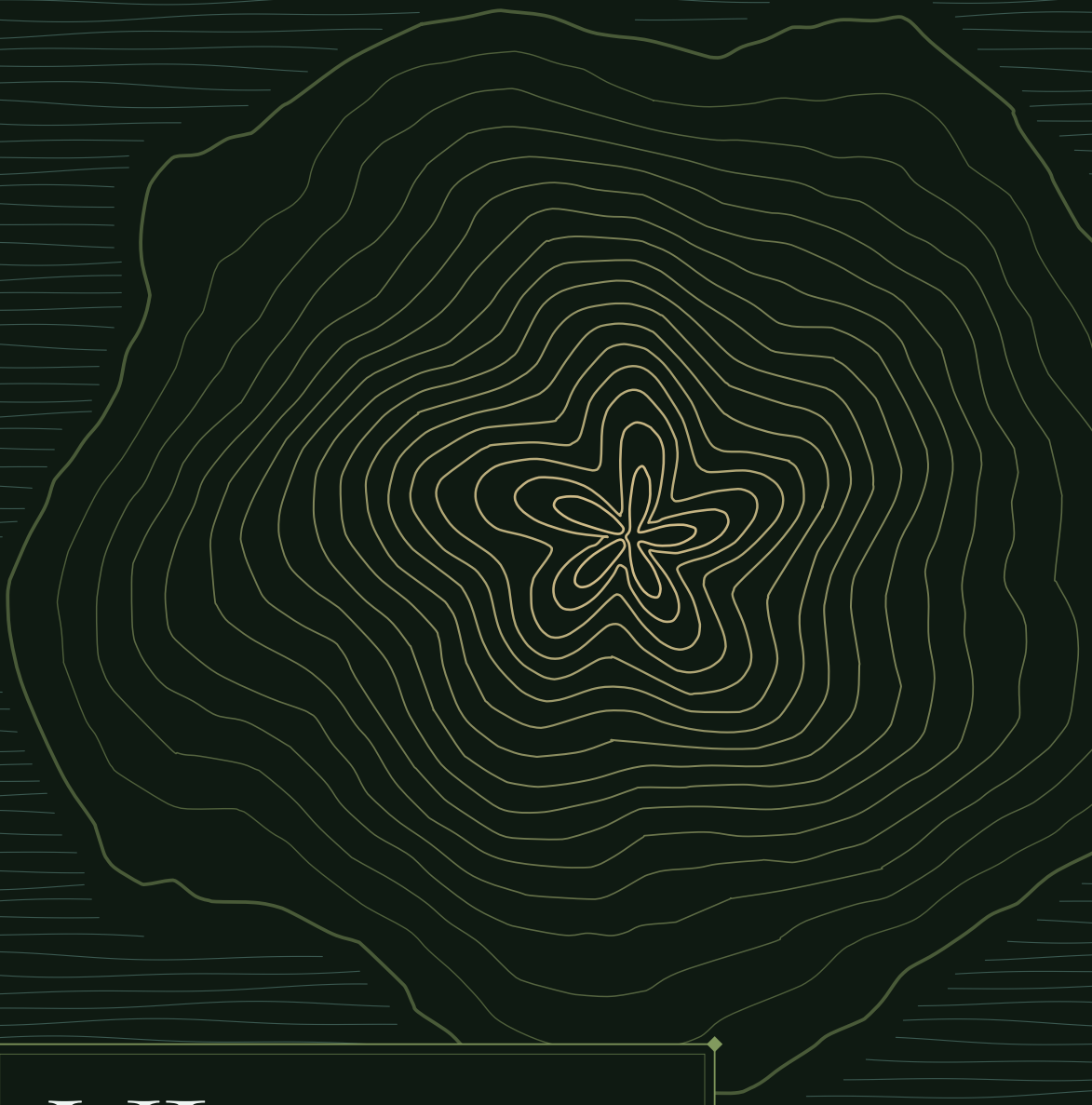
The Body That Needs No Map

The water regime differs from every other in the film in that it requires nothing the panthalassic world withholds. The Atoll needs soil, the Smokers fuel, Gregor a map and a sextant; the Mariner needs only his body, his boat, and the sea. He drinks the water his body has already used, breathes the element that drowns his neighbors, navigates by *mētis* rather than by chart, and finds his soil on the floor of the drowned cities, where no one else can reach it. He is the only figure in the film for whom the loss of the land is not a loss. In this sense he is the panthalassic condition's native: Hau'ofa's voyager become a species, Cousteau's *Homo aquaticus* arrived by catastrophe, Oannes without a mission.

But the Mariner's self-sufficiency is not the film's ideal. The closed circuit of his body — the still, the code of exchange, the refusal of every bond — is the condition from which he must be converted, and the conversion proceeds by a series of gifts that open the circuit: food shared, rain foreseen, swimming taught, breath given. The thalassal body becomes ethical only when it becomes porous, when the organ that made it independent of others becomes the means by which it sustains them. The Mariner's gills are in the end less an emblem of autonomy than of capacity — the capacity to live where others cannot, and therefore to carry them where they could not go alone.

Two figures thus stand at the center of the film's elemental order. Enola bears the land without being able to read it; the Mariner can live without the land, and so can deliver it without wanting it. Dorsal nomos needs a courier, and the thalassal body is the only courier who cannot be tempted by the cargo. The child's inscription and the fish-man's indifference to territory are the two halves of the film's answer to the problem of a world without ground: the law of the land must be carried by someone who does not need the land.

Yet the Mariner's indifference to territory is not, finally, indifference. The film does not end at sea. It ends on the shore of Dryland, with the Mariner standing on the earth he has delivered — a man who could stay, who is asked to stay, and who leaves. The meaning of that departure, the film's last and most contested gesture, is the subject of Chapter Six.



VI

DRYLAND

The Counter-Ararat and the Ethics of Departure

VI

And the ark rested in the seventh month, on the seventeenth day of the month, upon the mountains of Ararat.

— Genesis 8:4 (Authorized Version)

Live happily, you whose fortune is already accomplished; we are summoned from one fate to another. Your rest is won: you have no plain of sea to plough, no fields of Ausonia, forever receding, to pursue.

— Virgil, *Aeneid* 3.493–97 (trans. mine)

When there appeared to us a mountain, dark with distance, and it seemed to me higher than any I had ever seen … until the sea had closed above us.

— Dante, *Inferno* XXVI.133–35, 142 (trans. mine)

6.1

The Summit

Reading the Ending

The ending of *Waterworld* is brief, and it exists in two versions that must be read together. Both begin with a bird. After days aloft, with provisions failing, the Mariner wakes in the basket of Gregor's balloon to find a seagull perched on its rail; looking up, he sees a mountain rising through the clouds (scene-by-scene guide). The balloon comes down on a shoreline below a wide valley of forest. There is flowing fresh water, which sends Gregor into raptures; there are horses; and inland there is a pair of huts, to which the Atoll's Enforcer leads the party. Inside one lie two skeletons, hand in hand, beside a table covered with tattooing implements and papers bearing the symbols of Enola's map; Enola, entering, winds a music box she finds there and declares that she is home (scene-by-scene guide; PopApostle episode study). The Mariner, meanwhile, stands apart. The ground the others greet as salvation unsettles him, and on the shore he finds an old wooden catamaran.

In the theatrical version the departure is swift. The Mariner, feeling that he does not belong on the land, provisions the catamaran and sails away as Helen and Enola watch from the shore (production record). The extended version elaborates each farewell. Enola begs him to stay and, when he will not, presses the music box into his hands and runs off along the beach; Gregor gives him a bag of dirt, with a joke about not spending it all in one place; the Enforcer shakes his hand. When Helen asks why he is leaving, he answers that he will look for others worthy of Dryland, and perhaps for others like himself; she kisses him, tells him the story of Ulysses, and gives him the name. As he sails, Helen and Enola climb to the top of the island and find a metal plaque recording that they stand on the summit of Mount Everest (scene-by-scene guide).

The two versions inflect the departure differently, and the difference matters. The theatrical ending presents it as pure renunciation: a man who cannot belong to the land leaves it to those who can. The extended ending adds a mission. The Mariner leaves not only because he does not belong but in order to find others — others worthy of the land he has found, and others of his own kind — and he leaves with gifts: the music box, which holds the memory of Enola's home, and the dirt, which holds the currency of the Atoll. He departs, in this version, as a courier, carrying the land's existence outward to those who do not yet know of it. The

readings are not contradictory. Together they define the gesture this chapter calls the counter-Ararat: a refusal to settle the land that is at the same time a commitment to deliver it, a departure that is not an abandonment but a sending.

The summit has three names, and each names a relation to the land. In Tibetan it is Chomolungma, commonly glossed as goddess mother of the world; in Nepali, since the mid-twentieth century, Sagarmatha, the head of the sky. Its English name commemorates George Everest, the Surveyor General of India under whose direction the Great Trigonometrical Survey advanced — the colonial project of triangulation that measured the subcontinent and in the 1850s computed the height of the summit then designated Peak XV, establishing it as the highest point on earth. The Royal Geographical Society named the mountain for him in 1865, over his own objection that local names should be preferred. Dryland is thus, in the extended version, a mountain known to its neighbors as the mother of the world and to the empire as a monument to its surveyor: at once the summit of maternal belonging and the summit of cartographic striation. Enola, who comes home to her parents' graves, returns to Chomolungma. The plaque Helen finds belongs to Everest.

The plaque deserves attention, because it is the last inscription in a film about inscription. Its implied referent is the first recorded ascent, by Edmund Hillary and Tenzing Norgay on 29 May 1953, news of which reached London on the morning of the coronation of Elizabeth II and was hailed as a crowning achievement of an empire in its twilight; one of the film's video-game adaptations makes the reference explicit, placing on its summit a plaque commemorating Hillary and Norgay's first footsteps (PopApostle episode study). The language of the climb was the language of conquest — the conquest of Everest — yet the two men left on the summit not only flags but offerings: Tenzing buried sweets for the mountain's gods, Hillary a small crucifix. The summit's inscription is already double, an emblem of imperial achievement and a site of offering. When Helen and Enola read it, they read the last trace of the old world's *Landnahme* at the very place where the new world will begin. What they do with that inheritance is the question the departing Mariner leaves to them.

6.2

Ararat and Its Refusal

Altar, Vineyard, Curse, and the Law of Nations

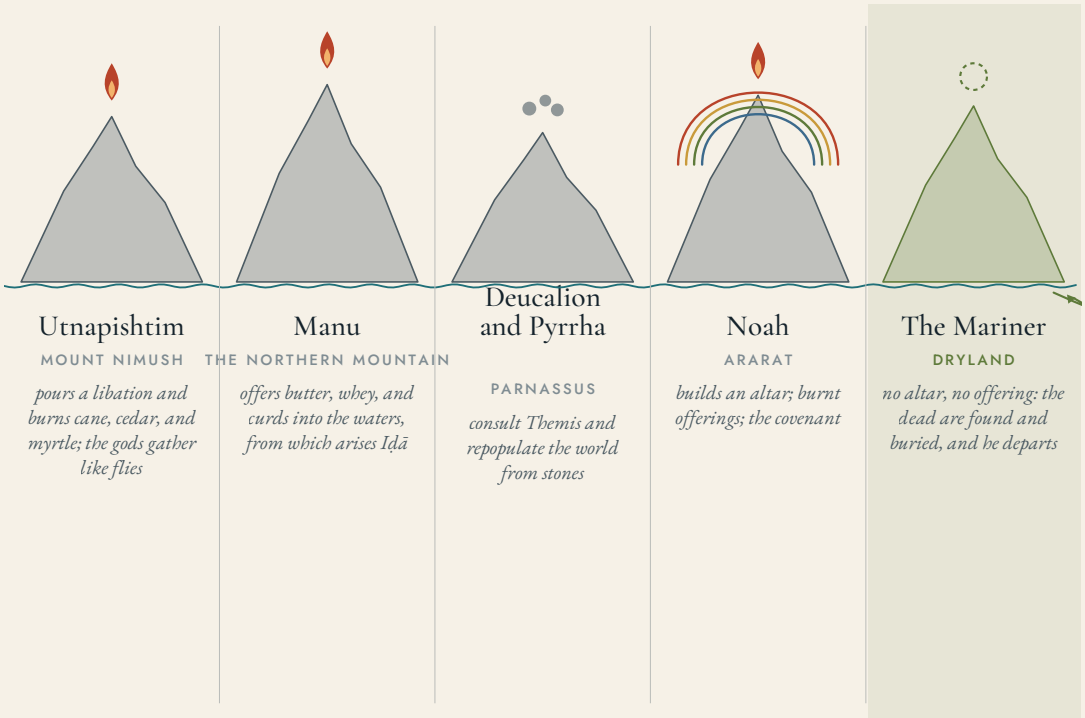
Every flood narrative in the archive surveyed in Chapter One ends with a founding act performed on the mountain. Utnapishtim, disembarking on Mount Nimush, pours a libation and burns cane, cedar, and myrtle, and the gods, smelling the sweet savor, gather like flies over the sacrificer (*Gilgamesh* XI). Manu, descending the northern mountain, offers butter, whey, and curds into the waters, from which arises a woman, Iḍā, through whom he engenders the race of humankind (Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa 1.8.1). Deucalion and Pyrrha, on Parnassus, consult Themis and repopulate the world from stones. And Noah, coming forth from the ark, builds an altar and offers burnt offerings of every clean beast and fowl; the Lord smells the sweet savor and resolves never again to curse the ground for man's sake (Genesis 8:20–21). The landing is always consecrated. The survivor's first act on the recovered earth is sacrifice, and sacrifice is the inaugural rite of a new order: it binds the gods, marks the ground, and founds the community that will occupy it.

Waterworld's landing is not consecrated. The Mariner builds no altar and burns no offering. What the party performs instead is a discovery of the dead — the two skeletons in the hut — and a proposal, made by the Atoll's Enforcer, to bury them in the earth (plot summary). The difference is exact. Sacrifice founds an order by offering a life to the gods; burial completes an order by returning the dead to the ground. The film's landing is an act of mourning rather than of foundation. And the one figure who might have founded a new order on the summit — the man who delivered the remnant, whose competence saved them, and to whom, in the logic of the flood narrative, the covenant would fall — declines to stay at all.

What he declines is specified in the text that follows Noah's sacrifice. Genesis 9 records the covenant in three parts. The first renews and intensifies the dominion of Genesis 1: humanity is to be fruitful and multiply; the fear and dread of humankind shall fall upon every beast, bird, and fish, all of which are delivered into human hands; and every moving thing shall be meat (9:1–3). The second institutes law: "Whoso sheddeth man's blood, by man shall his blood be shed: for in the image of God made he man" (9:6) — the first statute of the post-diluvial

FIGURE 9

Every Landing a Founding, Except One



WHAT THE COUNTER-ARARAT DECLINES

Dominion GENESIS 9:1–3	*'the fear of you and the dread of you shall be upon every beast'*	→ *He establishes no dominion.*
Law GENESIS 9:6	*'whoso sheddeth man's blood, by man shall his blood be shed'*	→ *He institutes no law.*
Vineyard GENESIS 9:20–27	*'the vineyard, the wine, the curse of Canaan'*	→ *He plants no vineyard.*
Lineage GENESIS 9:1	*'be fruitful, and multiply'*	→ *He founds no lineage.*
Rainbow GENESIS 9:8–17	*'the waters shall no more become a flood'*	→ *A covenant already broken.*

The landings of the diluvial archive, each consecrated by a founding act on the mountain, and the terms of the Noahic covenant the Mariner declines (§6.2).

world, a law of retribution to be enforced by human hands. The third is the covenant of the rainbow, the promise never again to destroy the earth by flood (9:8–17). Rabbinic tradition elaborated these verses into the seven Noahide laws — the prohibitions of idolatry, blasphemy, murder, sexual immorality, theft, and eating flesh torn from a living animal, together with the obligation to establish courts of justice — which, binding all the descendants of Noah, constituted a universal law for humankind. In the seventeenth century the Noahide precepts became a foundation for European theories of the law of nations. John Selden — the author, as Chapter One noted, of *Mare Clausum*, which claimed that the sea could be enclosed — devoted a treatise of 1640, *De Jure Naturali et Gentium juxta Disciplinam Ebraeorum*, to deriving natural law and the law of nations from the Noahide commandments. Ararat is, in this genealogy, a birthplace of international law: the mountain on which the survivors of the flood received the first universal nomos.

The covenant is followed by an episode that discloses the shadow of the new order. Noah, the narrative continues, became a husbandman and planted a vineyard; he drank of its wine and lay drunk and uncovered in his tent; his son Ham saw his nakedness, and Noah, waking, cursed Ham's son Canaan to be a servant of servants to his brothers (Genesis 9:20–27). The first act of cultivation on the recovered earth is a vineyard; its first product is intoxication; its first social consequence is a curse that institutes servitude. The so-called curse of Ham would be read for centuries, and with catastrophic force in the theology of the Atlantic slave trade and the American South, as divine sanction for the enslavement of Africans — a history David Goldenberg reconstructed in *The Curse of Ham* (2003). The postdiluvial order founded on Ararat thus contains, from its first chapter, both the universal law of the Noahide covenant and the particular curse that sanctified hierarchy: dominion over animals, retribution among humans, and the bondage of some humans to others.

The counter-Ararat refuses this order in each of its terms. The Mariner plants no vineyard; the only cultivation he has practiced is the lime tree on his boat and the tomato plant he bought at the Atoll, and he leaves the island's fields untouched. He establishes no dominion; the horses that pass the travelers on the summit are neither tamed nor hunted in the film's sight. He institutes no law; the only juridical figure on the summit is the Atoll's Enforcer, whose proposal is not a statute but a burial. And he founds no lineage. Though he and Helen have grown close — in the extended version they become lovers — he leaves without a child and without a claim on hers. The flood narratives end with a man who becomes

the father of a new humanity: Noah, Manu, Deucalion, Utnapishtim made immortal. *Waterworld* ends with a man who declines that paternity. The new humanity of Dryland is mothered by Helen and inherited by Enola, and the one who delivered it returns to the sea.

The covenant's last term deserves a final word. The rainbow is God's promise that "the waters shall no more become a flood to destroy all flesh" (Genesis 9:15) — a promise addressed to the land and its inhabitants, guaranteeing that the sea will keep its place. *Waterworld* is set in a world where that promise has failed, where the covenant has lapsed, and the counter-Ararat may be read as the response proper to a world without the rainbow. When the ground can no longer be guaranteed against the sea, the covenant that founded dominion on the ground cannot be renewed in good faith. The Mariner, who lives on the water, does not need the promise; his is the one existence in the film that does not depend on the sea keeping its place. His departure declines a covenant already broken, and leaves to those who remain the task of founding something that does not presuppose it.

6.3

The Mountain in the Southern Sea

Ulysses after Homer

Helen's naming of the Mariner, in the extended version, places the film's ending within the longest tradition of departure in Western literature, and the tradition is divided against itself. Homer's Odysseus is the hero of *nostos*, homecoming; the whole of the *Odyssey* bends toward his return to Ithaca, his house, his wife, and his land. Yet even Homer's ending is not final. In the underworld the seer Tiresias prophesies that after Odysseus has slain the suitors he must take an oar and walk inland until he comes to people who know nothing of the sea and eat no salt with their food, and who, seeing the oar on his shoulder, take it for a winnowing fan; there he must plant the oar in the ground and sacrifice to Poseidon, and then death will come to him gently, in a prosperous old age (*Odyssey* 11.119–37). The prophecy imagines a final reconciliation of sea and land: the sailor's instrument, mistaken for an instrument of the harvest, is planted in an earth where the sea is unknown, and the god of the sea is appeased. *Waterworld* inverts the rite. The Mariner does not carry an oar inland; he carries a bag of earth out to sea. The emblem of the land — the Atoll's currency — goes with him onto the water,

where it is useless, while he leaves the land itself to those who will farm it. Homer's reconciliation plants the sea in the land; the film's sends the land, as a token, back to the sea.

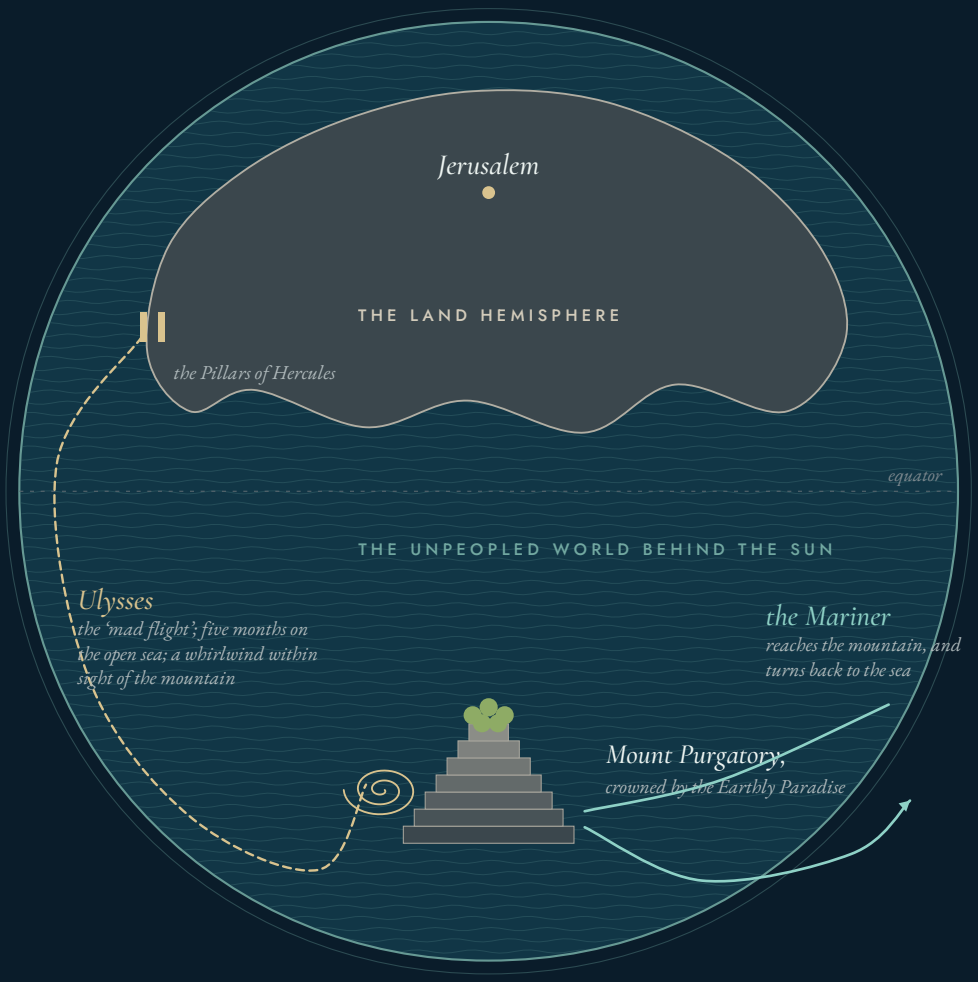
Dante's Ulysses refuses *nostos* altogether. In the twenty-sixth canto of the *Inferno*, speaking from the double flame in which he burns among the fraudulent counselors, he tells Virgil that neither tenderness for his son, nor piety toward his aged father, nor the love he owed Penelope could overcome his ardor to gain experience of the world, of human vice and worth; and so he put out again onto the open sea with a few companions. At the Pillars of Hercules, the limit set so that men should go no farther, he urged them on with a brief oration — consider your origin: you were not made to live as brutes, but to pursue virtue and knowledge — and they made wings of their oars for the mad flight, the *folle volo*, into the unpeopled world behind the sun (XXVI.94–126). After five months in the southern ocean they saw a mountain, dark with distance, higher than any they had ever seen; from the new land a whirlwind rose and struck the ship, spun it three times with all the waters, lifted the stern and drove the prow down, as pleased Another, until the sea closed over them (XXVI.127–42). The mountain is Purgatory, the one land in Dante's southern hemisphere, crowned by the Earthly Paradise. Ulysses dies within sight of it because he sought it by his own will, without grace.

The Mariner is Dante's Ulysses granted the landfall Dante denied him. He too has sailed beyond every known limit into a world without people; he too reaches the one mountain in the ocean, crowned with its paradise of trees, fresh water, and horses; and he too, at that summit, turns back toward the sea. But the meaning of the return has changed. Dante's Ulysses is drowned for presuming to reach paradise by his own power; his sin is the transgression of the limit. The Mariner reaches the mountain not by presumption but by service — he arrives as the courier of a child whose parents wrote the way on her back — and he leaves it not by divine whirlwind but by choice. Where Dante's Ulysses would have taken the mountain had the sea not taken him, the Mariner is given the mountain and declines it. The film absolves Ulysses by reversing the direction of his desire. The sin Dante punished was the will to possess a paradise one had not been granted; the virtue the film proposes is the will to leave a paradise one has been offered.

No modern reading of the canto can ignore the use to which Primo Levi put it. In "The Canto of Ulysses," a chapter of *If This Is a Man* (1947), Levi recounts trying to recite the canto from memory to a young French prisoner as they carried a soup kettle across the camp at Auschwitz, struggling to recover the lines and to translate them, and finding in the oration at the Pillars an overwhelming revelation

FIGURE 10

The Mountain in the Southern Sea



Dante's world (§6.3): the land hemisphere centred on Jerusalem and, in the southern ocean, Mount Purgatory. Ulysses dies within sight of the mountain; the Mariner reaches it, and leaves.

in the very place designed to reduce human beings to brutes. Levi's chapter is the twentieth century's testimony that the Ulyssean refusal of merely animal life belongs not to the conqueror but to the captive. Its resonance for *Waterworld* is specific. Chapter Two found in the Atoll's cage and vat a version of what Agamben called the camp, the nomos of the modern, and the Mariner who escapes that cage to sail beyond every limit carries with him, however faintly, the Ulyssean dignity Levi recovered in the Lager: the claim that a human being is the one who will not consent to be reduced to bare life.

Tennyson's "Ulysses" (1842) gives the departure its Victorian form. The aged king, home at last in Ithaca, finds that it little profits him to sit as an idle king by a still hearth among barren crags, "Match'd with an aged wife," meting out unequal laws "unto a savage race, / That hoard, and sleep, and feed, and know not me." He resolves to leave the scepter to his son Telemachus, fit to govern by slow prudence, and to sail again with his old mariners: "my purpose holds / To sail beyond the sunset, and the baths / Of all the western stars, until I die." The poem anticipates the Mariner's ending in its division of labor. Tennyson's Ulysses leaves the land to one suited to rule it and takes for himself the unfinishable voyage; the Mariner leaves Dryland to Helen and Enola, to Gregor and the Enforcer, and takes the sea. That Tennyson's islanders are those who hoard, and sleep, and feed is a description the Atoll would recognize. But Tennyson's king leaves because domestic governance bores him, and his departure carries the imperial glamour of the voyage beyond the known world. The Mariner leaves because he will not govern at all. His is not the restlessness of a sovereign but the renunciation of sovereignty.

Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949), which by the 1990s had become, through Christopher Vogler's adaptations, a working manual for Hollywood screenwriters, names the gesture structurally. The third phase of the monomyth, the Return, opens with a stage Campbell calls the refusal of the return: the hero, having won the boon, may decline to carry it back to the world of common day. Campbell's examples are mystics and sages reluctant, after illumination, to re-enter the world. The Mariner's refusal is of another kind. He has already brought the boon back — the remnant is on the land, the child is home — and what he refuses is not the return to the community but its reward, a place within it. In Campbell's later stages the hero becomes master of the two worlds, moving freely between the realm of the boon and the realm of the everyday. The Mariner is master of two worlds in the most literal sense, a creature of sea and land, and his mastery takes the form of choosing the world in which he will not rule. The monomyth's homecoming becomes, at the last moment, a sending forth.

6.4

The Doorway and the Horizon

The Western's Ethics of Departure

The Mariner's departure belongs equally to the American Western, whose foundational narrative is the story of a man who makes the settlement possible and cannot live within it. Robert Warshow's essay "The Westerner" (1954) described the genre's hero as a figure of melancholy and limitation, a man whose violence the community requires and whose presence it cannot absorb; Richard Slotkin's trilogy on the myth of the frontier, culminating in *Gunfighter Nation* (1992), traced the genre's ideology of regeneration through violence, in which the savagery of the frontier is purged by a hero who must himself be expelled once the land is secured. The Western's endings are therefore endings of exclusion. The town is founded, the homestead saved, the railroad arrives — and the man who made it possible rides away.

The canonical image is the last shot of John Ford's *The Searchers* (1956). Ethan Edwards, who has hunted for years the niece abducted by a Comanche band, carries her at last to the homestead of the Jorgensens; the family passes through the door into the dark interior; Ethan, framed in the doorway against the bright desert, hesitates, turns, and walks away, and the door closes on him. The structural parallels with *Waterworld* are unmistakable. A girl is abducted by raiders; a solitary man pursues and recovers her; he delivers her to a homestead; he remains outside it. But the meaning of the exclusion is inverted. Ethan cannot enter because of what he is: a man whose racial hatred is so consuming that for much of the film he means to kill the niece he is searching for because she has lived as a Comanche — a violence the settlement needs at its frontier and cannot admit to its hearth. The Mariner cannot enter because of what the settlement is: a community of land-dwellers in which the hybrid, the gilled man, the creature of the sea, has no place. Ethan is excluded for hating the mixed; the Mariner is excluded for being it. Ford's doorway marks the boundary between civilization and the violence it disowns. Reynolds's shoreline marks the boundary between the land and a being whose very body testifies that the land is not the only world.

George Stevens's *Shane* (1953), whose shape the Mariner's bond with Enola recalls, supplies the second paradigm. A gunfighter rides into a Wyoming valley,

takes work with a homesteading family, defends the homesteaders against a cattle baron's hired killer, and rides out, wounded, into the mountains as the family's boy calls after him to come back. Shane's departure is explained within the film by the impossibility of living with a killing: a man who has killed cannot remain in the valley he has made safe. The Mariner, too, has killed for the community he leaves — the drifter aboard his boat, the Smokers on the Deez — and his insistence that he does not belong on the land has the cadence of Shane's self-exile. But where Shane's departure purges the community of the violence that saved it, the Mariner's removes from Dryland something other than violence: the possibility of a sovereign. He is the strongest of the survivors, the one who could have ruled. The Western's gunfighter leaves so that the law can arrive; the Mariner leaves so that no one's law need arrive at all.

Ford's *The Man Who Shot Liberty Valance* (1962) gives the Western's departure its most melancholy form. Tom Doniphon, the rancher who secretly kills the outlaw Liberty Valance and lets the eastern lawyer Ransom Stoddard take the credit, loses the woman he loves to Stoddard, burns the house he had been building for her, and dies forgotten; Stoddard, on the strength of the legend, becomes a senator, and the territory becomes a state. Doniphon's renunciation is the condition of statehood: the man of the frontier destroys his own homestead so that the man of law can found the polity. The Mariner shares Doniphon's renunciation of the domestic but not its service to the state. Dryland gets no senator. The figure who leaves is not making way for a legal order he will not share; he is declining to be the origin of any order.

Costner's own *Dances with Wolves* (1990) offers the closest analogue within his filmography, and it complicates the pattern. John Dunbar, the Union officer who has become a member of a Lakota band, leaves its winter camp at the film's end because his presence will draw the pursuing Army upon it; he departs to protect the community that adopted him. The departure is an act of care: the outsider removes himself because he endangers those he loves. *Waterworld*'s extended ending, in which the Mariner leaves to find others worthy of Dryland and perhaps others of his kind, shares something of this logic. The Mariner is a hybrid among land-dwellers, and his presence on Dryland would make the new community, like the Atoll before it, a community obliged to decide what to do with the anomaly. By leaving, he spares them the decision — and preserves the possibility, which his promise to seek others holds open, that the anomaly will one day return in numbers, not as a threat but as kin.

The Western thus supplies the counter-Ararat with its gestures and tests its meaning. In each of these films the departing man stands in a determinate relation to the order he leaves: Ethan to the racial violence it disowns, Shane to the killing it cannot live with, Doniphon to the law that supersedes him, Dunbar to the army that hunts him. The Mariner's relation is to sovereignty as such. He is not expelled by the settlement; he declines to become its foundation. In the terms of Chapter One, the Western's hero leaves so that the nomos can be established without him; the Mariner leaves so that the nomos of Dryland, whatever it becomes, will not be founded on appropriation. That difference is the subject of the sections that remain, which ask what the departure leaves behind and what kind of ethics it enacts.

6.5

Widowed Land and Common Treasury

What the Departure Leaves Behind

Dryland is staged as a paradise: a green valley, a running stream, horses grazing, light falling through trees — the iconography of Eden, of Dante's Earthly Paradise at the summit of Purgatory, of the Terrestrial Paradise Columbus believed lay near the mouth of the Orinoco on the breast-shaped summit of the world. American culture has its own names for the image. Henry Nash Smith's *Virgin Land* (1950) traced the myth of the West as a garden of the world, an agrarian paradise awaiting the settler's plough; Leo Marx's *The Machine in the Garden* (1964) followed the pastoral ideal through American literature and its repeated violation by the technologies of industrial modernity. Dryland is that garden in its purest form, a pastoral with no machine at all, the Smokers' engines having burned and sunk with the Deez. It is the American pastoral restored at the end of the American petroleum age.

But Dryland is not virgin land. The travelers find on it a hut, two skeletons, and the implements with which a dying couple wrote the way home on their child's back. The land had inhabitants, and they are dead. The historian Francis Jennings, in *The Invasion of America* (1975), argued that the English colonists of the seventeenth century found not a virgin land but a widowed one: a continent whose peoples had been devastated by epidemics introduced through earlier European contact, so that the wilderness the settlers claimed to have discovered was in

truth a landscape emptied by catastrophe. Dryland is a widowed land in exactly Jennings's sense — its people dead, its huts standing, its fields untended — and the arrival of the balloon party reproduces in miniature the founding scene of settler colonialism: newcomers come upon a land whose prior inhabitants have perished, and must decide what claim the dead retain upon it.

The film's answer is its most quietly radical gesture. Among the newcomers is the child of the dead. Enola, entering the hut, declares herself home; the land is not discovered but inherited, and its inheritor is the daughter of those who lived there, carrying on her back the testament they wrote. The settler-colonial scene is rewritten as the homecoming of the dispossessed. The land returns to the heir of its last inhabitants, and the others — Helen, Gregor, the Enforcer — come as her household, not as her conquerors. This is the decisive difference between Dryland and Locke's America, and between the Mariner's delivery and the Deacon's conquest. Had the Smokers reached the summit, they would have found a widowed land and seized it. The Mariner's party brings the widow's daughter home.

What order the new community will found the film does not say, but Chapter Four's reference to the English Revolution returns here with force. In April 1649 Gerrard Winstanley and a small company of Diggers began to dig and sow the common land on St George's Hill in Surrey, and in *The True Levellers Standard Advanced*, published that month, they declared that the earth had been made at the creation a common treasury for beasts and men alike, and that the enclosure of land as private property was the original fall from which all oppression flowed. Local landowners destroyed their colony within a year. Dryland, after the Mariner's departure, is a land without an owner: its finder has refused it, its heir is a child, and its other inhabitants hold no title. It is, in the Diggers' sense, a common treasury, waiting to be kept in common or enclosed. The film ends before the choice is made, and the departure of the one person strong enough to enclose it is the condition under which the choice remains open.

The community's composition also completes the elemental scheme of this dissertation. Those who remain on Dryland are the Enforcer, who carries the Atoll's law of earth; Gregor, who embodies the aeronautical regime of air; Enola, the bearer of the skin's inscription; and Helen, the Atoll's dissenter, the Cassandra who believed in Dryland when no one else did. Fire is absent, the Smokers having perished in their own combustion, and water has departed with the Mariner. In Empedocles' cosmology the roots are drawn together by Love and driven apart by Strife, and Chapter One observed that the panthalassic world represented a third possibility, the hegemony of a single element. The ending restores a mixture, under

Love, of the elements that can coexist on the land — earth, air, and skin — while the element of Strife consumes itself and the element of the sea withdraws to its own domain. The cosmos of *Waterworld* closes in a new distribution of the roots: not a total mixture but a partition by consent, in which each element keeps its place and none claims the whole.

The ending is not utopian, and it should not be read as one. The Enforcer's first impulse is to extend the Atoll's metabolic piety to the dead; Gregor's parting gift is the Atoll's currency; the plaque on the summit records the old world's language of conquest. The habits of the earth regime have arrived on Dryland intact, and nothing guarantees that the community will not rebuild on solid ground the walls and vats of the floating city. The theme-park sequel to the film, as Chapter Seven shows, imagines precisely such a relapse: in it the Deacon survives, the danger returns, and the Mariner must come back to defend Dryland. The film's own ending refuses that sequel. It leaves the question of Dryland's order to those who will live there, and removes from the island the one figure whose presence would have answered the question for them.

6.6

The Counter-Ararat

Toward a Thalassal Ethics of Non-Appropriation

The ending's ethical meaning can now be stated in philosophical terms, and the most precise vocabulary for it is Emmanuel Levinas's. In "The Trace of the Other" (1963), Levinas characterized the whole movement of Western philosophy as an odyssey: a voyage of the self through the world that always returns to itself, assimilating every otherness it meets into the same, as Odysseus, after all his wanderings, comes home to Ithaca. Against the myth of Ulysses returning home Levinas set the story of Abraham, who leaves his country forever for a land not yet known and forbids his servant even to bring his son back to the place of departure (Genesis 24:6). Abraham's departure without return is Levinas's figure for the ethical relation itself: a movement toward the other that does not come back to the self, a work undertaken for a future in which the one who undertakes it will not share. The irony of *Waterworld*'s extended version is that it names the Mariner Ulysses at the very moment he becomes Abraham. He has had his odyssey; he could have his Ithaca, with a Penelope and a Telemachus waiting on the shore; and

he leaves it for the open sea, to find others, without return. The name looks back to Homer. The act looks forward to Levinas.

Levinas also supplies the critique of rootedness that the counter-Ararat presupposes. In "Heidegger, Gagarin and Us" (1961), written after the first human orbit of the earth, he praised Yuri Gagarin for having left, if only for an hour or two, the Place — the sacred landscape, the rootedness in soil, the pagan intimacy of a people with its land that Heidegger's late thought had celebrated and that the politics of blood and soil had made murderous. Technology, Levinas provocatively argued, wrenches human beings out of the superstition of place, and Judaism's freedom with respect to sedentary forms of existence had anticipated that liberation. The Mariner is a Gagarin of the sea. His body has left the Place; his existence is rooted in no soil; and his refusal to take root on Dryland is a refusal of the sacralization of land on which the Atoll's piety and the Deacon's crusade alike depend. Levinas's ethics is an ethics of the face, not of territory, and the Mariner's farewells on the shore — to Enola's face, to Helen's, to Gregor's and the Enforcer's — are the film's last ethical gestures precisely because they are farewells to persons rather than to a land.

The Jewish mystical tradition offers a still more radical figure. In the Kabbalah of Isaac Luria, taught in sixteenth-century Safed, creation begins not with an act of expansion but with an act of contraction: *tzimtzum*, the withdrawal of the infinite into itself so as to make room for a world that is not God. Creation is, on this account, first of all a making-room, a self-limitation of the creator so that the creature may exist. Simone Weil, writing in the 1940s from another tradition, developed a related idea of decreation: that the highest love consists in withdrawing the self so that others may be. The counter-Ararat is a *tzimtzum*. The one figure who could have become the founder, the father, and the sovereign of the new world withdraws, and his withdrawal is the condition of the new world's freedom. Noah's covenant fills the post-diluvial earth with the authority of its survivor; the Mariner's departure empties Dryland of that authority, so that its inheritors may decide its order for themselves. The creator-figure contracts so that the world can begin.

The epistemological correlate of this ethics was stated in Chapter One. Kant, having surveyed the territory of the pure understanding, declared it an island, the land of truth, surrounded by a wide and stormy ocean, the native home of illusion, and counseled the voyager to remain upon it. Neurath, against every foundationalist dream, insisted that we are like sailors who must rebuild their ship on the open sea, never able to bring it into dry dock. The Mariner, having reached the land of

truth, returns to the ocean — not because he prefers illusion to truth, but because he has understood that truth on land is the possession of those who live there, while his own knowledge is the knowledge of the voyage, which is never finished and never owned. Kant's island is the epistemology of the settler; Neurath's boat is the epistemology of the Mariner. The counter-Ararat is the choice of Neurath's boat after the island has been reached.

In the terms of Carl Schmitt, with which this dissertation began, the counter-Ararat is the refusal of *Landnahme*. Schmitt held that every nomos begins with an appropriation of land, and that the order of the earth is founded by those who take, divide, and pasture it. The Mariner, who could have taken Dryland, does not; he leaves it undivided and unpastured by any claim of his. If the nomos of Dryland is founded at all, it will be founded without the primal act Schmitt held to be constitutive of every order: it will begin with an inheritance and a refusal rather than a seizure. This is the possibility that Schmitt's theory, for all its rigor, could not imagine — a law of the earth whose first act is not taking but declining to take. Chapter Seven calls the law of such a world thalassonomy.

The thalassal ethics that the counter-Ararat enacts may now be defined in four propositions. It is, first, an ethics of inhabitation without ownership: the Mariner lives in the sea as Hau'ofa's voyagers lived in the sea of islands, as a world and a road, not as a territory. It is, second, an ethics of delivery without claim: he carries the bearer of the land to the land, and the carrying confers on him no right to what he has carried. It is, third, an ethics of withdrawal: like the Lurianic creator, he makes room by leaving, so that the order of the new world can be chosen by those who will live in it. It is, fourth, an ethics of the unfinished voyage: he does not rest on the island of truth but returns to the sea to seek others, so that the work of delivery continues beyond any single landfall. Against the Noahic covenant, which re-founds dominion upon the mountain, thalassal ethics proposes a covenant of non-appropriation, sealed not by a rainbow but by a departure. Its emblem is the film's last image: a man in a small boat on a wide sea, leaving behind him a land that is no one's because he would not make it his.

6.7

Conclusion

Alone, Reversed

The film's last configuration redistributes its central anagram. Enola, whose name is "alone" written backward, stays on the land; the Mariner, who had been made unalone by her, sails away alone. But the solitude to which he returns is not the solitude from which he came. At the beginning of the film he was alone as a closed circuit, a body that recycled its own water and owed nothing to anyone, trading by a code under which nothing was free. At the end he is alone as a courier. He carries a music box that holds the memory of a child's home, a bag of earth given by a friend, and, in the extended version, a name given by a lover; and he sails to find others worthy of the land he has delivered. His aloneness has been turned inside out. It is no longer the absence of bonds but the form a bond takes when it does not seek possession. Melville's epilogue to *Moby-Dick* takes as its epigraph the messenger's words from Job — "And I only am escaped alone to tell thee" — and its sole survivor floats on Queequeg's tattooed coffin until a searching ship finds him. The Mariner is Ishmael's inverse: not the one who escapes alone to tell, but the one who leaves alone after others have escaped with him.

This chapter has read the departure through four traditions. The flood narratives showed what the Mariner declines: the altar, the vineyard, the curse, and the covenant of dominion that the survivors of every deluge establish upon the mountain. The tradition of Ulysses showed what he chooses: neither Homer's homecoming nor Tennyson's sovereign restlessness, but a Dantean voyage absolved by its direction — a paradise offered and left. The Western showed whom he resembles and how he differs: like Ethan Edwards and Shane he delivers the settlement and stays outside it, but he is excluded by his difference rather than his violence, and he leaves not so that a law may arrive but so that no one's law need. And Levinas, Luria, and Neurath showed what kind of ethics the departure enacts: an Abrahamic leaving without return, a creative withdrawal, a preference for the unfinished voyage over the closed island.

The critique registered in Chapter Five must stand beside this reading. The counter-Ararat is enacted by a white American star in a Pacific landscape, and its renunciation of the land is available to him precisely because he can live without it;

a gesture of non-appropriation performed by the one person who has no need of the land is a cheaper renunciation than the film admits. The ethics it models must therefore be universalized with care. Those who cannot breathe water cannot simply leave. For them thalassal ethics cannot mean departure; it must mean instead the refusal to found the order of the land on seizure — the decision, left to Helen, Enola, Gregor, and the Enforcer, to keep Dryland a common treasury rather than build a new Atoll. The Mariner's gesture is exemplary not because others should imitate it literally but because it removes, at the decisive moment, the sovereign who would otherwise have made that decision for them.

The final chapter leaves the story to follow the film into the world it anticipated. Since 1995 *Waterworld* has lived on as a theme-park spectacle whose sequel reverses the counter-Ararat, as a comic book whose villain bears the name of Hobbes's sovereign, and as cultural shorthand for extravagant failure; meanwhile the sea-level rise it exaggerated has begun, in the Pacific, to put to international law the very question the film put to myth. Chapter Seven asks what a law of the sea in the strong sense — a law that does not presuppose the land — might look like, and gives it the name this dissertation has held in reserve: thalassonomy.

VII

THALASSONOMY

Waterworld after the Waterline

VII

And I saw a new heaven and a new earth: for the first heaven and the first earth were passed away; and there was no more sea.

— Revelation 21:1 (Authorized Version)

The sea is common to all, because it is so immense that it cannot be possessed by anyone, and because it is suited to the uses of all, whether one considers navigation or fishing.

— Hugo Grotius, *Mare Liberum* (1609), ch. 5 (trans. mine)

The state as a person of international law should possess the following qualifications: (a) a permanent population; (b) a defined territory; (c) government; and (d) capacity to enter into relations with the other states.

— Montevideo Convention on the Rights and Duties of States (1933), art. 1

7.1

The Show Must Go On

The Afterlives of a Catastrophe

Waterworld did not end in 1995. It has lived on in more forms, and for longer, than most of the films that outgrossed it, and the forms of its afterlife are themselves an argument about the culture that produced it. The release was accompanied by a novelization, by video games for the Super Nintendo, the Game Boy, the Virtual Boy, and the personal computer, and by a pinball machine; a four-issue sequel comic, *Waterworld: Children of Leviathan*, followed from Acclaim in 1997; and in July 2021 a follow-up television series was announced, only for its prospective director to concede in 2025 that the announcement had been premature (production record). The most enduring afterlife, however, is architectural and performative. Since 1995 a live stunt show based on the film has played several times a day at Universal Studios Hollywood, and it has been reproduced at Universal's parks in Osaka, Singapore, and Beijing (production record). The flood has become a scheduled event.

The show's narrative is a sequel, and it is a sequel that undoes the film's ending. Helen returns to an atoll with proof that Dryland exists; she is followed by the Deacon, who has survived the events of the film; the Mariner arrives, defeats the Deacon, and carries Helen back to Dryland (production record). Every term of the counter-Ararat is reversed. The Deacon, whom the film consumed in his own explosion, is resurrected to be defeated again in perpetuity; the Mariner, who refused the land, returns to take the woman to it; the land, which the film left to its heirs, becomes the reward of the hero's victory. The theme park restores the conventional ending the film declined: the hero gets the girl and the ground, and the villain is defeated in a combustion spectacle that can be repeated at the next showing. At Universal Studios Japan the logic has been carried to its limit in seasonal crossovers with the pirate manga *One Piece*, in which the Deacon allies with the pirate Buggy the Clown against the Straw Hat crew (production record) — the Smokers' piratical theology absorbed into a franchise of pirates, the sea-raider become a licensed character among licensed characters. And the comic sequel gave its new villain, the supplier of the Smokers, the name of Hobbes's sovereign: Leviathan.

The show is a textbook instance of what Guy Debord, in *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967), described as the inversion of life into representation, and of what

Jean Baudrillard, writing of Disneyland in *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981), called deterrence: the theme park presents itself as imaginary in order to make the world outside its gates seem real. The *WaterWorld* arena stages the drowning of the earth as a brief entertainment in Southern California, in Osaka, in Singapore — coastal places whose own exposure to the rising sea is a matter of engineering budgets and planning documents — and so performs, for the audience on the bleachers, the reassurance that the flood is a show. Mark Fisher's *Capitalist Realism* (2009) took as its point of departure the remark, attributed variously to Fredric Jameson and Slavoj Žižek, that it is easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism. The theme park makes the end of the world a product, sold by the ticket and repeated on schedule, and demonstrates the remark with diagrammatic clarity: the apocalypse has become one of capitalism's attractions.

Yet the show contains, perhaps unintentionally, a rebuttal of its own reassurance. Its performers drench the front rows, and the seats nearest the water are known to visitors as a zone in which they will be soaked. Chapter One opened with Lucretius's spectator on the shore, who watches another's shipwreck from the safety of land, and with Blumenberg's account of the shore's gradual disappearance from modern thought. The soak zone is the end of that genealogy in the idiom of the amusement park. The spectator of the drowned world, seated on the shore of a concrete lagoon, gets wet. The protection the shore once afforded has become a matter of choosing one's seat.

The film's reputation has had an afterlife of its own. *The Simpsons*, in 1997, gave it a sardonic monument: an arcade game called Kevin Costner's Waterworld that takes forty quarters, allows the player two steps, and ends (production record) — the cost overrun condensed into a game in which nothing happens but expenditure; in 2022 a fan programmer made the fictional game real. Revisionist assessments have meanwhile accumulated, as trade analysts noted the film's eventual profitability and critics argued for its standing as a cult classic deserving reappraisal (production record). The mockery and the reappraisal share an assumption this dissertation has contested from its first page: that the film's meaning is a function of its cost. The afterlives that matter most are not those in which the film is ridiculed or rehabilitated, but those in which its images have become working parts of the culture's imagination of the sea.

Those afterlives are many. *Raft* (2018; full release 2022), a cooperative survival game, sets its players on a few planks adrift on an endless ocean, from which they must build an ever larger vessel out of floating debris while searching for the remains of a drowned civilization and the rumored existence of land — the Atoll's

bricolage converted into a game mechanic. James Cameron's *Avatar: The Way of Water* (2022) imagines a reef people, the Metkayina, whose tattooed bodies and seafaring culture draw on Polynesian and especially Māori models, and whose sacred kin, the whale-like tulkun, are hunted by an invading corporation for a precious fluid harvested from their brains: the whaling economy that Chapter Three traced from the *Pequod* to the Deez, restaged as interplanetary extraction, and accompanied by renewed debate over Hollywood's borrowing of Pacific cultures. And *Mad Max: Fury Road* (2015), co-written by the creator of one of *Waterworld*'s precursors, fused the film's regimes of water and fuel in a single tyrant. Thirty years after its release, *Waterworld*'s images circulate as a common stock — the raft of salvage, the tattooed map, the oil cult, the gilled man — in a culture that has begun to need them.

7.2

The Rising Sea

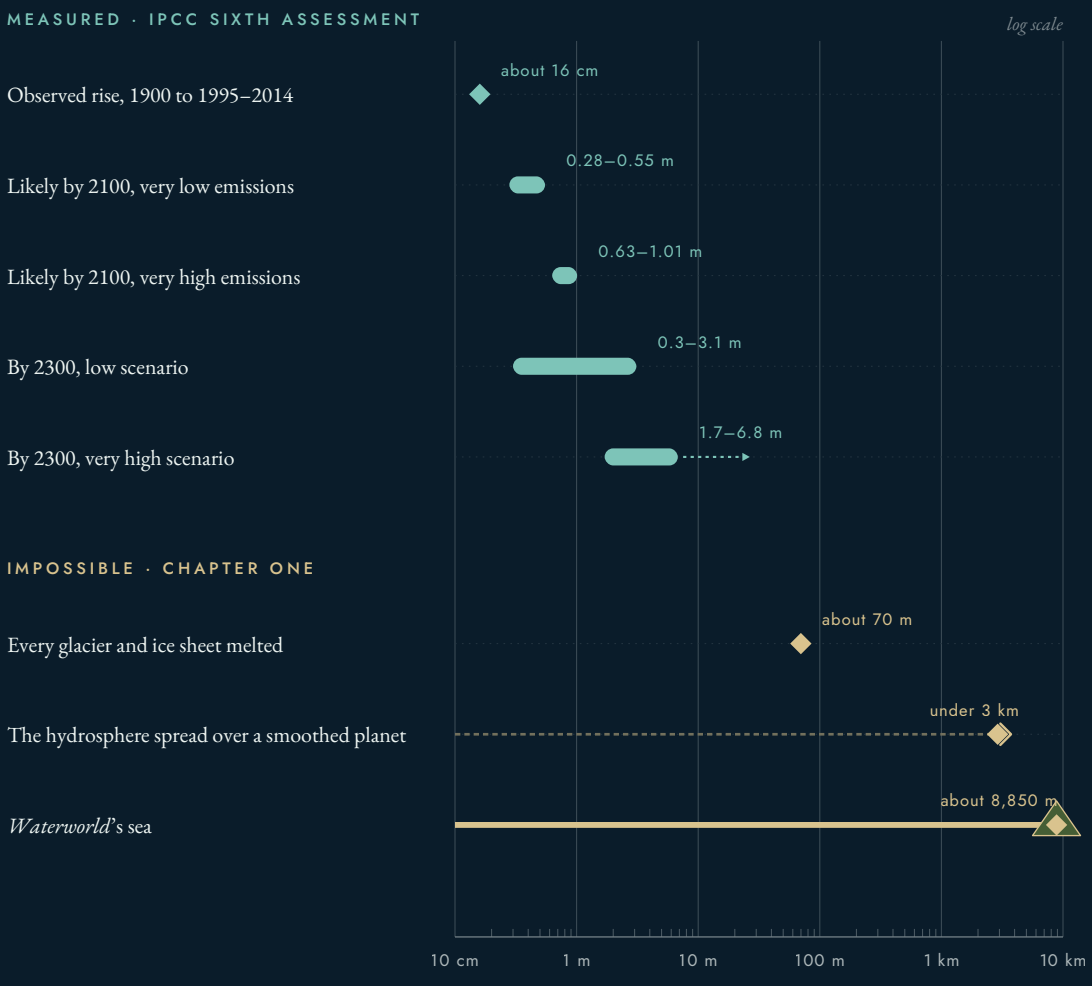
From Myth to Measurement

The flood of *Waterworld* is, as Chapter One argued, a theological rather than a physical event; its volume exceeds the planet's water. The flood actually under way is smaller, slower, and in some respects more frightening, because it is measured. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change's Sixth Assessment Report estimates that global mean sea level rose by about sixteen centimetres between 1900 and the period 1995–2014, and projects a likely further rise by 2100 of between 0.28 and 0.55 metres under a very low emissions scenario and between 0.63 and 1.01 metres under a very high one. By 2300 the assessed ranges extend to between 0.3 and 3.1 metres in a low scenario and between 1.7 and 6.8 metres in a very high one, with low-likelihood, high-impact ice-sheet processes that cannot be ruled out pushing the upper bounds higher still (IPCC AR6). Some 896 million people, nearly eleven percent of the world's population in 2020, live in the low-lying coastal zone, a number projected to exceed a billion by mid-century; and for some small islands and low-lying coasts, the Panel judges, the rising sea could become an existential risk (IPCC AR6).

These numbers describe a catastrophe of a different temporal kind from the film's. Rob Nixon's *Slow Violence and the Environmentalism of the Poor* (2011) named the problem: environmental harm that unfolds gradually and out of sight,

FIGURE 11

The Flood Measured and the Flood Sent



896 million

people — nearly eleven percent of the world's population in 2020 — live in the low-lying coastal zone, a number projected to exceed a billion by mid-century.

Sea-level rise as assessed in the IPCC's Sixth Assessment Report (§7.2), set against the impossible flood of Chapter One. Horizontal scale logarithmic.

dispersed across time and space, lacking the spectacular event that commands attention, and falling hardest on the poor. Sea-level rise is slow violence *par excellence* — millimetres a year, invisible from one season to the next, registered in the salination of wells and gardens, the retreat of shorelines, the rising frequency of king-tide floods. Amitav Ghosh's *The Great Derangement* (2016) argued that the literary novel, committed to the probable and the everyday, has been structurally unable to represent such a catastrophe, and that the culture's imaginative failure before climate change is itself a kind of derangement. *Waterworld* is the inverse of the derangement Ghosh diagnosed. It is all improbability — a flood too large, a mutation too fast, a summit too high — and its excess, which critics mocked, was the price of its visibility. It made the drowning of the world imaginable by making it impossible.

The film's word for its floating cities has acquired, in the interval, an exact referent. *Atoll* is one of the very few English words borrowed from Dhivehi, the language of the Maldives, in which *atholhu* named the rings of coral islands of which that nation is composed. The Maldives, Kiribati, Tuvalu, and the Marshall Islands are nations built largely or wholly on atolls, most of their land lying within a few metres of the sea, and they are the communities for which the Panel's existential risk is not a figure of speech. The film's Atoll is an artificial ring of salvage floating on an ocean that has swallowed every coast; the real atolls are rings of coral sand on which peoples have lived for centuries and which the coming centuries may submerge. The coincidence of the name is the film's most uncanny prophecy. It called its last human polities atolls, and the polities whose existence the rising sea most directly threatens are atolls.

The difference between the film's Atoll and the real atolls is also the difference between the two political responses this dissertation has traced. The film's Atoll walls itself against the sea, hoards its soil, excludes the stranger, and falls; it is Hau'ofa's island in a far sea, isolated and condemned. The atoll nations of the Pacific have answered the rising sea in the opposite way: by federation, by advocacy in every forum of international law, by insisting that their peoples and their seas constitute their nations even as their land diminishes. They have begun, in other words, to answer in law the question the film posed in myth — whether a polity can survive the loss of its ground — and the answer they have given is the subject of the next section.

7.3

States Without Ground

The Pacific Jurisprudence of Continuity

International law has long held that a state requires a defined territory. The Montevideo Convention of 1933, quoted as this chapter's third epigraph, codified what customary law already assumed: a state is a permanent population, a defined territory, a government, and a capacity to enter into relations with other states. Whether a state exists or has disappeared, the standard textbooks say, is a question of fact, and for most of the discipline's history the corollary went without saying: no territory, no state (Verfassungsblog). Schmitt's nomos, in which order is founded on the appropriation of land, and the Montevideo criteria, in which statehood is anchored in territory, are two expressions of a single terrestrial premise. What neither anticipated was the complete submersion of a state's land beneath the sea.

That possibility is no longer hypothetical, and the states it threatens have answered it in law. In 2021 the leaders of the Pacific Islands Forum declared that their maritime zones, once established and notified under the Convention on the Law of the Sea, would continue to apply notwithstanding sea-level rise; and on 9 November 2023 they issued a Declaration on the Continuity of Statehood and the Protection of Persons, affirming that the statehood and sovereignty of the Forum's members will continue, and the rights and duties inherent in them be maintained, notwithstanding climate change-related sea-level rise (New Zealand MFAT). The Forum names the region it speaks for the Blue Pacific Continent, and the phrase deserves to be read literally. A continent, in the old geography, is the largest unit of land; the Blue Pacific Continent is a continent of water, a political geography that takes the ocean, rather than the islands scattered across it, as the substance of the collective. It is Hau'ofa's sea of islands raised to the status of a regional identity, and it is the nearest thing in contemporary law to the panthalassic world's self-description.

The declarations were followed by treaty. The Falepili Union between Australia and Tuvalu, in force since 2024, expressly recognizes Tuvalu's continuing statehood and sovereignty in the face of sea-level rise and opens a pathway for Tuvaluans to resettle in Australia; by subsequent reports, more than eighty per-

cent of Tuvalu's population applied for the new visas (Verfassungsblog). The United Nations Development Programme projects that ninety-five percent of Tuvalu's land could be flooded by 2100. Tuvalu has meanwhile explored a digital replica of its islands and a blockchain-based identity system to connect a dispersed citizenry — the outline of a state that might persist as a people, a sea, a memory, and a network after its land is gone (Verfassungsblog). Commentators have compared the prospect to the Sovereign Order of Malta, which lost its island in 1798 and has nonetheless retained, for more than two centuries, an international legal personality, diplomatic missions, and the capacity to make treaties.

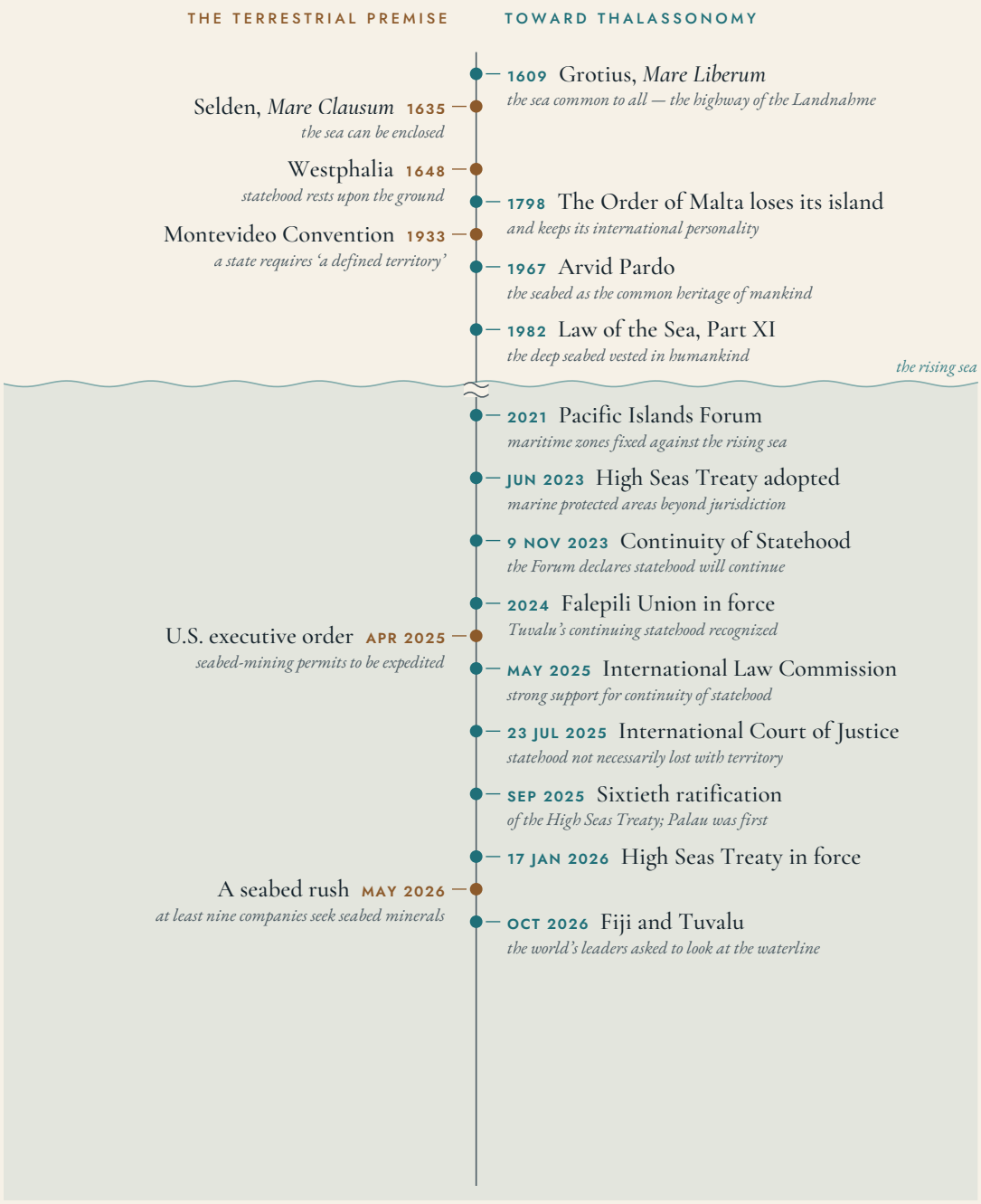
The question reached the International Court of Justice in its Advisory Opinion on the Obligations of States in respect of Climate Change, delivered on 23 July 2025. In a single paragraph the Court recorded the argument of small island states that a strong presumption of continued statehood should apply even upon the complete loss of a state's territory and the displacement of its population, and stated its own view: once a state is established, the disappearance of one of its constituent elements would not necessarily entail the loss of its statehood (para. 363). The International Law Commission's study group, in its final report of May 2025, had found strong support among states for the continuity of statehood and sovereignty, and grounded it in legal stability, territorial integrity, permanent sovereignty over natural resources, self-determination, and equity (Verfassungsblog). The Court's formulation was cautious — Judge Tomka called it Delphic, and insisted in his declaration that statehood remains all but inseparable from land and people — but its direction is unmistakable. The world's highest court has entertained, in principle, the existence of a state without ground.

These developments are not a footnote to the present; they are its agenda. In October 2026 the preparatory meeting for the thirty-first Conference of the Parties to the climate convention was held in Nadi, Fiji, alongside a leaders' event in Tuvalu convened to show the world what the rising sea is doing to the island nation, ahead of the conference in Antalya in November 2026 at which Australia presides over the negotiations (Australian Prime Minister). The atoll nation whose existence the sea most directly threatens became, for two days, the stage on which the world's leaders were asked to look at the waterline.

Read against this dissertation's argument, the Pacific jurisprudence of continuity is a real answer to the question *Waterworld* posed in myth, and it is the opposite of the answers the film's Atoll and Smokers gave. It does not hoard the residue of the land, as the Atoll hoards soil; it does not dream of a new land to conquer, as the Smokers dream of Dryland. It asserts instead that a people and its sea can con-

FIGURE 12

States Without Ground



Law and the sea, from *Mare Liberum* to the Blue Pacific Continent (§7.3–7.4).

stitute a polity without the ground on which the Montevideo criteria and Schmitt's nomos alike were built — that sovereignty can be anchored in water, in kinship, and in law itself. By fixing their maritime zones against a retreating baseline, the Pacific states have made the sea the stable element and the land the variable one. This is, in the most literal sense, an inversion of the terrestrial premise of international order, and it is the empirical counterpart of the counter-Ararat: a refusal to let the order of the world be decided by whoever holds the land.

7.4

Thalassonomy

Elements of a Law That Does Not Presuppose the Land

This dissertation has reserved for its conclusion a name for the law the film imagines and the Pacific has begun to write. *Thalassonomy* — from *thalassa*, the sea, and *nomos* — designates a law of the sea in the strong sense: not the law of the sea as currently codified, which derives maritime entitlements from coastlines and treats the ocean as an appendage of the land, but a law that does not presuppose the land at all and takes the sea rather than the earth as its ground of order. Schmitt held that the sea has no character, that no lines can be engraved upon it, and that no nomos can therefore arise from it. Thalassonomy names the order that arises when that impossibility is turned into a principle: an order founded not on appropriation but on passage, not on enclosure but on relation, not on the division of a surface but on the sharing of a medium.

Its genealogy begins, ambiguously, with Grotius. *Mare Liberum* (1609), quoted as this chapter's second epigraph, argued that the sea is common to all because it is too immense to be possessed and suited to the uses of all, whether for navigation or for fishing. But Grotius wrote as an advocate for the Dutch East India Company, whose seizure of a Portuguese carrack in the Strait of Singapore his argument was meant to justify, and the freedom of the seas he theorized became in practice the freedom of the strongest navies to range over every ocean and appropriate the lands at its edges. The free sea of early-modern international law was the highway of the *Landnahme* Schmitt described. Thalassonomy cannot simply be Grotius's free sea; it must be a sea that is common in a stronger sense — not open to whoever can use it, but held in trust for all.

That stronger sense was articulated in 1967, when Arvid Pardo, Malta's ambassador to the United Nations, proposed that the seabed and ocean floor beyond national jurisdiction be declared the common heritage of mankind: not open to national appropriation, administered by an international authority, reserved for peaceful purposes, and exploited, if at all, for the benefit of humanity as a whole, with particular regard for the needs of poorer nations. The principle was written into Part XI of the 1982 Convention on the Law of the Sea, which vests the mineral resources of the deep seabed in humankind and entrusts their administration to the International Seabed Authority. Under that mandate the Authority has granted exploration rights to some two dozen contractors but has not permitted commercial mining, and its members remain divided over the code that would govern it (AP via Alaska Public Media). The common heritage of mankind is the most radical non-proprietary concept in international law: a legal status for part of the earth's surface that forbids its appropriation by any state. It is thalassonomy's first codified principle.

The second is the Agreement on Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction, adopted in June 2023 after nearly two decades of negotiation and in force since 17 January 2026, having reached its sixtieth ratification in September 2025; the first state to ratify it was Palau (IISD SDG Knowledge Hub). The High Seas Treaty, as it is known, provides for marine protected areas beyond national jurisdiction, requires environmental impact assessments for activities on the high seas, and establishes the fair and equitable sharing of benefits from marine genetic resources. It extends to the living ocean the logic Pardo extended to the seabed: the high seas, nearly two-thirds of the ocean, cease to be merely the space no one owns and become a space everyone is obliged to protect. That a Pacific island nation was first to ratify is fitting. The polities most threatened by the rising sea are those that have done most to make the sea a commons in law.

Thalassonomy has its antagonists, and they are the Smokers' heirs. In April 2025 the President of the United States issued an executive order directing federal agencies to expedite permits for mining the deep seabed, including in international waters, under a statute of 1980 that predates the Convention; by May 2026 at least nine companies were in talks with the government for access to seabed minerals, and the federal regulator had revised its rules so that exploration and commercial recovery could be sought in a single application (AP via Alaska Public Media). The prize is the polymetallic nodules that lie by the trillions on the abyssal plain between Hawai'i and Mexico. Among the companies seeking access is a firm that began as a hunter of sunken treasure — the Mariner's salvage economy, which

brought up soil and artifacts from the drowned cities, reborn as an extractive industry on the floor of the real ocean. The unilateral licensing of the deep seabed is a *Landnahme* of the sea floor: an attempt to engrave the one surface of the ocean that does bear lines, and to divide and appropriate what the common heritage principle holds in trust. American Samoa and Guam have banned deep-sea mining in their own waters (AP via Alaska Public Media); the conflict between the islands and the miners is the conflict between the Atoll's successors and the Smokers', and between both and the Mariner's.

From the film, the Pacific, and the law, the elements of thalassonomy can now be stated. The first is *continuity without ground*: a polity's existence depends not on its possession of land but on its people, its relations, and its seas — the principle the Pacific Islands Forum has declared and the International Court of Justice has entertained. The second is *the sea as commons*: the ocean is not a void beyond the reach of law but a shared medium held in trust, as the common heritage principle and the High Seas Treaty hold. The third is *inheritance rather than appropriation*: claims to land derive from those who lived on it and their heirs, as Enola's claim to Dryland derives from her parents' inscription, rather than from discovery or conquest. The fourth is *the refusal of sovereignty by the strongest*: the order of a recovered land is to be decided by those who will live on it, not by whoever could seize it — the counter-Ararat translated into a principle of political justice. The fifth is *the priority of passage over possession*: a law of the sea must protect movement, refuge, and connection — the mobility of Tuvaluans, the voyages of the sea of islands — before it protects title. None of these principles is a utopian invention; each has a foothold in existing practice. What *Waterworld* adds is their unification in a single image: a man in a small boat who has delivered the land and will not own it.

7.5

The Argument Restated

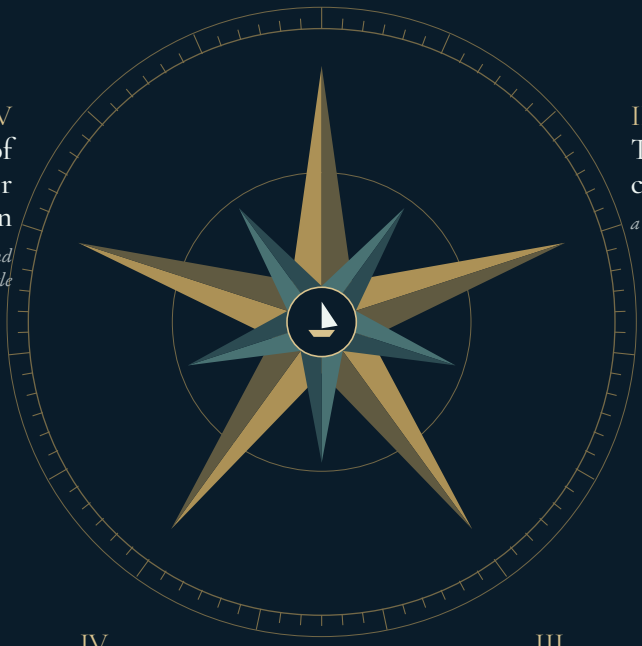
Contributions, Limits, and Future Work

This dissertation set out to read *Waterworld* not as a fiscal catastrophe or a derivative spectacle but as the most systematic cinematic articulation of the panthalassic condition: the situation in which the disappearance of land abolishes the ground of property, law, memory, and identity, and compels every surviving

FIGURE 13

The Elements of Thalassonomy

I
Continuity without ground
a polity's existence depends not on its possession of land but on its people, its relations, and its seas



II
The sea as commons
a shared medium held in trust

III
Inheritance rather than appropriation
claims to land derive from those who lived on it and their heirs

IV
The refusal of sovereignty by the strongest
the order of a recovered land is to be decided by those who will live on it

V
The priority of passage over possession
movement, refuge, and connection — before title

What Waterworld adds is their unification in a single image: a man in a small boat who has delivered the land and will not own it.

The five principles stated in §7.4.

order to relocate its foundation onto substitute surfaces. Its argument can now be stated in full. The film's hydrological impossibility signals its register: it is a diluvial myth, whose meanings lie in the archive of flood and earth-diver cosmogonies from *Atrahasis* to the *Kumulipo* (Chapter One). Within that myth the classical elements become rival regimes of value and inscription. The Atoll is the regime of earth, a compost commonwealth that has closed the metabolic rift at the price of becoming a camp, and that preserves the residue of the land without being able to find it (Chapter Two). The Smokers are the regime of fire, a church of combustion housed in the hulk of the *Exxon Valdez*, venerating the patron saint of the spill and preaching the conquest of a new land (Chapter Three). Gregor is the regime of air, a minor science of wonder whose balloon carries the film's only working knowledge; and Enola's back is the fifth surface, the skin on which, because the sea cannot be engraved, the law of the land has been written (Chapter Four). The Mariner is the regime of water, a thalassal body that needs neither map nor land, whose closed circuit is opened by a sequence of gifts that culminates in the gift of breath (Chapter Five). And the ending, in which he delivers the land and declines it, is the counter-Ararat — the refusal of the Noahic re-founding of dominion — which this dissertation has read as a thalassal ethics of non-appropriation (Chapter Six). The concepts proposed along the way — the panthalassic condition, dorsal nomos, the counter-Ararat, thalassal ethics, thalassochthony, thalassonomy — are offered as instruments for reading not only this film but the larger imagination of the sea of which it is a part.

The argument's contributions fall into four fields. To film studies it offers a method for reading the commercially troubled or critically dismissed blockbuster as an artifact of real philosophical density — a method that treats impossibility and excess as signals of register rather than as errors, and that seeks coherence in the logic of materials rather than in the intention of an auteur. To the blue humanities it offers an elemental hermeneutic that reads the sea not in isolation but in its relations with earth, fire, air, and skin, and that connects the oceanic turn in literary and cultural studies to the history of law. To political theology it offers, in dorsal nomos and the counter-Ararat, two concepts for thinking order after the loss of ground: the first describing how law survives as inscription when it can no longer be founded on appropriation, the second describing the act by which the strongest declines to found. And to law and the humanities it offers thalassonomy, a name for the emergent body of principles — continuity without ground, the sea as commons, inheritance rather than appropriation — through which the Pacific has begun to answer in international law the question the film asked in myth.

The argument has limits that should be stated plainly. Its object exists in several versions, and some details on which it relies — the naming of the Mariner as Ulysses, the identification of Dryland as Everest, Gregor's parting gift of dirt — belong to the extended version rather than the theatrical release; the dissertation has marked these dependencies, but a reading of the theatrical cut alone would be thinner in its Homeric and geographic resonances. Many of its descriptions of particular scenes rest on published scene-by-scene accounts and production histories rather than on frame-by-frame analysis, and a closer formal study — of cinematography, sound, score, and stunt work — would complement and might correct it. Its method is deliberately associative, assembling constellations of texts across traditions; such constellations illuminate structural affinities but cannot establish influence, and the dissertation has tried throughout to distinguish the authorial deposits the production record confirms (the Old Testament stories, the matter of Troy, the *Mad Max* lineage) from resonances the critic supplies. Finally, the argument is written from within the Euro-American tradition it partly criticizes, and its account of Oceanic thought, which it acknowledges as the source of the ethics it attributes to the film, is necessarily an outsider's account.

Several lines of further research suggest themselves. The novelization by Max Allan Collins, the comic *Children of Leviathan*, and the video games each extend the film's world in directions this study has only touched, and a comparative study of the franchise's media would test the elemental scheme against texts shaped by different industrial logics. A study of the film's reception outside the United States, where it earned the greater part of its gross, would complicate the American narrative of failure with which this dissertation began. A comparative project placing *Waterworld* beside Pacific cinema and literature of the rising sea — from Niki Caro's *Whale Rider* (2002) to the documentary *Anote's Ark* (2018), which follows Kiribati's former president in his campaign for his nation's future — would give the sea of islands the voice the film denies it. And a legal-humanities study of thalassonomy would trace, beyond this dissertation's scope, how the principles identified here are being argued in courts, treaties, and declarations as the waterline rises.

7.6

Coda

Shipwreck without Spectators

This dissertation began on the shore, with Lucretius's spectator watching another's shipwreck from the safety of land, and with the critics of 1995 who watched the shipwreck of *Waterworld* from the same vantage. It ends without a shore. Blumenberg's genealogy traced the slow disappearance of the spectator's ground — Pascal's wager, by which we are already embarked; Neurath's sailors, who must rebuild their ship at sea — and the three decades since the film's release have given that philosophical figure a literal referent. The shore is retreating. The low-lying coast on which nearly a billion people live is the spectator's vantage, and it is going under; the island nations that have declared their statehood continuous have declared it from shores their own grandchildren may not be able to stand on. There is no longer a place from which the sea can be watched without being shared.

The Christian scriptures end with a vision of a new heaven and a new earth in which, as this chapter's first epigraph records, there is no more sea. In the apocalyptic imagination of the West the sea was chaos, the abyss from which the beast arises, the remnant of the formless deep that creation subdued, and its abolition was the sign of the world's perfection. *Waterworld* inverts the vision. It imagines a new earth in which there is no more land, and asks whether human beings can live in it — whether, deprived of the ground their religions, laws, and economies have presupposed, they can find a way of being in the world other than appropriation. Its answer is divided among its regimes. The Atoll hoards the residue of the earth and dies of its enclosure. The Smokers burn the last of the fire in pursuit of a land to conquer and are consumed. Gregor rises above the water and reads its only map. Enola carries the land on her back to the place where she was born. And the Mariner, who can live in the sea, brings them all to the mountain and goes back to the water.

The film's last image is not a covenant, a city, or a coronation. It is a small boat on a wide sea, sailed by a man who has delivered the land and will not own it, carrying a music box that holds a child's memory of home and a bag of earth he does not need. If the image holds a lesson for an age of rising water, it is not the one the

theme park teaches, in which the hero comes back to claim the woman and the ground. It is the harder one the film itself proposes: that the deepest fidelity to the land may consist in refusing to possess it; that the law of a drowning world must be written on what remains — on bodies, on seas, on the relations between peoples — rather than on a ground that can no longer be relied upon; and that the task of those who can survive the water is not to rule those who cannot, but to carry them, and then to let them go.

Lucretius's spectator watched the shipwreck from the land. The Mariner watches the land from the sea, and sails on. We, who are already embarked, must learn from him to do both: to deliver the earth to those who will live on it, and to live, without owning it, on the water that is rising around us all.

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Keywords

Waterworld (1995) · Kevin Reynolds · Peter Rader · David Twohy · Kevin Costner · panthalassic condition · dorsal nomos · counter-Ararat · thalassal ethics · thalassochthony · thalassonomy · elemental hermeneutics · material imagination · political theology · nomos · *Landnahme* · Carl Schmitt · land and sea · smooth and striated space · Deleuze and Guattari · homo sacer · Giorgio Agamben · flood myth · deluge · earth-diver · Turtle Island · Matsya · Gun and Yu · Legend of the Suns · *Kumulipo* · *Gilgamesh* · *Atrahasis* · *Enūma Eliš* · Genesis · Ovid · Plato's *Timaeus* · pre-Socratic philosophy · Thales · Anaximander · Heraclitus · Empedocles · natural place · Dante · *Questio de aqua et terra* · Gaston Bachelard · J. G. Ballard · *The Drowned World* · Sándor Ferenczi · *Thalassa* · oceanic feeling · Neurath's boat · Kant's island of truth · Hans Blumenberg · shipwreck with spectator · Lévi-Strauss · autochthony · blue humanities · oceanic studies · Epeli Hau'ofa · wet ontologies · petroculture · petrofiction · *Exxon Valdez* · ecocriticism · climate fiction · post-apocalyptic cinema · *Mad Max* · *Rapa Nui* · Easter Island · tattoo and *tatau* · Queequeg · Kafka · cartography and the body · Annette Kolodny · the Western · *The Searchers* · *nostos* · Odysseus and Ulysses · Anthropocene · sea-level rise · deterritorialized statehood · Pacific Islands · Montevideo Convention · Mary Douglas · matter out of place · Karl Polanyi · fictitious commodities · metabolic rift · Justus von Liebig · guano age · Guano Islands Act · F. H. King · bricolage · floating cities · Verne's Propeller Island · Metabolist architecture · Kenneth Boulding · Spaceship Earth · Buckminster Fuller · Biosphere 2 · Frank Herbert's Dune · Soylent Green · W. Ross Ashby · requisite variety · Julia Kristeva · abjection · Malthus · Hobbes's Leviathan · Garrett Hardin · lifeboat ethics · Elinor Ostrom · the commons · Leviticus · René Girard · scapegoat · Jonah · Michel Foucault · biopower · the mutant in popular culture · Lovecraft's Innsmouth · Exxon Valdez oil spill · Joseph Hazelwood · Saint Joe · Bligh Reef · Alang ship-breaking · petro-theology · Walter Benjamin · capitalism as religion · Max Weber · iron cage · Georges Bataille · the accursed share · potlatch · grease feast · Marcel Mauss · Andreas Malm · fossil capital · Timothy Mitchell · carbon democracy · Reza Negarestani · Cyclonopedia · Amitav Ghosh · petromelancholia · Stephanie LeMenager · Cara Daggett · petro-masculinity · Moby-Dick · the try-works · There Will Be Blood · Futurism · F. T. Marinetti · Mad Max: Fury Road · Dennis Hopper · televangelism · the noble lie · the Grand Inquisitor · the diaconate · Locke's Second Treatise · Turner's frontier thesis · Lebensraum · The Limits to Growth · doctrine of discovery · ekpyrosis · Atwood's God's Gardeners · Gregor · aeronautics · Daedalus and Icarus · Bacon's New Atlantis · Swift's Laputa · Montgolfier brothers · Nadar · Jules Verne · The Mysterious Island · minor science · thaumazein · Landnámabók · Noah's dove · the god trick · Michel de Certeau · longitude · Polynesian wayfinding · etak · Hōkūleʻa · rongorongo · mirror-writing · Lacan's mirror

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